Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

November 2026

Contents

What is Rostas?....5
How Rostas Works — The Big Picture....6
Key Concepts....7
- Availability — Simple for Volunteers....7
- The Intelligent Matching Engine....7
- The Roster Board....8
- The Automated SMS Replacement Chain....8
- Looking After Your Volunteers....10

Who Does What....11
Where to Start....12
The Setup Wizard....13
- Step 1 — Licence....13
- Step 2 — Your Organisation....13
- Step 3 — Your Details....14
- Step 4 — SMS Test....15
- Step 5 — Done....17
- Your coordinator link....18
- Put Rostas on your desktop....18

What's Next....20
Importing your volunteers from CSV....21
Adding a volunteer manually....23
The profiles list....24
- Finding volunteers with no roles set....24

The Profile Detail Page....26
- Contact details & toggles....26
- Issuing a volunteer a new link....26
- Roles — what they do....27
- Linking roles together....28
- Frequency — how often they serve....30
- Relational rostering — serving together....31
- Next roster availability....32
- Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster....34
- Taking a Volunteer Off a Roster....34

What Volunteers See....36
- When an old link no longer applies....37

The Rostas App....38
- How volunteers install it....43
- Sending a volunteer their app link....46

The overview table....49
Digging into a role....50
Reordering roles....52
The Builds Dashboard....53
- The state button....53
- The date-chip strip....53

The New Roster Wizard....55
- Step 1 — Name & Icon....55
- Step 2 — Roles....56
- Step 3 — Season....56
- Step 4 — Volunteers....57
- Step 5 — Review....58

The Roster Wizard....59
- Finding your way around the wizard....59
- Step 1 — Confirm Dates....59
- Step 2 — Roles....60

Step 3 — Role Prefs....60
Step 4 — Availability....61
Step 5 — Build & Check....62
Checking the roster on the Board....63
Step 6 — Notify....64
The Build Menu....67
Pause / Resume roster....67
Confirming Build Dates....68
Removing a date....68
Shifting the boundary between builds....68
Adding an extra date....68
Managing Roles....71
Fill order — which role gets first pick....71
Season Length & Season Type....73
Roster cadence — how often the roster runs....73
Season type — fixed-term or perpetual....73
Volunteer frequency cap — how often a person serves....74
Resetting Roster Data....75
Deleting a Roster....76
Reading the Board....77
Legend and Frequency....77
Printing the roster....77
Taking Action on a Cell....78
Saving someone as declined....79
When the roster changes while the Board is open....80
Swapping two volunteers....80
Manual Replacement....82
Finding someone by name....82
Asking a volunteer from another roster....83
Assigning a Second Role on the Same Date....84
The SMS Replacement Chain....85
Searching for a Volunteer....87
The Settings View....88
Finding your way around....88
The two-column layout....88
Editing a setting....89
Using System Status....91
Following a warning to its fix....92
After making a change, check the card again....92
Understanding your roster's rhythm....92
Settings Categories....94
News and podcasts in the app....94
A different coordinator for one roster....96
SMS Settings in Detail....97
Reminder SMS mode — controlling reminder texts....97
Message wording....98
Template Placeholders....100
SMS Credits....101
Quick Controls....102
Advanced Settings....103
Setup Checklist....104
Troubleshooting....105
Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages....105
Volunteers aren't receiving emails....105
Roster has unfilled slots after building....105
SMS replacement chain isn't progressing....105

"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time" 105
When to contact tech support 106
Connectors 107
Choosing your volunteer database 108
Switching database 108
The sync status at the top of Settings 109
Infoodle 110
Where to find your Infoodle details 110
Connecting Infoodle 110
Which people are synced 112
Planning Center 113
Connecting Planning Center 113
Which people are synced 114
Reconnecting or disconnecting 114
Other connectors 116

Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

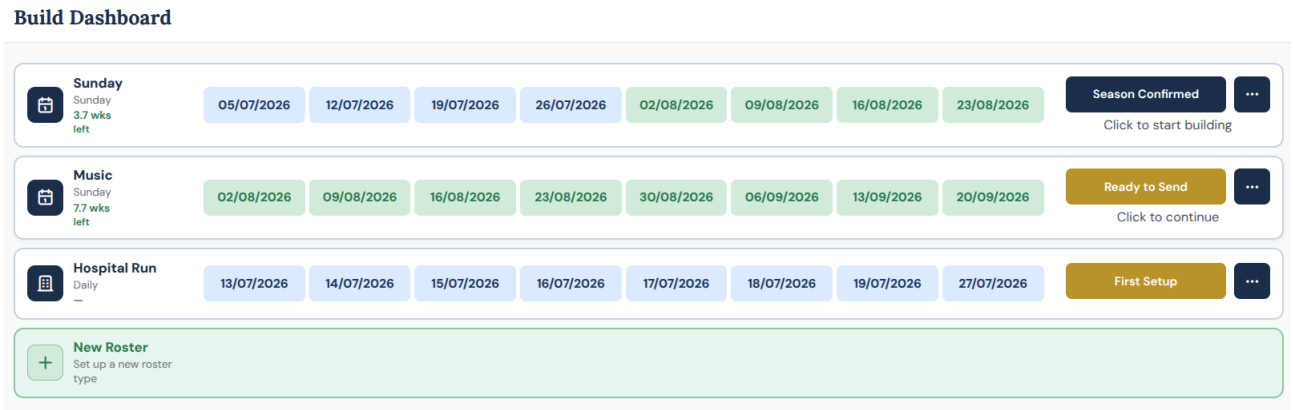
Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step Roster Wizard guides you through each stage in order:



The six-step roster lifecycle. The Roster Wizard guides you through each step — each stage is triggered by a single button.

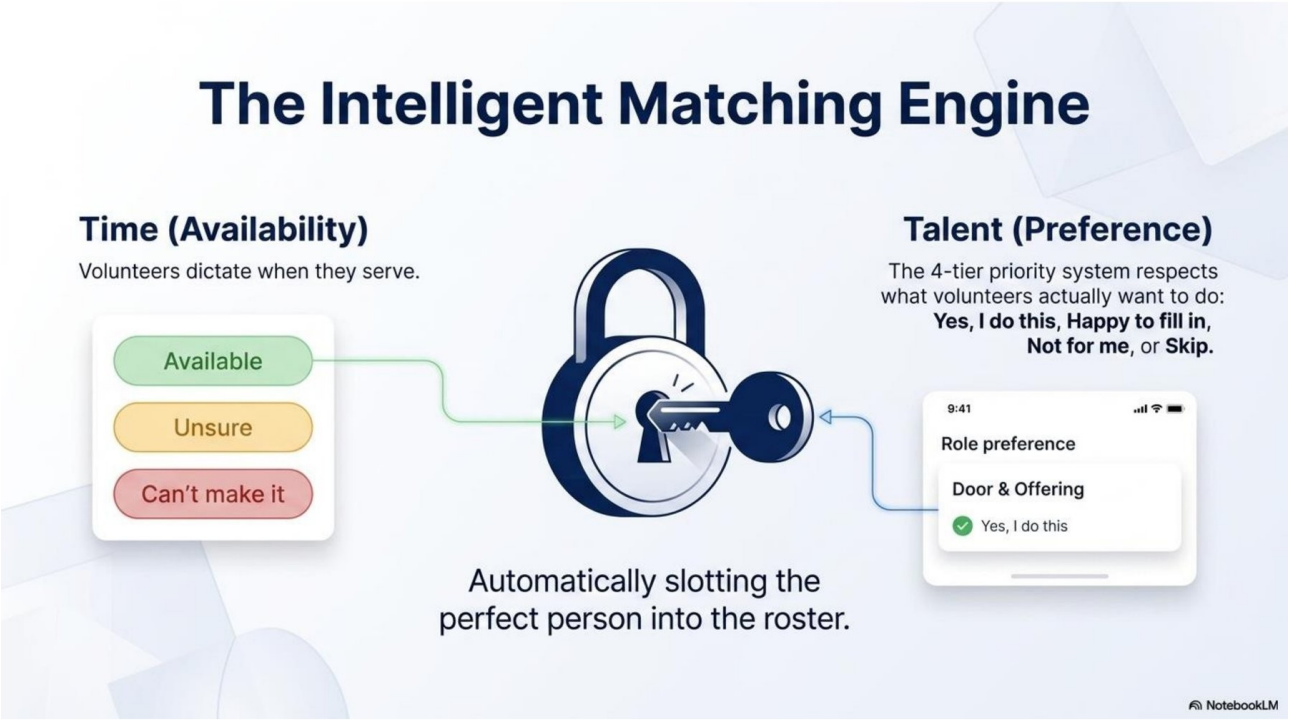


The Builds dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each roster type is a full-width row showing its current state, recent and upcoming dates, and a menu of actions. Click a row's state button to open its wizard.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas can email your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available for. Volunteers receive a personalised link and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.

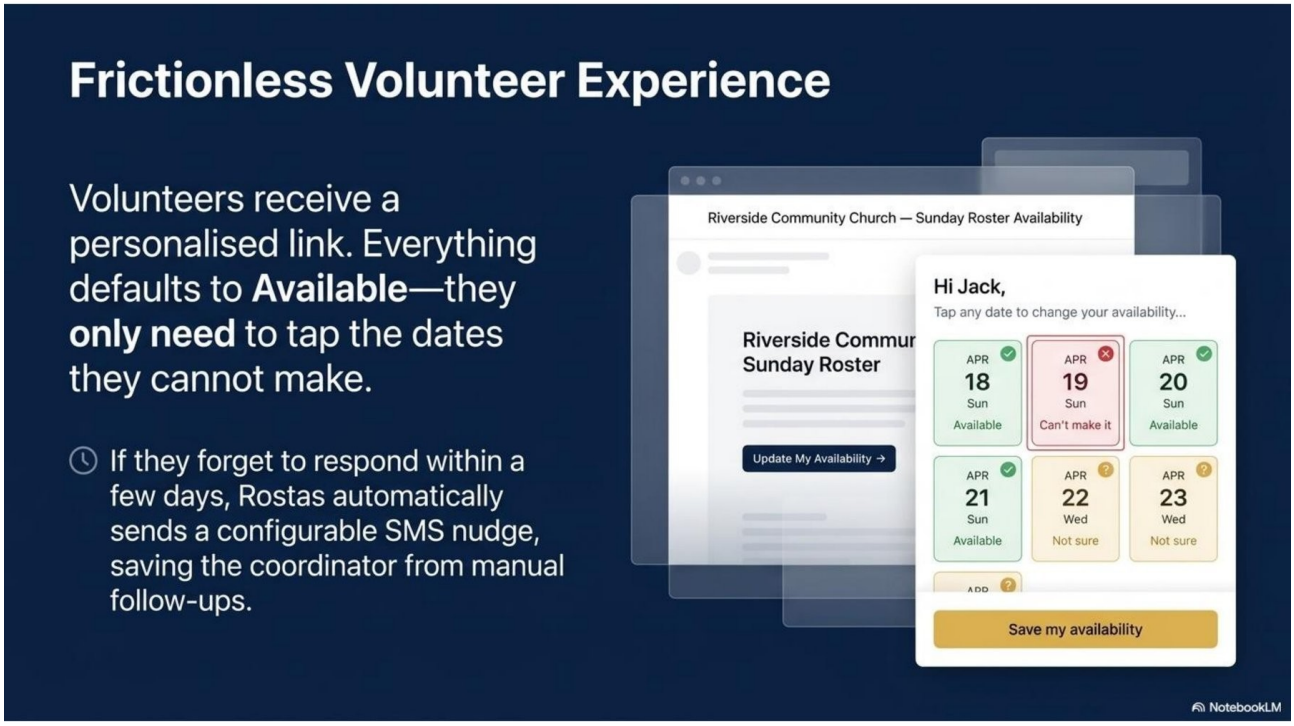


Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

> **If a volunteer doesn't respond**, Rostas can send an automatic SMS nudge after a configurable number of days. No manual chasing needed.

The Intelligent Matching Engine

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:

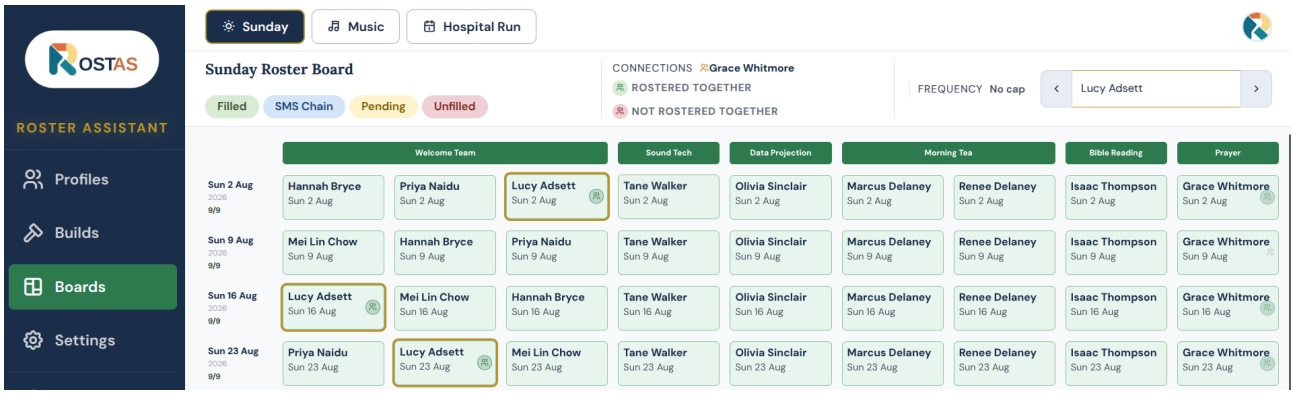


The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas picks the volunteer who has served least in recent weeks (counting all their roles), then whoever did this particular role longest ago — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

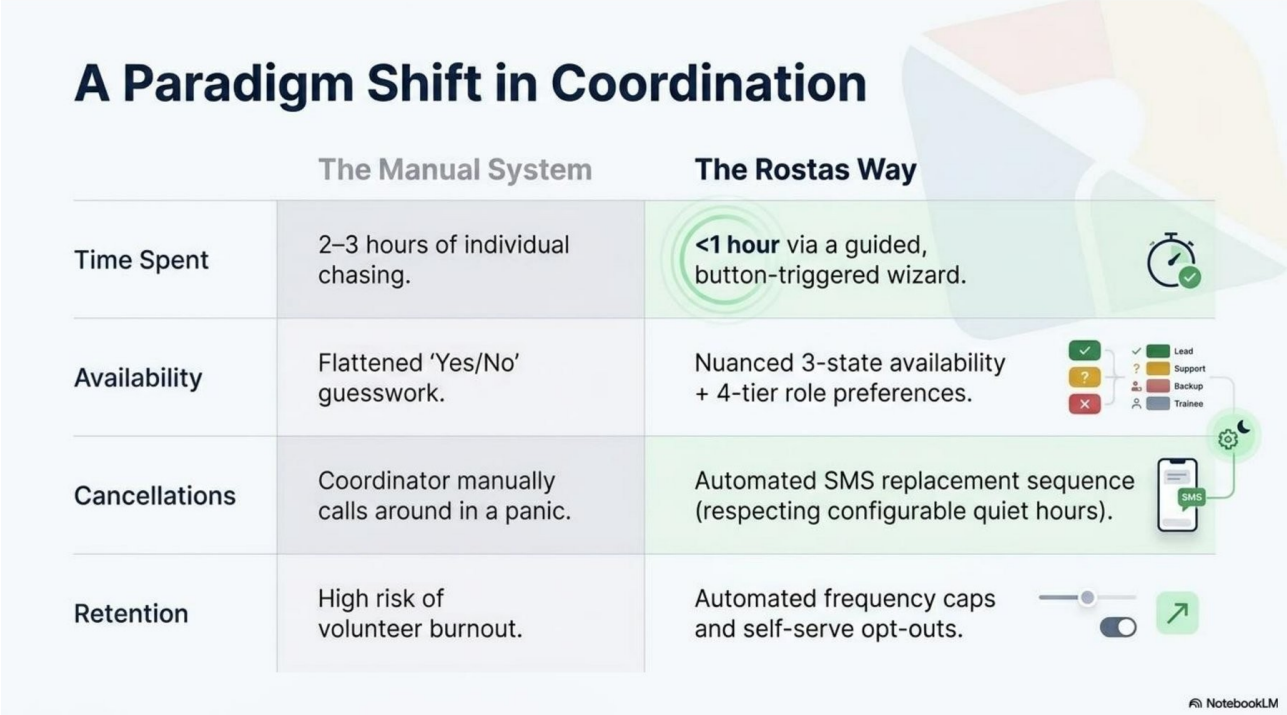
The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.



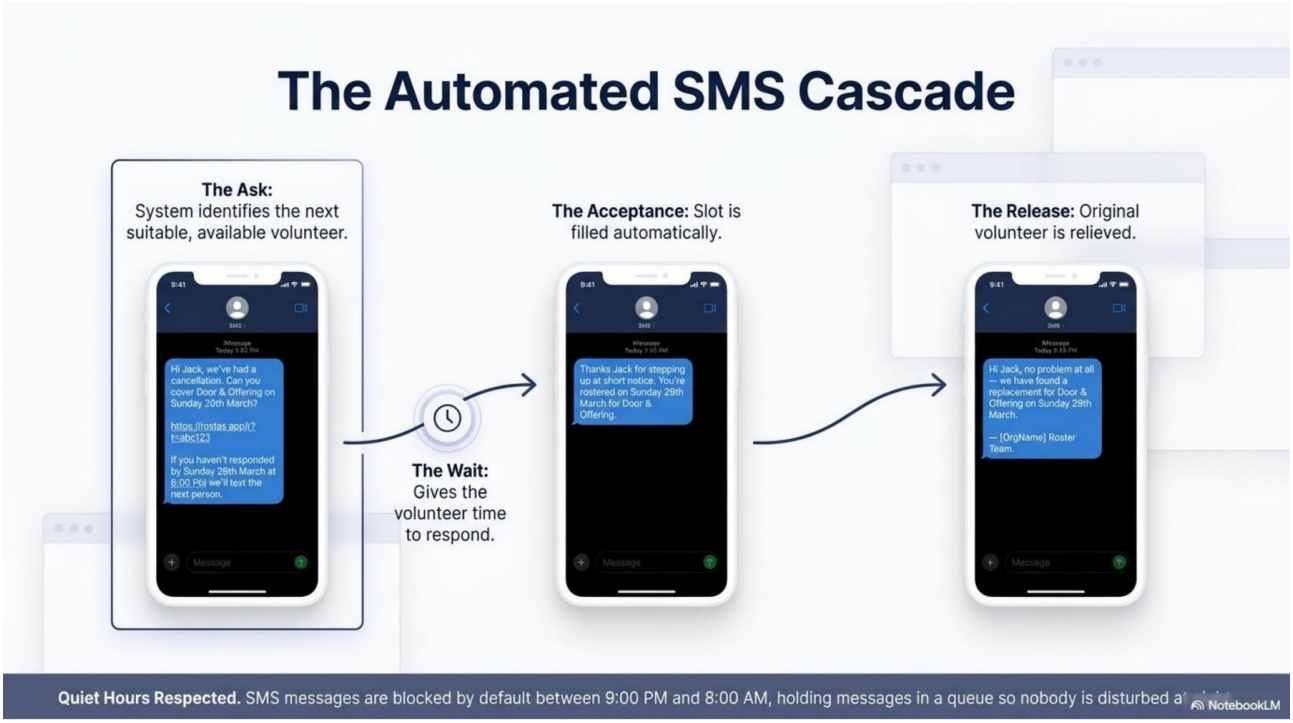
The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and take action. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

The Automated SMS Replacement Chain

When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap a link in their notification email. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.



Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.



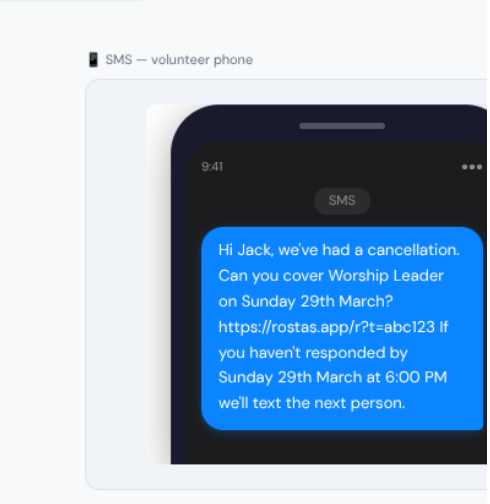
The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

Quiet hours are always respected. Rostas never sends automated SMS during your quiet hours. If the replacement chain reaches a volunteer during that window, it pauses and resumes automatically once quiet hours end. You set the start and end times in Settings → Timing & behaviour (the default is 9pm–8am).

Every reply-seeking message — the automated chain above, Manual Replacement, and a Cross-Roster Ask — decides how to reach the volunteer the same way, in this order:

> You can see and edit the wording for every tier — including the app-push text and the SMS — in Settings: text wording is under **SMS**, app-notification wording under **App**, and email wording under **Email wording**.

The Tier 2 message contains a **personalised link** straight to the volunteer's accept / decline page. There's nothing to type and no separate entry page to visit — they just tap the link in the text.



What a replacement request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a short message with a direct link to accept or decline.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

> **Rostas doesn't replace your judgement.** There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into seven parts and an appendix. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Builds dashboard on every future visit.

> **Before you start:** have your Rostas licence key ready — it's in your Rostas welcome email. If someone else at your organisation has already set Rostas up, you don't need this wizard: ask them to forward you the coordinator link (see Your coordinator link).

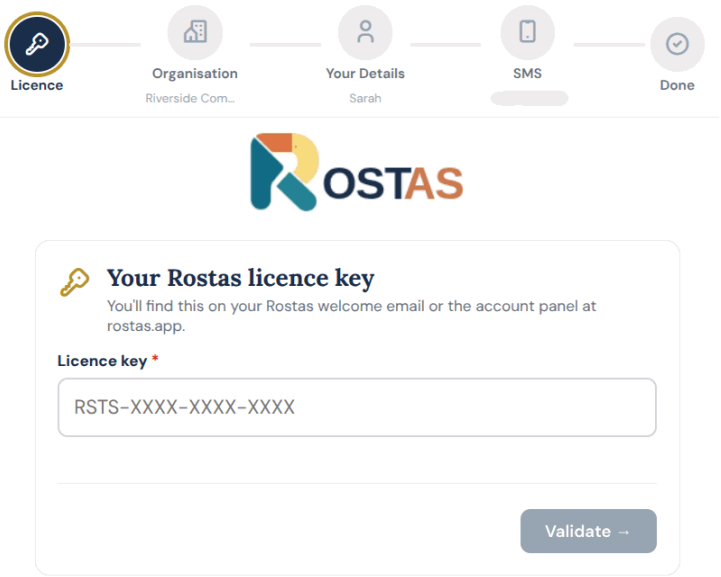
> **Signed in to more than one Google account?** If your browser is signed in to two Google accounts at once (for example your personal Gmail and the church account), the setup page won't open: you'll see **"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time"**. This is a Google limitation, not a fault in your copy. The simplest fix is to make a **Church** browser profile with only the church account in it, and do the setup there. It takes two minutes. See Put Rostas on your desktop. For a quick one-off, you can also open the setup link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac).

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has five steps — Licence, Organisation, Your Details, SMS and Done — shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Licence

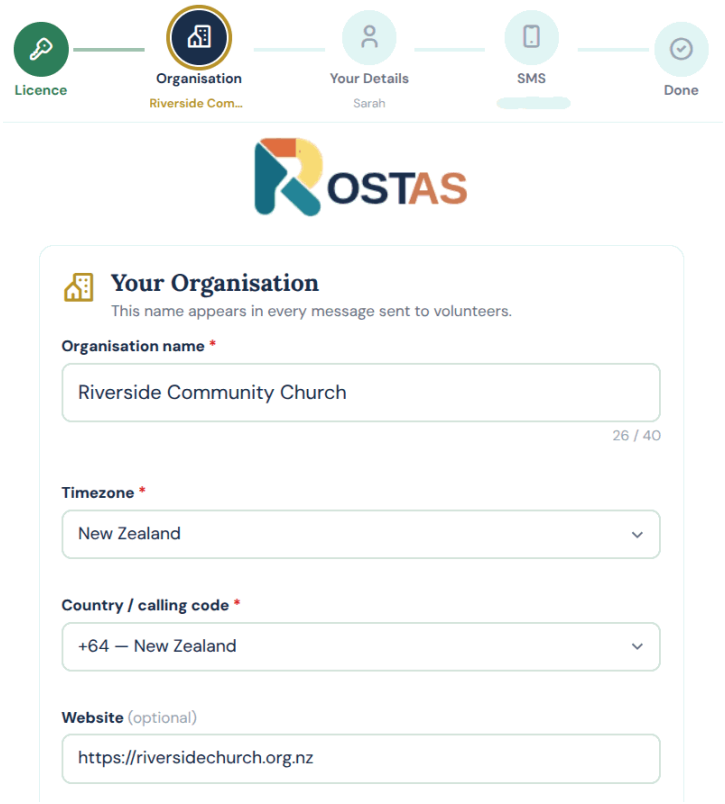
Enter the licence key from your Rostas welcome email (it looks like **RSTS-XXXX-XXXX-XXXX**; you can also find it in your account at rostas.app) and click **Validate →**. Rostas checks it and moves you on to your organisation's details. If the key isn't accepted, check it for typos, then contact support@rostas.app.



Step 1 — type or paste your licence key, then click Validate.

Step 2 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.

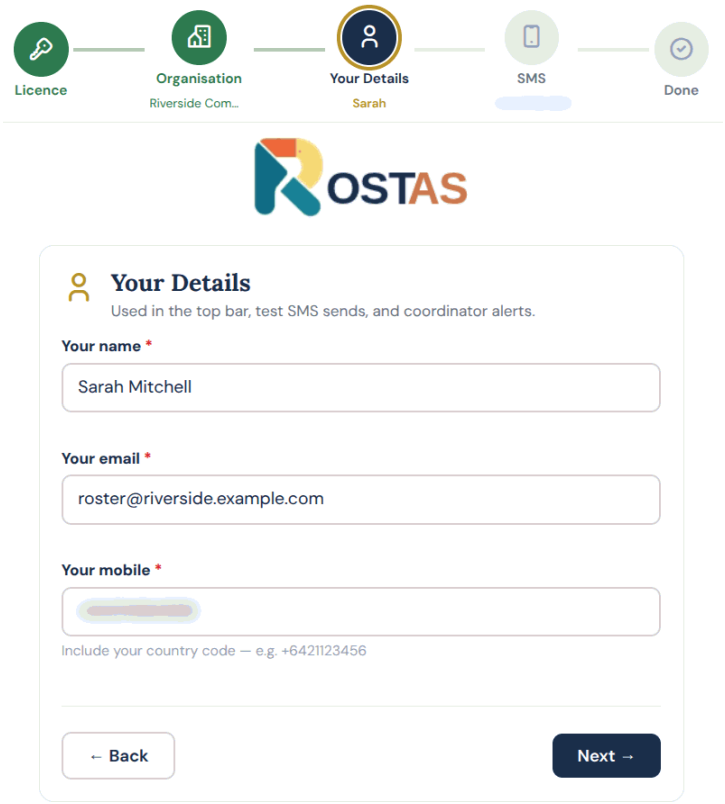


Step 2 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next →** when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 3 — Your Details

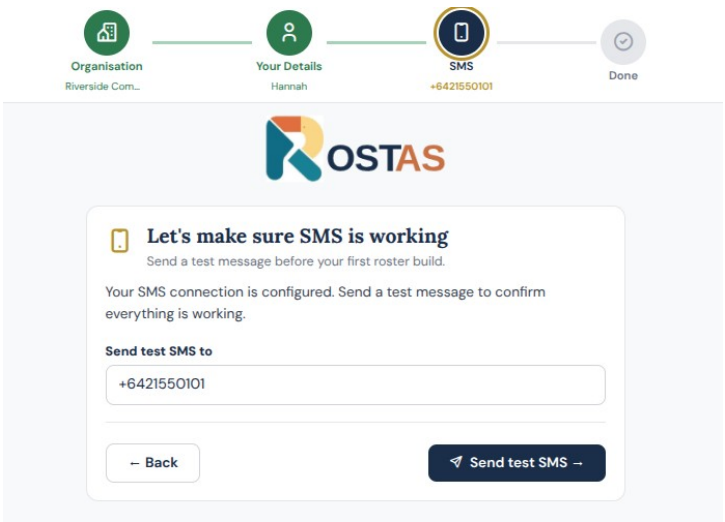
Step 3 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for the SMS test send, error alerts, and the bottom of the coordinator app sidebar.



Step 3 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Step 4 — SMS Test

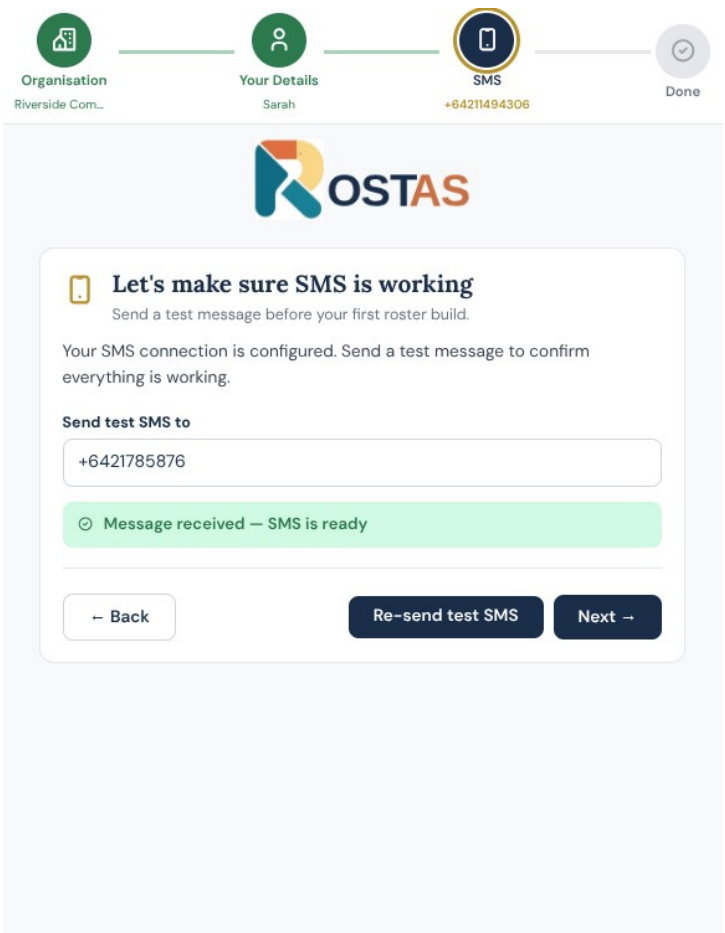
Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.



Step 4 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 4

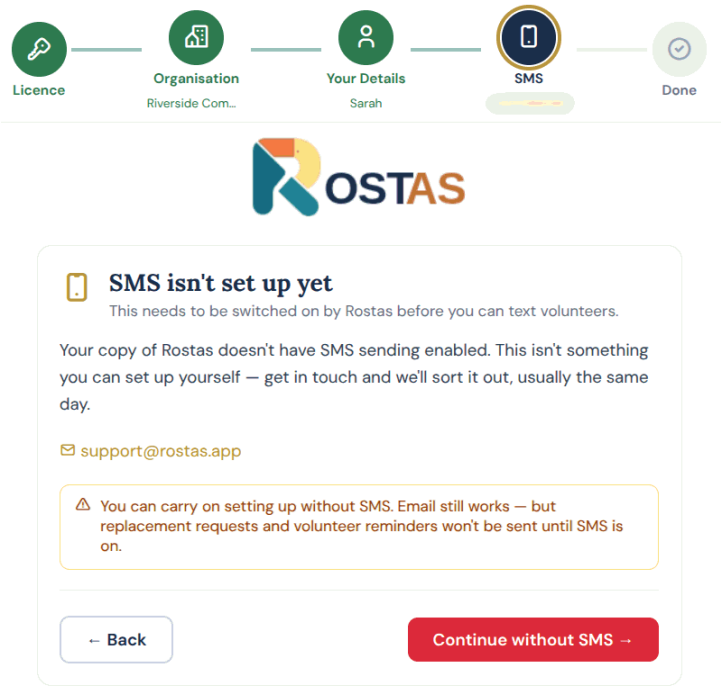
Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap **Send test SMS →** and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received, a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.



When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number is correct. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, email support@rostas.app — SMS sending is set up by Rostas, not something you configure yourself.

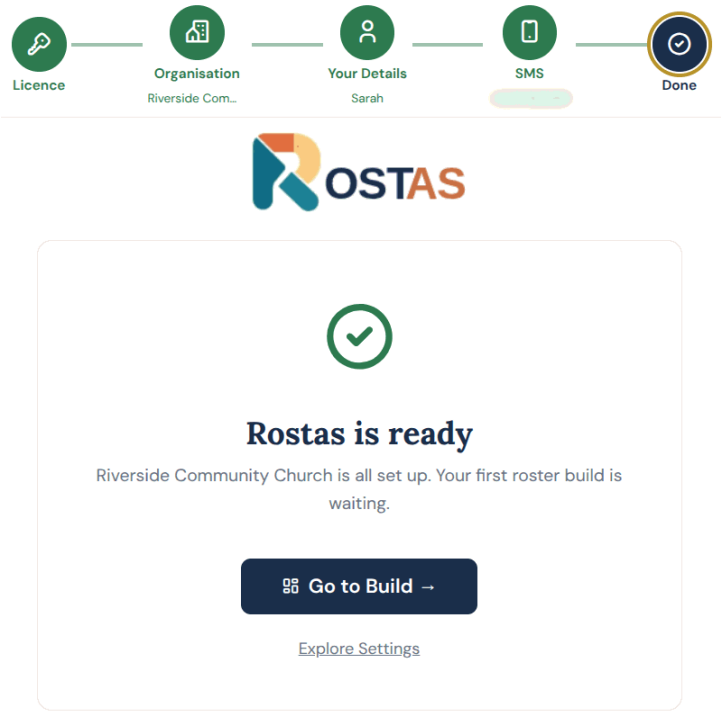
If SMS isn't set up on your copy yet, Step 4 shows a "SMS isn't set up yet" screen instead of the test send, with a link to support@rostas.app and a **Continue without SMS** button. You can finish setup and start using Rostas by email — SMS replacement requests and reminders begin working once SMS is switched on. Your first 20 SMS credits are free; after that, texts use prepaid credit packs (see SMS Credits).



If SMS isn't switched on for your copy yet, Step 4 looks like this. Email support@rostas.app, or click Continue without SMS and carry on.

Step 5 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.



"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Builds dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Builds dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before you import volunteers or do your first build.

Your coordinator link

When set-up finishes, Rostas emails you a **coordinator link** (to the Organisation email, or your own email if that's blank). This link is how you open Rostas from now on — **bookmark it** on every computer you use. It works like a password for the coordinator screens, so don't forward it to volunteers or post it anywhere.

If you open Rostas without it, you'll see a **Coordinator sign-in** box: paste your coordinator link there, or click **Email me the coordinator link** to have it sent again. A device you've signed in on remembers you, so this is usually only needed once per device.

Put Rostas on your desktop

Most coordinators use Rostas on a computer that's also signed in to their personal Google account. Google can't open Rostas when a browser has two Google accounts signed in, so the best setup is a separate **Church** profile in Chrome with only the church account in it, and a Rostas icon that always opens there. You do this once, and from then on you just click the icon.

Part 1 — Make a Church profile in Chrome

1. Open Chrome as normal.
2. Click your **profile picture** at the top right, just left of the three dots (if you have no picture, it's a small round person outline).
3. Click **Add** (some versions say **Add Chrome profile**).
4. In the new window, click **Sign in** and sign in with the **church Google account only**, the one that owns your copy of Rostas. Don't add any other accounts to this profile.
5. If Chrome asks **"Turn on sync?"**, either answer is fine.
6. Name the profile **Church** and pick a different colour, so you can tell its windows apart, then click **Done**.

Part 2 — Install Rostas as an app

7. In the **Church** window (check the name and colour at the top right), open your coordinator link and wait for Rostas to load.
8. Click the **three dots** (top right) → **Cast, save and share** → **Install page as app…**
9. Name it **Rostas** and click **Install**. Rostas opens in its own window, with the Rostas **R** as its icon.

Always open Rostas from the icon. It always opens in your Church profile, so it works even while your normal Chrome is signed in to other Google accounts, and it keeps working after a restart. If you ever click a Rostas link elsewhere and see "Sorry, unable to open the file", close that tab and use the icon

> instead.

What's Next

Rostas is set up. Next, get your volunteers in: head to **Part C — Profiles** to import or add them and set up how each one serves. Once your profiles are in, **Part E — The Roster Cycle** walks you through building your first roster.

- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- Volunteers imported or added
- Full profile set up for each volunteer in your first roster build
- SMS and Email test modes turned off, just before you send your first real roster

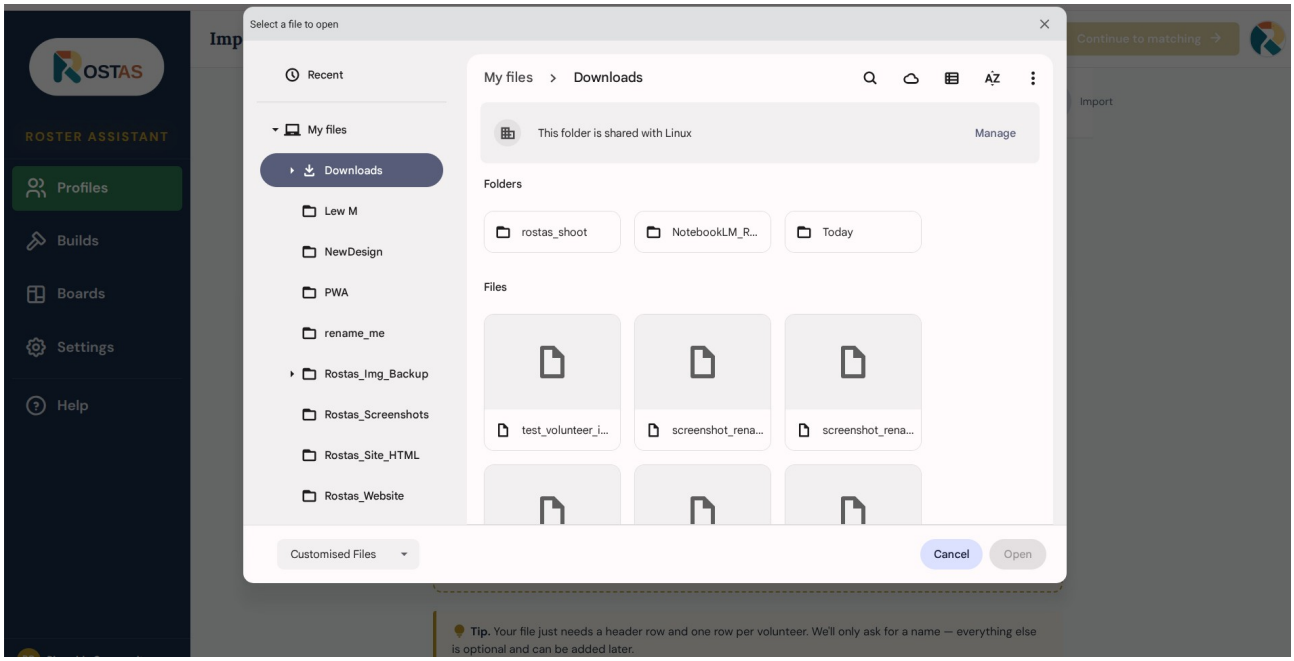
Your copy starts in test mode. A new copy of Rostas has **SMS test mode** and **Email test mode** switched on, so nothing reaches a volunteer while you set up and try things out: texts go to the coordinator's phone and emails come to you. The Status page shows an amber warning for each one while it's on. Leave them on while you import volunteers and try a build. **Turn them off just before you send your first real roster** (Step 6 — Notify): click **Turn off test mode** beside each warning on the Status page, or switch them off in Settings → Quick Controls. While a test mode is on, every volunteer's message for that channel comes to you instead.

The Profiles section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Profiles** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, view role lists, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

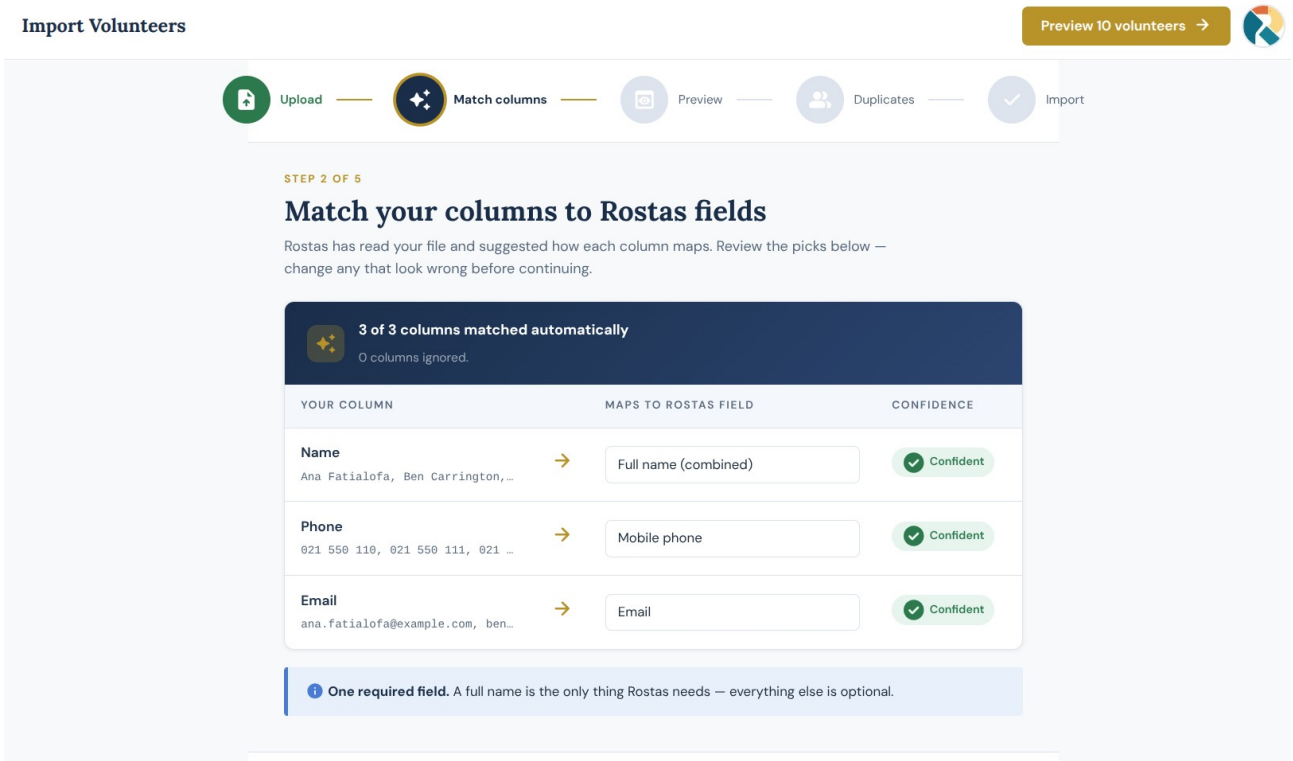
Importing your volunteers from CSV

The quickest way to get your volunteers into Rostas is to import a spreadsheet — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list. This is how most organisations start. If your volunteers already live in another system, you may be able to sync them automatically instead — see the Connector Appendix.

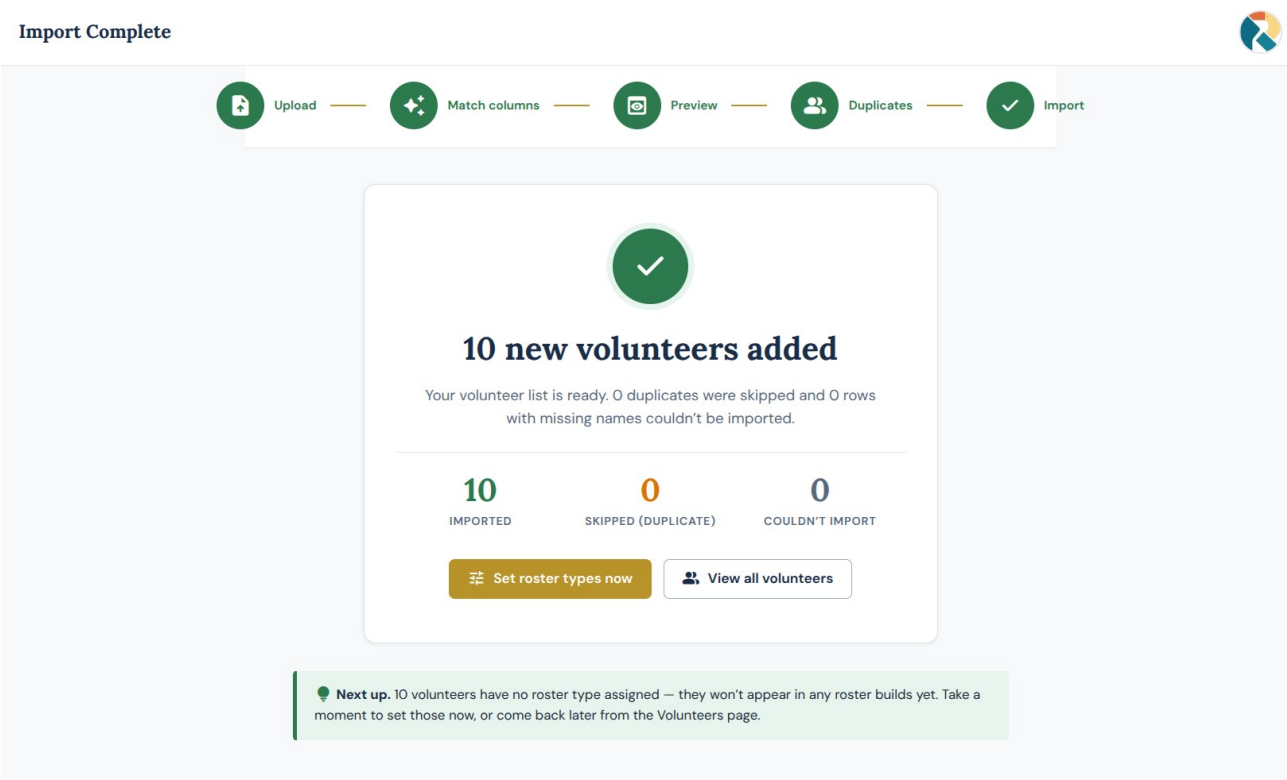
Open the **Profiles** list and click **Import Volunteer CSV** on the toolbar. The import runs in three steps.



Step 1 — choose the spreadsheet file to import.



Step 2 — Rostas matches the columns it recognises automatically; review the rest, map any it wasn't sure about, and check the preview before committing.

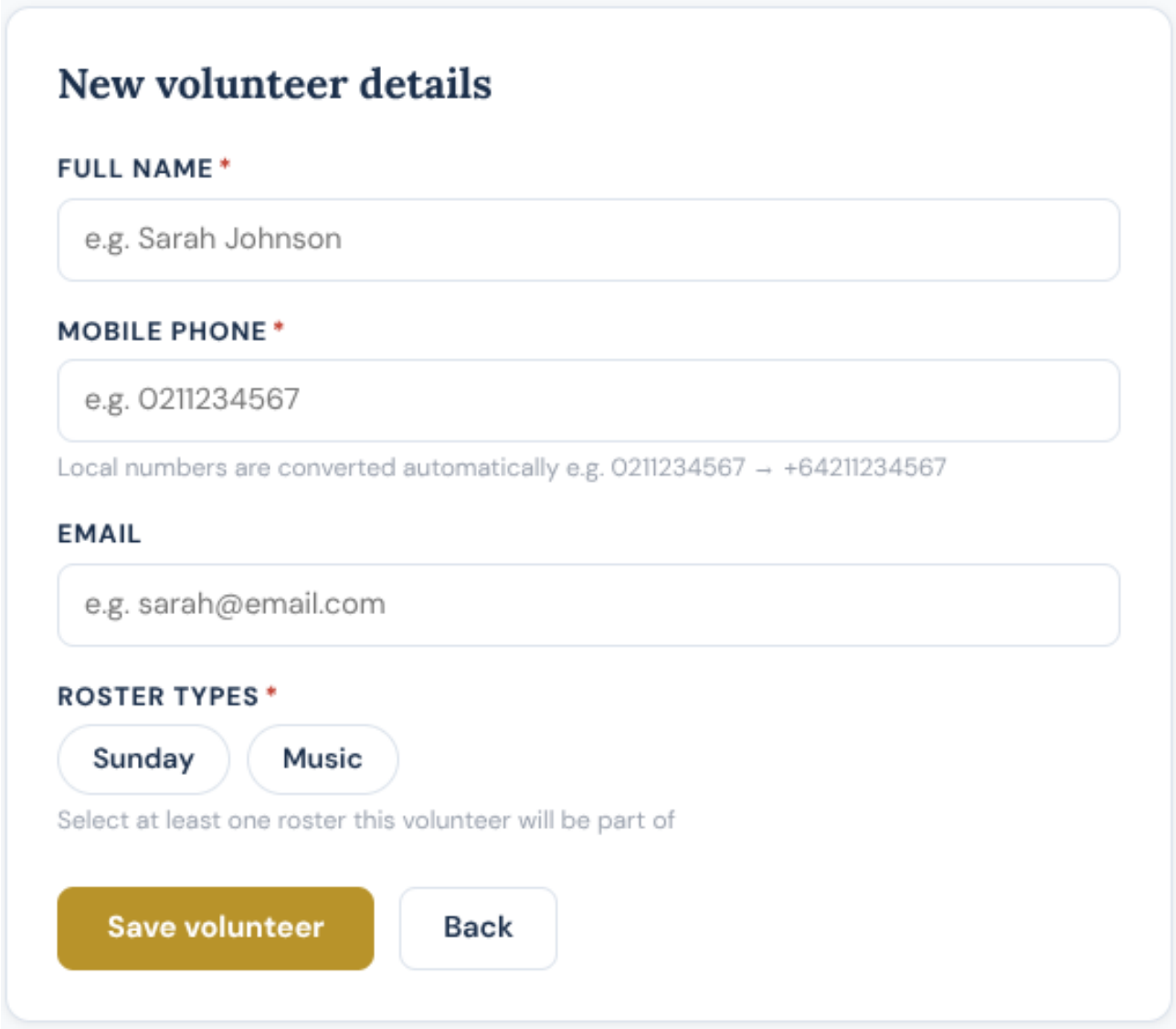


Step 3 — a confirmation of how many volunteers were imported. They appear in the Profiles list straight away.

Your CSV needs at minimum a name and a mobile number. Email is strongly recommended so volunteers can receive availability requests and notifications. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type, map it during the import and volunteers are assigned to the right rosters automatically. Phone numbers missing a country code are corrected for you.

Adding a volunteer manually

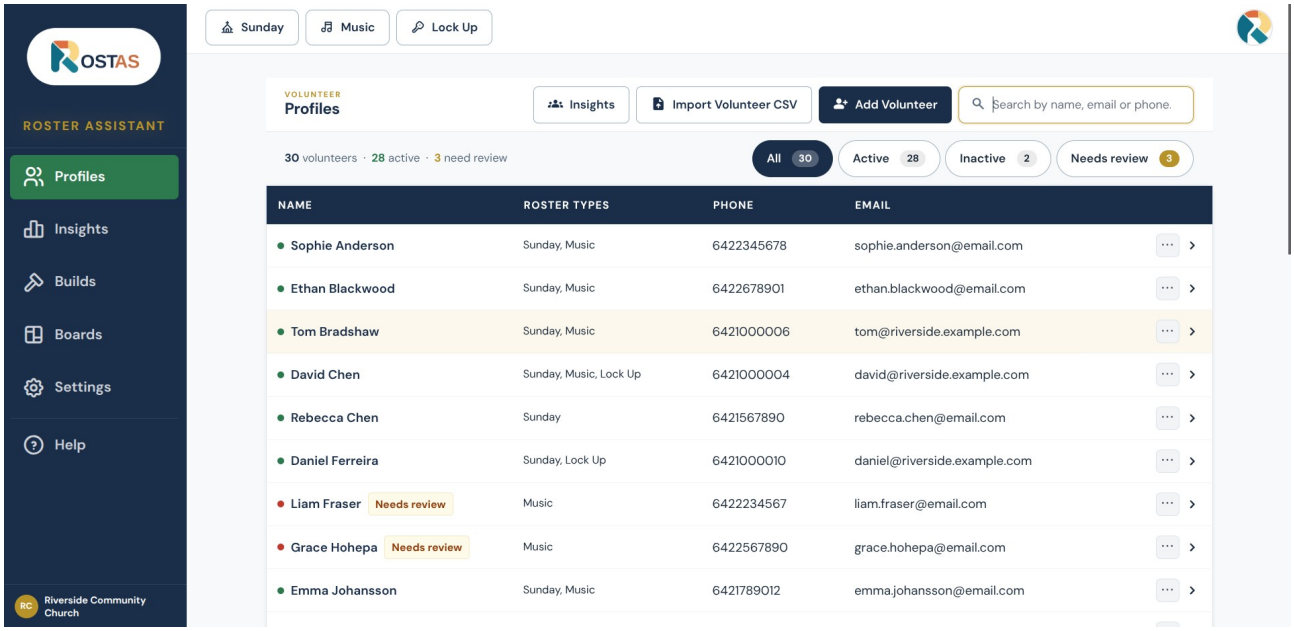
For one-offs — a single new volunteer between imports — click **Add Volunteer** on the Profiles toolbar. Fill in their details and save; they appear in the list immediately and can be included in your next build.



The Add Volunteer form — name, mobile, email, and which roster types they serve in.

The profiles list

Once your volunteers are in, the Profiles list shows everyone — name, roster types, phone, and email — in one place. Search by name, email, or phone, or filter by Roster Type at the top of the page, or Active, Inactive, or All using the chips below the search bar. Click any row to open that volunteer's profile.



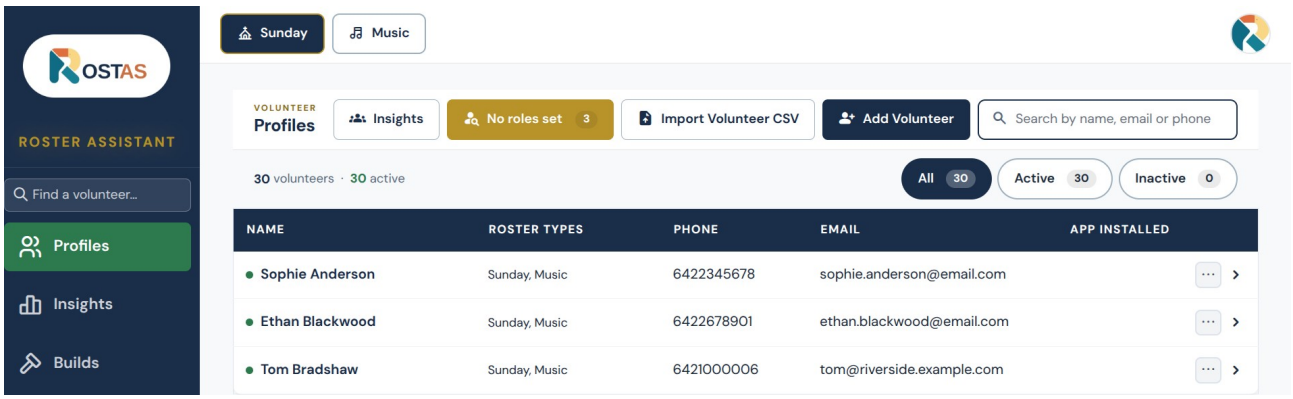
The Profiles list — everyone in one place. The toolbar holds Import Volunteer CSV and Add Volunteer; click any row to open a profile.

Click any row to open that volunteer's full profile — where you edit their details, set the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with, and view their availability.

Finding volunteers with no roles set

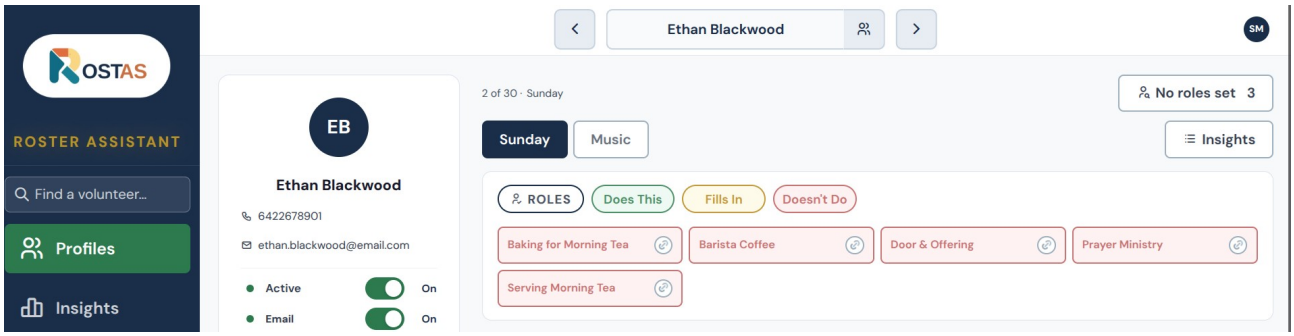
A volunteer who is ticked for a roster but hasn't been given any roles on it is left out of that roster's builds — Rostas has nothing to place them in. The **No roles set** button finds these people so you can set their roles in one sitting.

10. Pick a roster using the pills at the top of the Profiles page. The **No roles set** button next to Insights shows how many volunteers on that roster still have no roles.
11. Click the button. The list narrows to just those volunteers, and the button turns gold. Click it again to see everyone.
12. Click a name to open their profile. A bar at the top shows *No roles set*, the roster, and where you are in the list (for example "volunteer 2 of 3").
13. Choose their roles and save. Then press **Next** — the arrows now step only through the volunteers who still have no roles, and anyone you've just set up drops off the list.
14. When you're finished, click **Back to Profiles** in the bar.



The No roles set button, with the number of volunteers on the chosen roster who still have no roles.

The same button is on every volunteer's profile, on the row that shows where you are in the list. Its count is for the roster tab you're looking at, and it changes when you switch tabs. Click it to start stepping through the people with no roles from wherever you are; click it again (it's gold while you're doing this) to go back to stepping through everyone on that roster.



The No roles set button on a profile — switch the walk on or off without going back to the list.

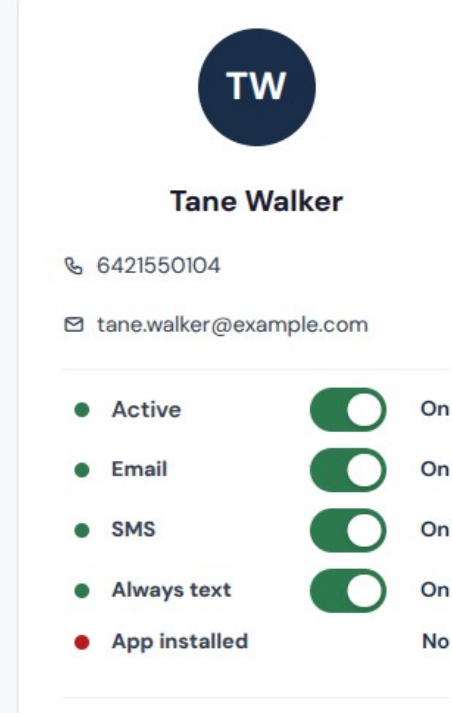
Who counts as "no roles set"? Active volunteers who are on that roster and have no role marked *Does This* or *Fills In* for it. A role set to *Doesn't Do* counts as not set. Inactive volunteers, and anyone finishing or removed from the roster, are left out of the count. Each roster is counted separately — roles on Sunday don't count towards Music.

The Profile Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their profile. This is where you manage everything about that person — their contact details, which rosters they serve in, the roles they do, how often they serve, who they serve alongside, and their availability. The left panel holds their contact details and a tab pill per roster type; the right panel holds the settings for whichever roster tab is selected, so each roster a volunteer serves in has its own independent setup.

Contact details & toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and status, with four toggles that control how Rostas treats them, plus an automatic App Installed indicator described below:

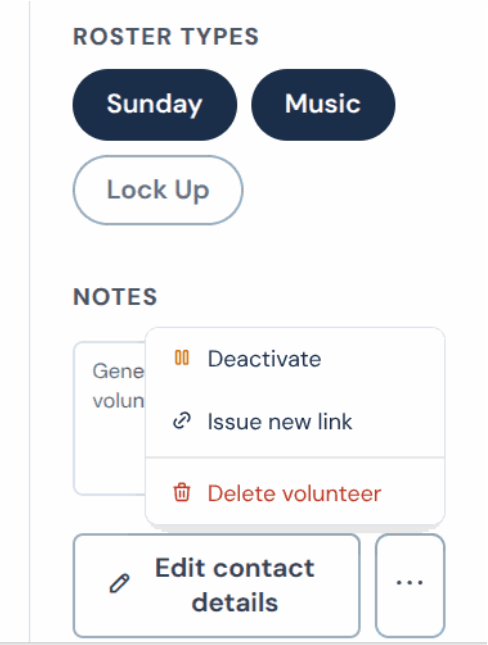


The left panel's toggles. "Always text" is the last — it opts a volunteer in to reminder texts even when they'd normally be reached by email.

> It's a handy way to spot who's worth encouraging toward the app: a red dot is your cue to mention it next time you see that volunteer, or to send them their app link straight away. Getting more volunteers onto the app pays off twice over — it makes it easier for them to check and adjust their own roster, and every reminder the app can deliver in place of a text is one less SMS your organisation pays for.

Issuing a volunteer a new link

Every volunteer's emails, texts and app carry a link that is private to them. Anyone holding that link can see their roster, reply for them and set up the app as them, so treat it like a key. If a link may have got into the wrong hands, give the volunteer a new one: open their profile, click the ⋯ button beside **Edit contact details**, and choose **Issue new link**.



The ⋯ button beside Edit contact details opens this menu. Issue new link is the middle option.

Use it when:

- A volunteer **forwarded** one of their emails or texts to someone else.
- Their phone was **lost, stolen, or sold** with the app still on it.
- They see **"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices"** when setting up the app. Each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets.

Rostas asks you to confirm first. Straight away:

- Their **old links stop working**, including links in earlier emails and texts. Anyone who opens one sees "This link has been replaced — please use the link in your latest email or text."
- The **app signs out** on every phone it was set up on, and app notifications stop until they set it up again.
- Their **next email or text carries the new link**. They set the app up again from that link, just as the first time (see How volunteers install it).

> **Let the volunteer know.** Issuing a new link doesn't send anything, so the volunteer won't have their new link until their next Rostas email or text arrives. Tell them their app has signed out and that the new link is on its way.

Roles — what they do

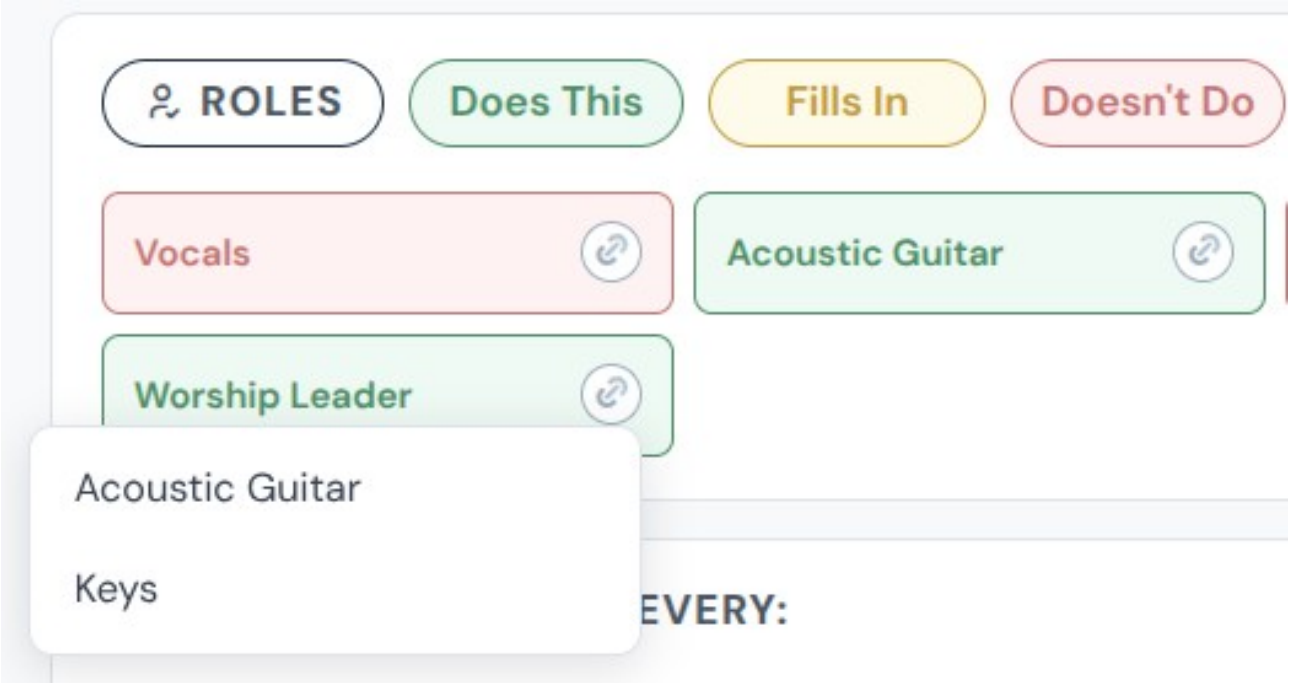
The Roles section on the right panel is where you set which roles this volunteer performs in this roster. Each role shows as **Does This**, **Fills In**, or **Doesn't Do**



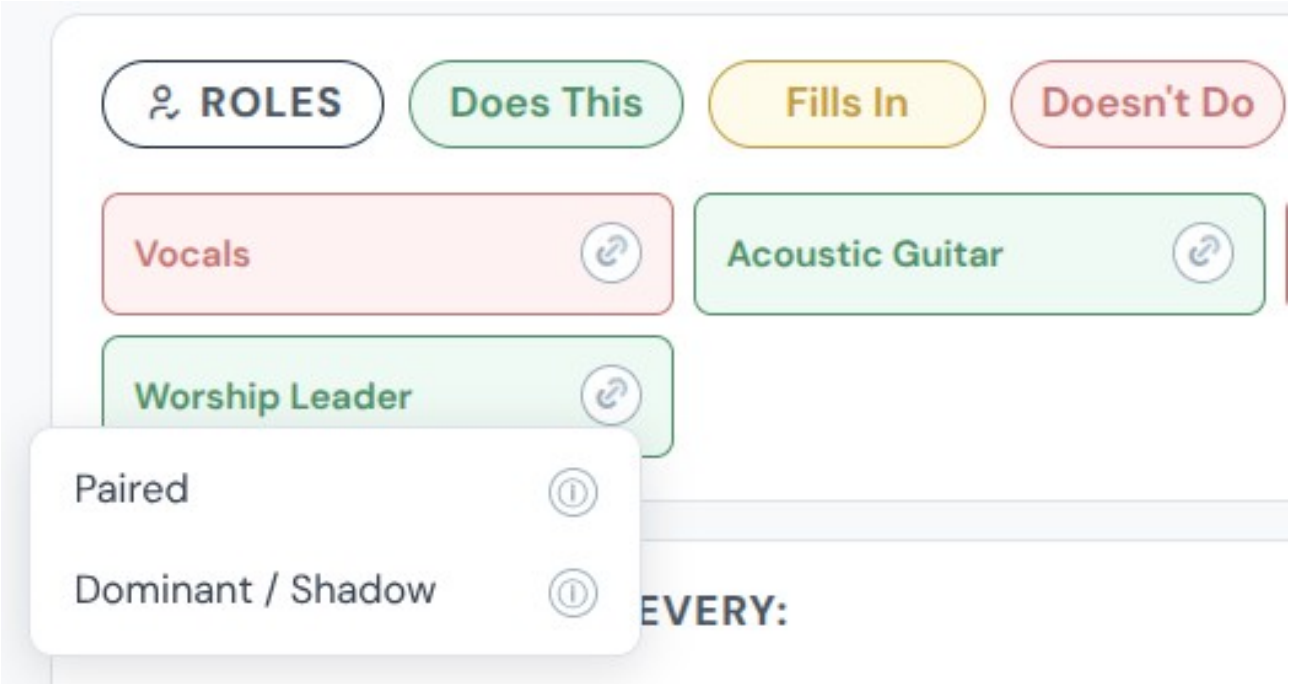
The Roles section. Set each role to Does This (a primary role they do regularly), Fills In (they'll cover it when needed), or Doesn't Do.

Linking roles together

Sometimes two roles should travel together — Say a worship leader always also plays an acoustic guitar. Role linking handles this. Both roles must be set to **Does This** first; then click the link icon (🔗) on a role card to open a dropdown of roles you can link it to, and choose the link type.



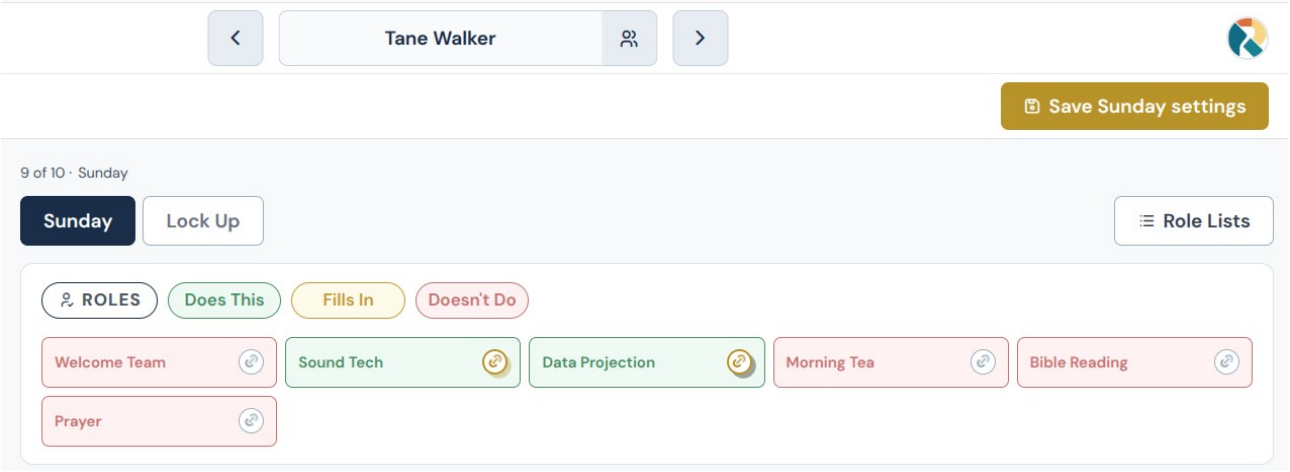
Clicking a role's link icon lists the other roles it can be linked to.



After picking a role, choose the link type — Equal Paired or Dominant—Shadow.

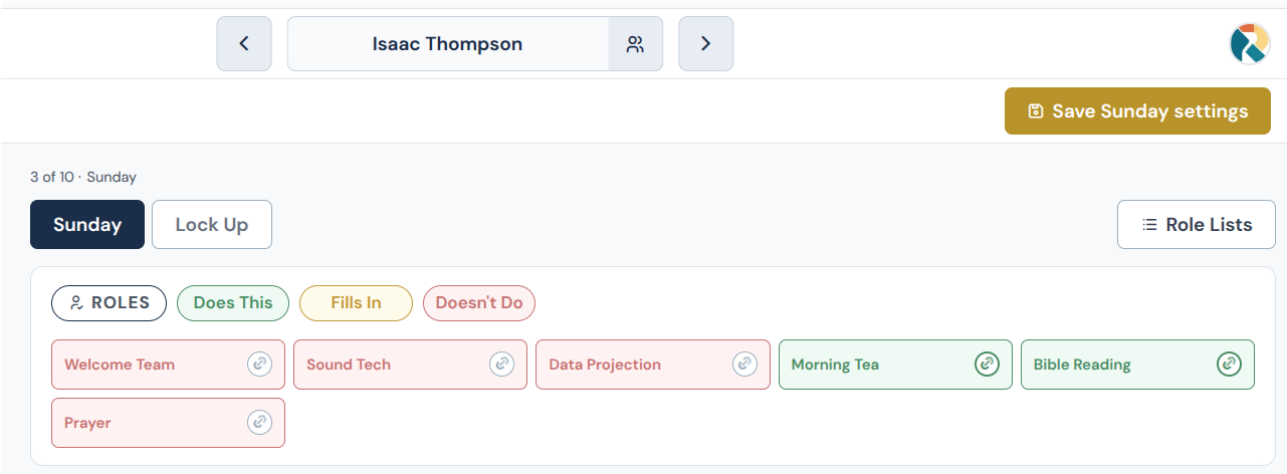
Linked roles are ringed on the profile so you can see the relationship at a glance.

A **gold drop-shadow** marks the dominant role, a **grey drop-shadow** its shadow pairing.



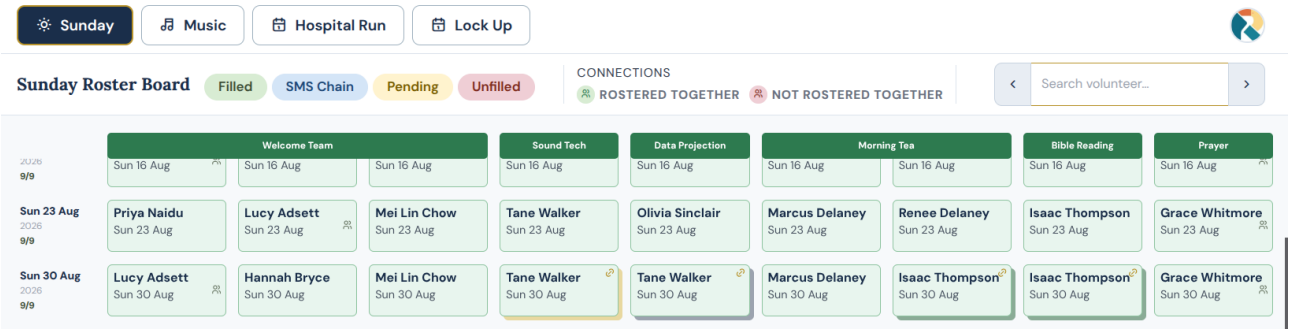
Gold drop-shadow and grey drop-shadow pairing

A highlighted g**reen circle border** marks paired roles in profile settings.



Paired roles are marked with a green border on the profile.

On the Board, the matching assignment cards carry the same colours.

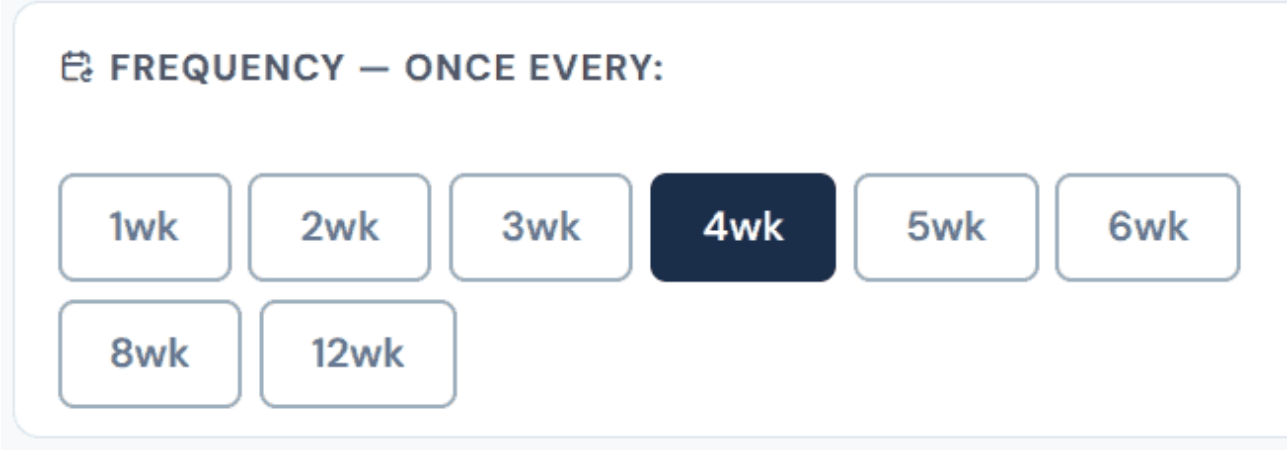


On the Board, a linked pair's cards share a colour — so a linked assignment is easy to spot.

> **To change or remove a link**, click the link icon on an already-linked role — the dropdown then shows the linked partner and an option to unlink.

Frequency — how often they serve

The Frequency control — labelled **ONCE EVERY** — caps how often this volunteer is rostered in this roster, so nobody is over-used even when they're always available. Tap a pill: once every **1wk**, **2wk**, and so on up to **12wk**. If none is set, Rostas uses once every 4 weeks.

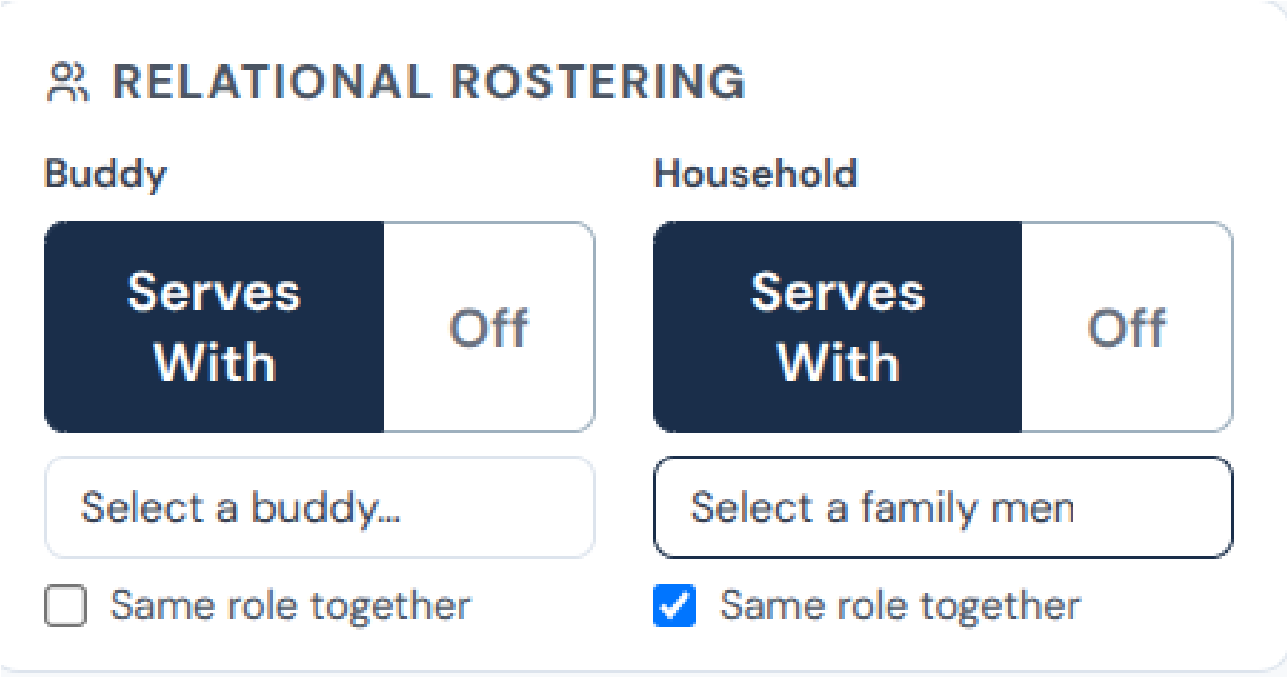


The Frequency control. "1wk" means they can be rostered every week; "4wk" means at most once every four weeks, and so on.

> **The cap counts distinct service dates, not roles.** A volunteer rostered to two roles on the same day counts as one service — so serving twice in one Sunday doesn't use up two of their allocation.

Relational rostering — serving together

Relational rostering asks Rostas to place people *together* on the same dates — a **Buddy** they like to serve alongside, or a **Household** so family members share the same rota. Turn on "Serves With" and pick who, then choose how closely they should be linked: the same date, or the same role too.



Relational rostering — Buddy and Household "Serves With" settings, each now carrying a "Same role together" checkbox. Household is ticked here, linking two family members to the identical role every time.

Who you can pick. The **Buddy** list shows everyone on this roster. The **Household** list puts the likely family first, under "Same surname or household" (the same surname, or the same household in Infoodle or Planning Center), then everyone else under "Everyone else on this roster". So a couple or blended family with different surnames can still be linked as a household.

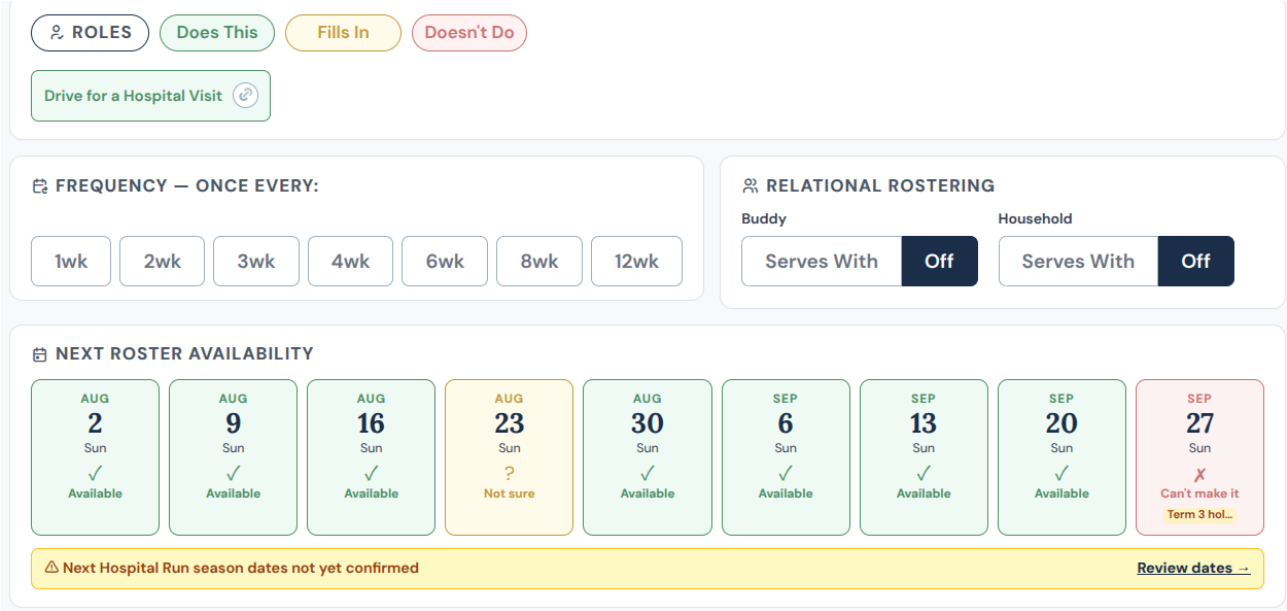
Their frequencies need to line up. Rostas can only keep a pair together when they serve equally often, or one serves a multiple of the other's frequency (say every 2 weeks and every 4 weeks: they serve together on the 4-weekly person's turns, and the other also serves alone in between). Combinations like 2 and 3 weeks, or 4 and 6, would rarely meet, so the profile won't accept them. If you pick someone like that, or change the frequency to one that doesn't fit, the choice goes back to what it was and a red message explains why, with a **Match** button that sets this person to their partner's frequency and makes the link. If one of the pair has been away, Rostas may hold the other back for a turn so they get back in step and serve together again.

Two ways to serve together. Left unticked, a Buddy or Household pair just needs to be rostered on the *same date* — any role each of them is capable of is fine. This suits people who want to travel in together or simply be there on the same Sunday. Tick **"Same role together"** when one person is mentoring or training the other — this asks Rostas to put them on the *same role*, together, every time. Because that's a tighter constraint, a same-role pair is held back more often, and only placed once a slot exists that fits them both.

Relational rostering is not the same as role linking. Role linking ties two *roles* together for the same person; relational rostering places two *people* on the same dates. One is about jobs, the other about company.

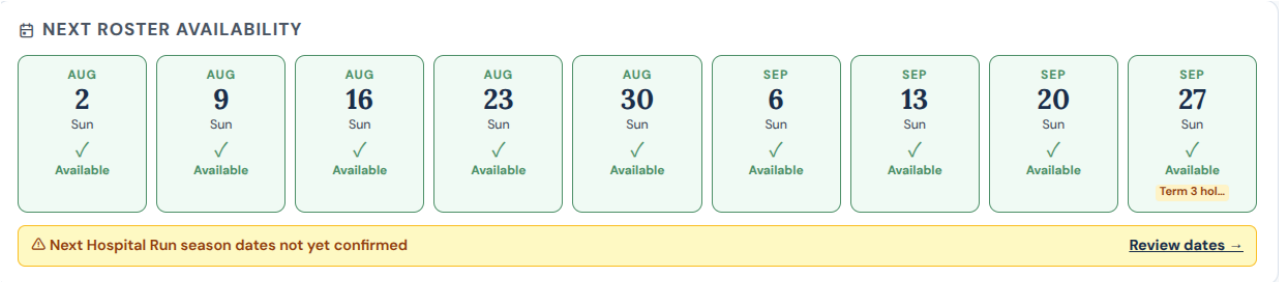
Next roster availability

The availability grid shows this volunteer's responses for the upcoming dates — the same three states they set on their own form:



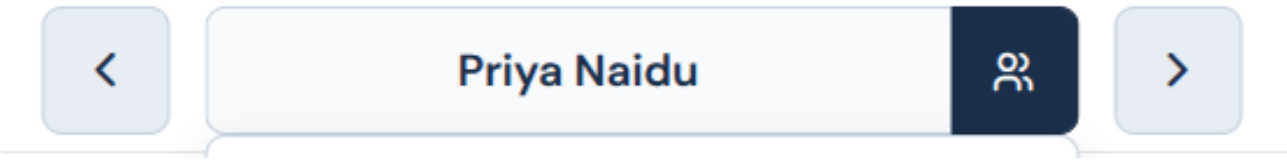
The Next Roster Availability grid. Holiday dates are tagged automatically so you can see at a glance which dates are affected.

If the season's dates aren't confirmed yet, a yellow banner appears at the bottom of this section — it's good to get season dates confirmed. Adding or deleting dates helps volunteers accurately know dates for the next roster.



The season-dates-unconfirmed banner — a reminder to confirm the season before availability can be gathered.

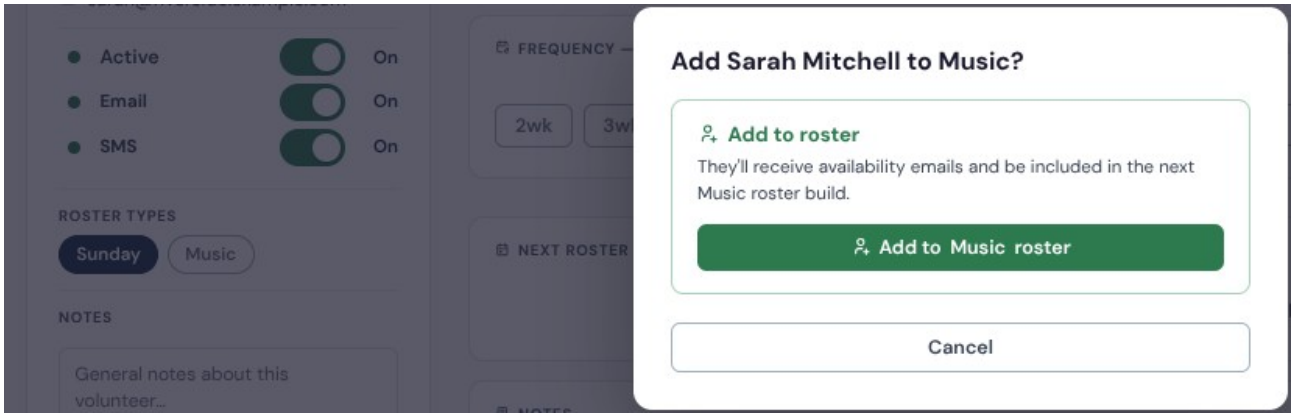
Searching across rosters. The prev/next arrows at the top of the profile step through volunteers. Next to them is a search-scope toggle (people icons) — switch it on to search across every roster rather than just the current one.



The profile top bar — step between volunteers with the arrows, and widen the search to all rosters with the scope toggle.

Adding a Volunteer to a New Roster

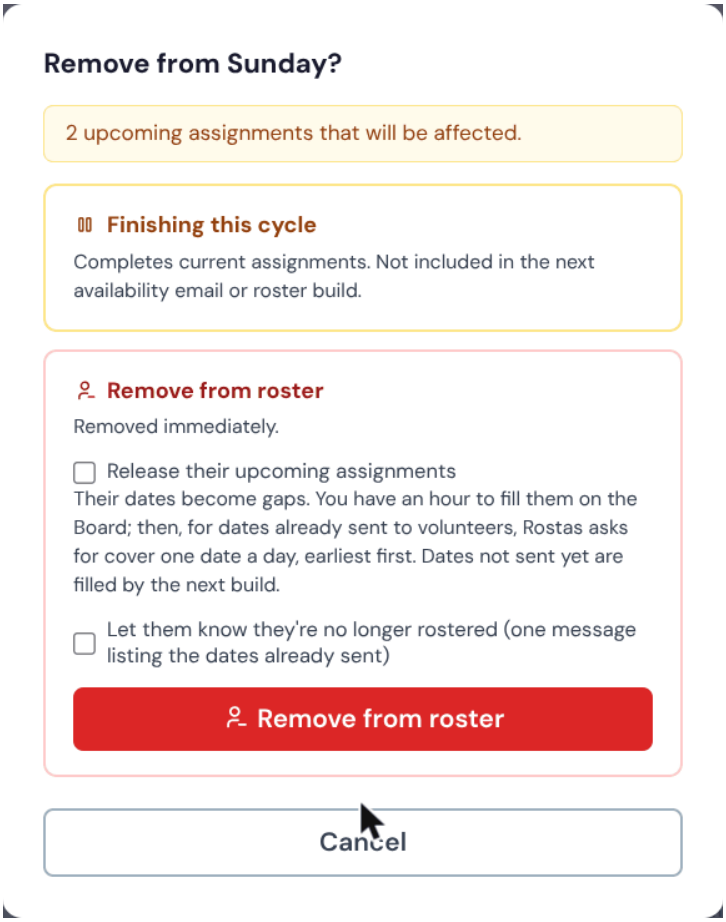
If a volunteer starts serving in an additional roster type, click the inactive roster tab on their detail page. A confirmation dialog appears — confirm to add them to that roster. Their settings for the new roster start fresh and can be configured from the right panel.



Clicking an inactive roster tab shows a confirmation before adding the volunteer. Once confirmed they appear in that roster's volunteer pool at the next build.

Taking a Volunteer Off a Roster

When someone stops serving on a roster, open their profile and click that roster's navy pill under **Roster Types** (for example *Sunday*). A box opens asking *Remove from Sunday?*. If they're on any upcoming dates, a yellow line at the top says how many.



The pop-up when you click a roster pill. Both tick boxes under Remove from roster start unticked.

Release their upcoming assignments takes them off every upcoming date on that roster (today's service is left alone; change that on the Board). Each of those cards becomes an empty gap (a red dashed *Unfilled* card) and the date's count drops, for example from 10/10 to 9/10.

Removing someone straight away is often urgent or sad, so Rostas fills their dates gently rather than sending a burst of requests:

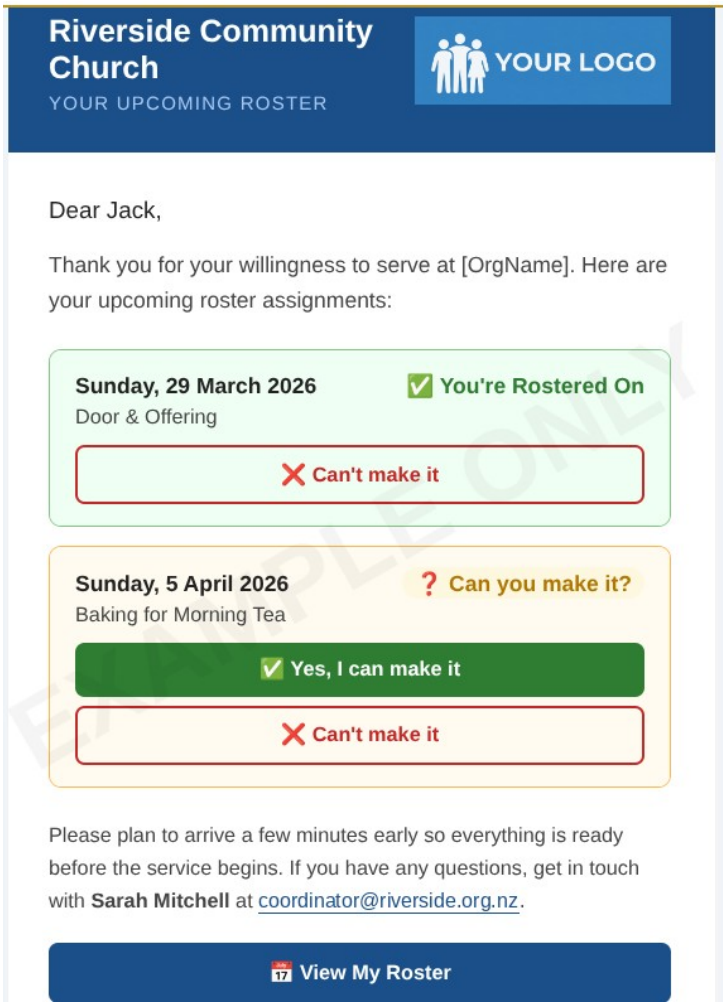
- **You have an hour** to fill any of the gaps yourself on the Board, for example with someone you've already spoken to.
- **Dates whose roster has already gone out:** after the hour, Rostas sends replacement requests for **one date a day, earliest first**, just as if the person had tapped *Can't make it*. A date you've filled meanwhile is skipped. A date coming up soon is never left until less than two days before it.
- **Dates whose roster hasn't gone out yet:** nobody is asked; the next roster build fills them, or you can fill them on the Board.
- **Roster paused:** no requests go out; the gaps wait for you.

Let them know they're no longer rostered starts unticked. Tick it to send the person one message (in the app, or by text) listing every date whose roster had already gone out, for example "you're no longer rostered for Welcomer on Sun 4 Oct, Sun 11 Oct and Sun 25 Oct". Leave it unticked when a message would be unkind or unwanted, for example if they have died, and tell them or their family yourself.

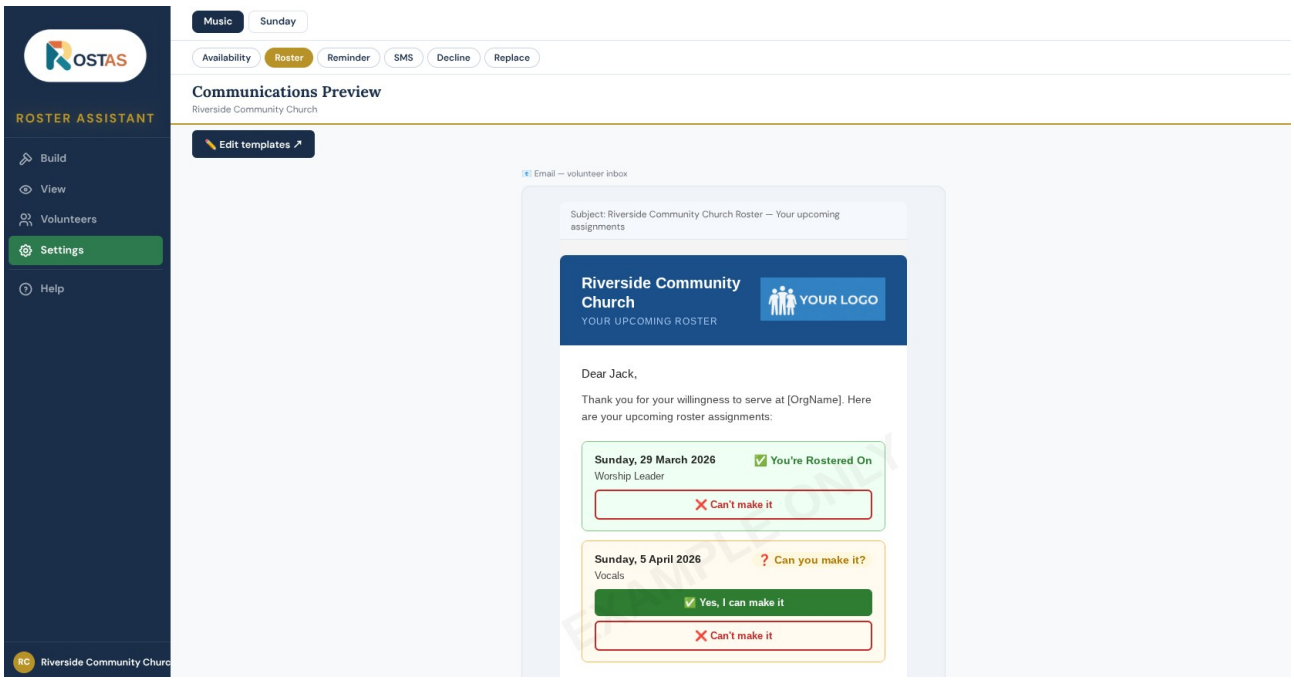
> **Changed your mind?** Click the same roster pill on their profile and choose *Add to Sunday roster* (or whichever roster it is). Dates you released aren't given back to them; put them back on a date from the Board if you need to.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas through personalised links, and — if they've installed it — the Rostas app. Installing is entirely optional: nothing is ever gated behind it, and a volunteer who never installs keeps using email and SMS links exactly as before. These are the main things volunteers are sent:



The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.



The roster notification email — every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments. The "Can't make it?" button at the bottom starts the replacement chain if tapped.

All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised. Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS, whether or not they've installed the app.

When an old link no longer applies

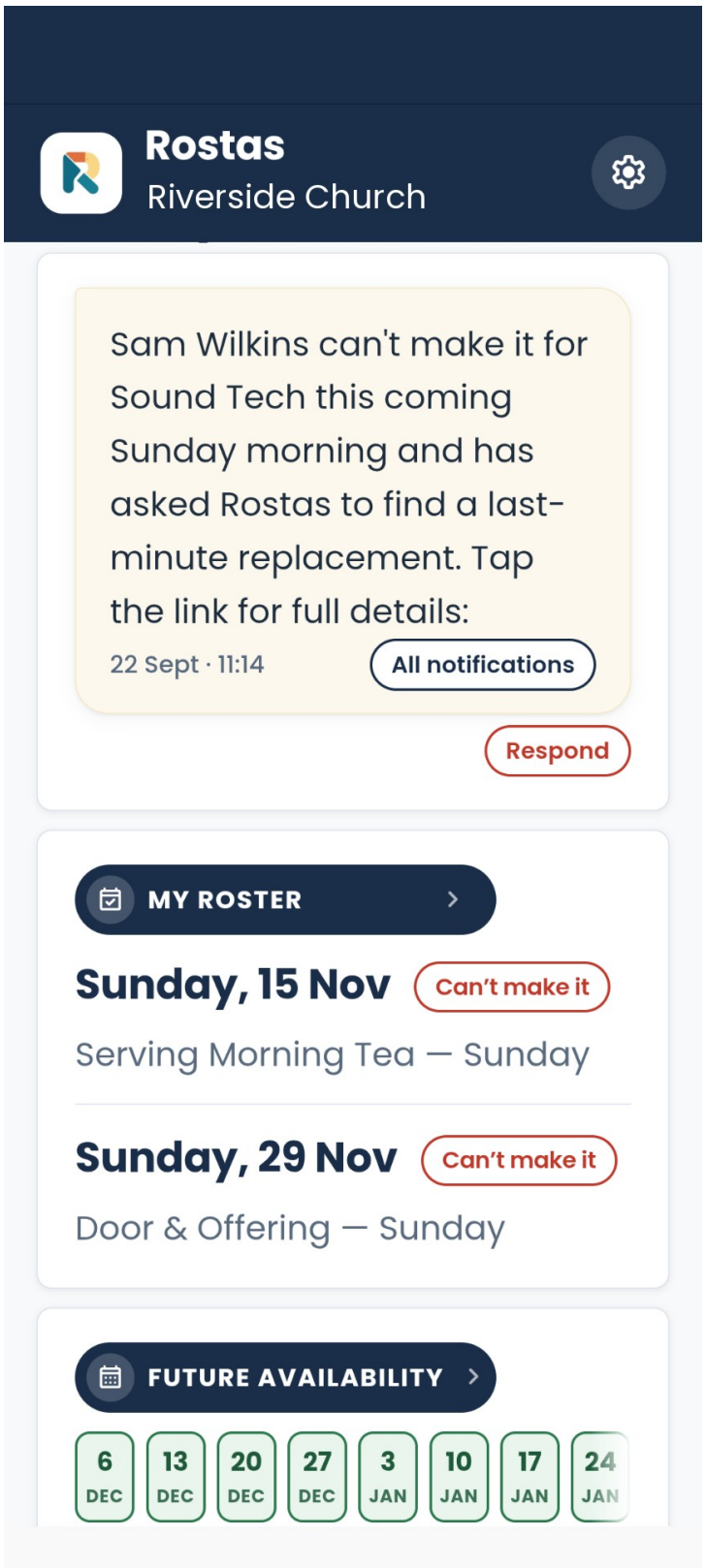
Volunteers sometimes tap a link in an older email or text after things have moved on: you've replaced them on the Board, or they've already said they can't make it. Rostas checks every answer against the roster as it is now, so an old link can never undo a change you've made or put back someone who has been replaced. Instead of changing anything, the volunteer sees a plain explanation:

If a volunteer calls to say they can make it after all, put them back from the Board: **Undo decline** on a Declined card, or **Keep [name], stop requests** while Rostas is still looking. See Taking Action on a Cell.

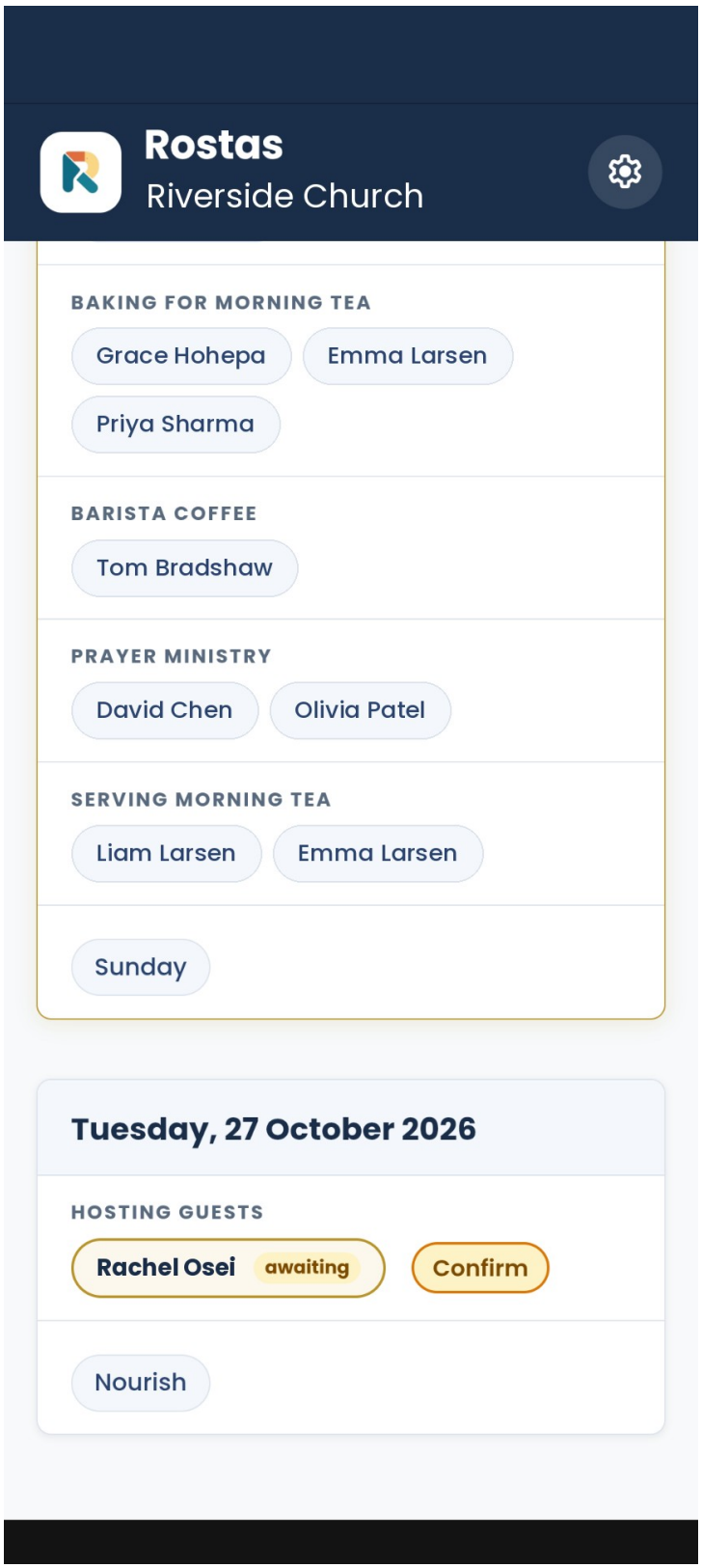
The Rostas App

Rostas has an installable app — technically a "Progressive Web App", not something from an app store — at **mobile.rostas.app**. It's a front end for exactly the same data volunteers already see by link: nothing changes about what Rostas does, only how it's reached.

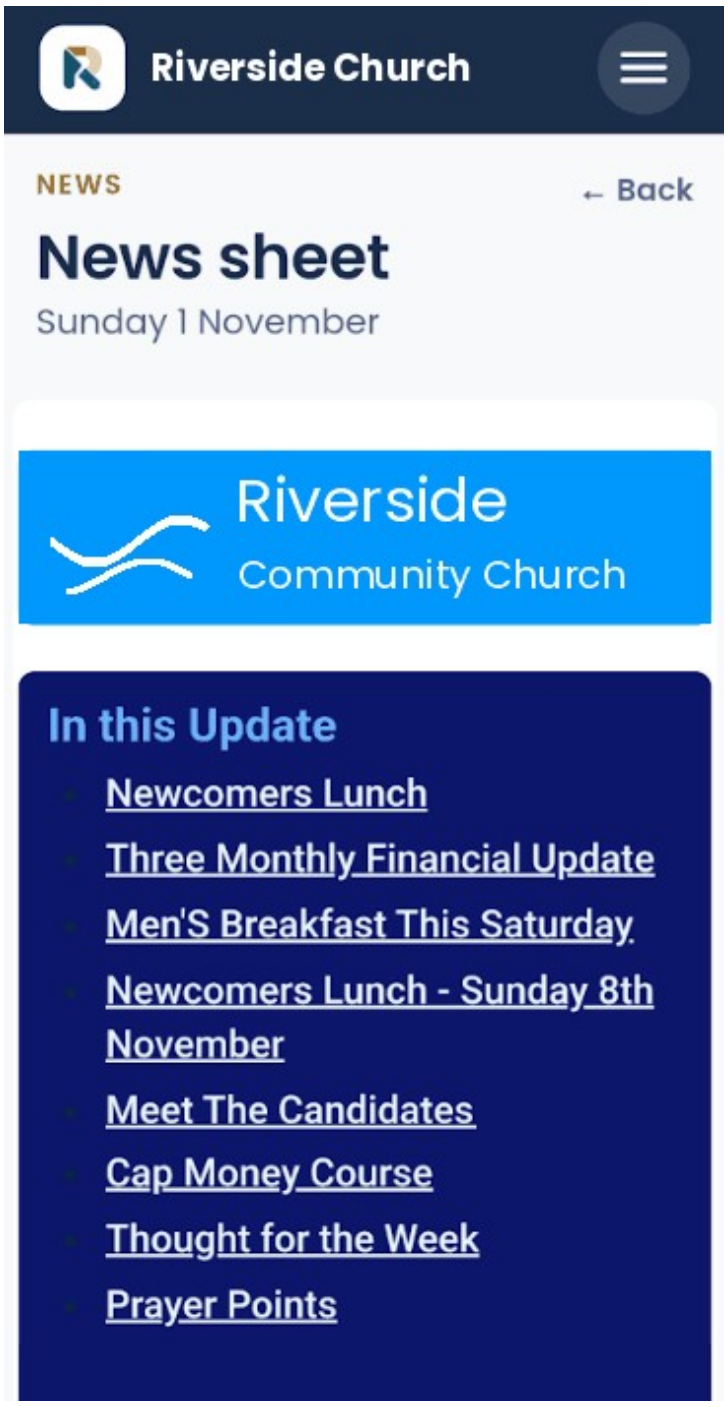
Across the top of every screen is a navy header: the **R** button (tap it from anywhere to go back to Home), your **church name**, and a three-line **Menu** button on the right. The Menu holds **News**, **Podcasts** and **Settings**; News and Podcasts only appear once your church has filled in their addresses (see News and podcasts in the app).



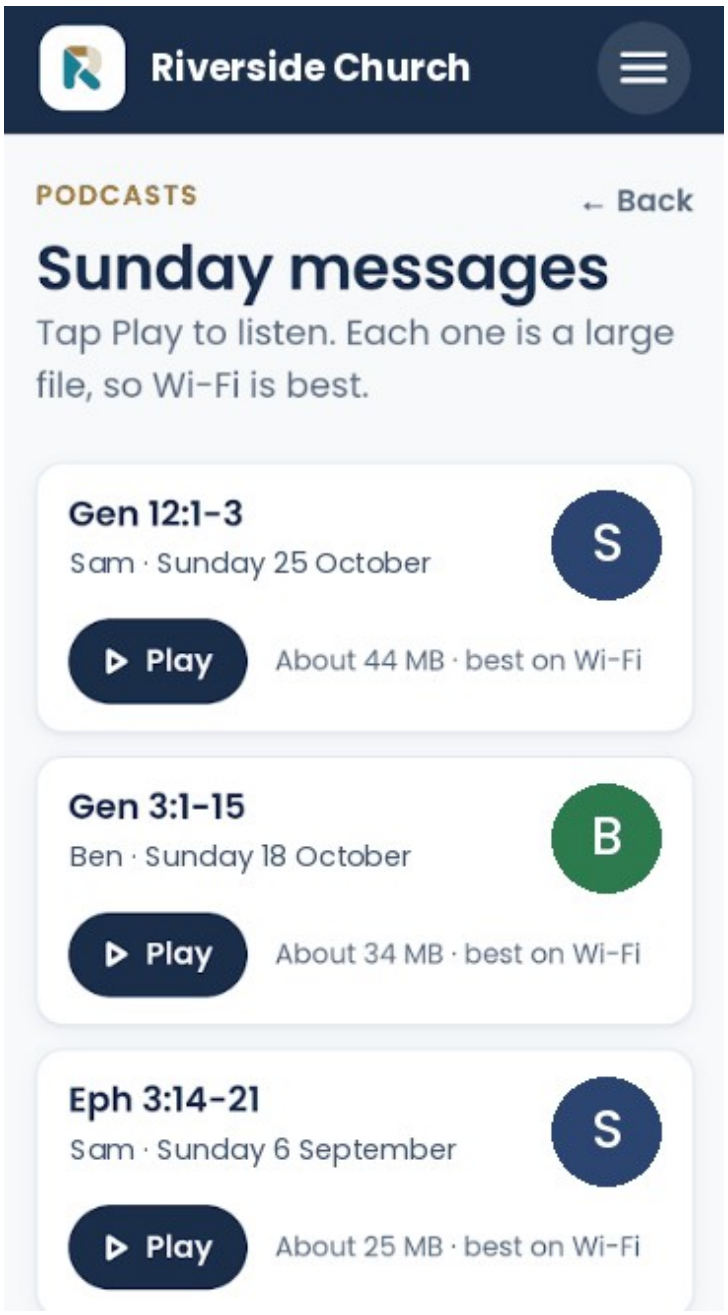
The app's Home screen — latest notification with a one-tap Respond, upcoming assignments under My Roster with a one-tap Can't make it, and a Future availability strip to scroll through.



Your Roster — the amber pill means the assignment is still pending confirmation; tapping it opens a Yes/No sheet.

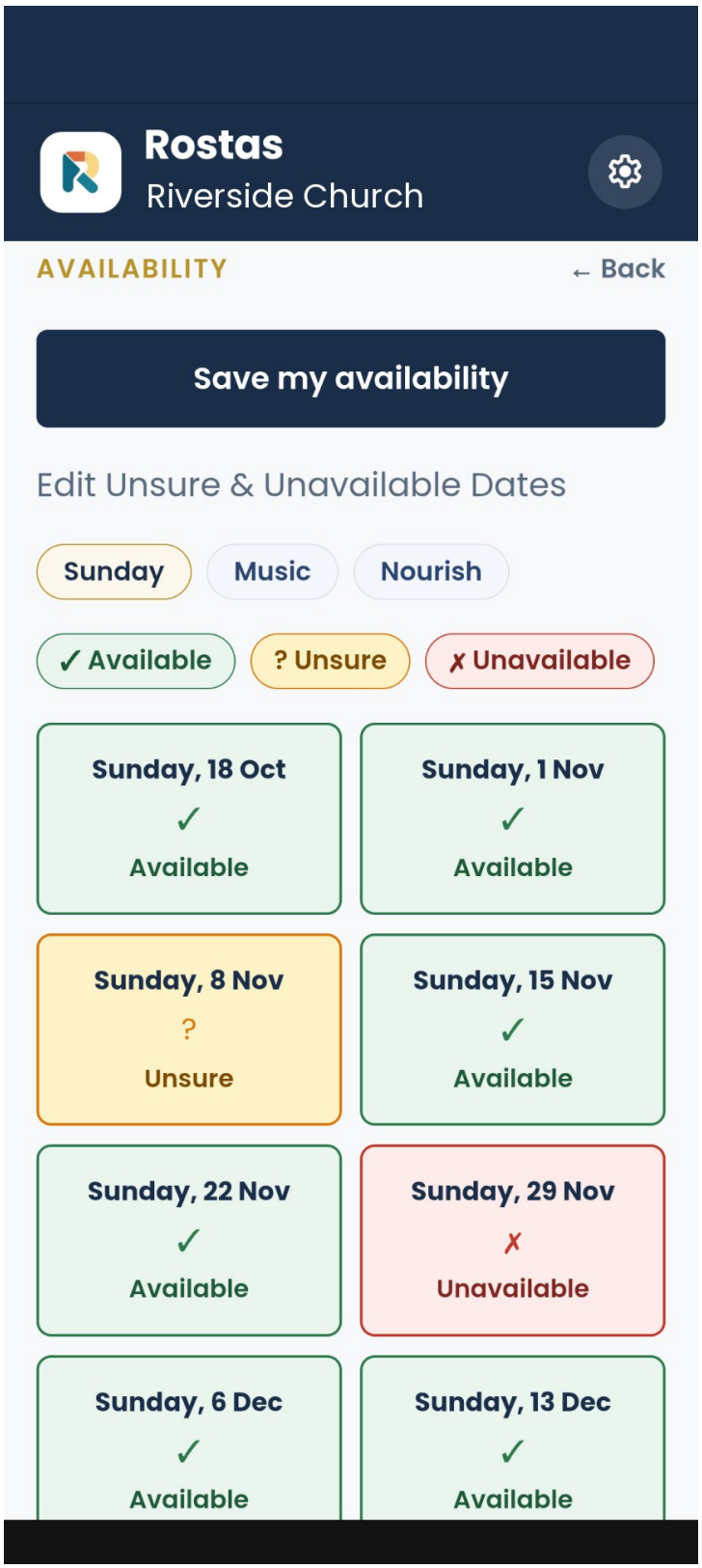


News — this week's news sheet. Tap a line under In this Update to jump to it.



Podcasts — Sunday messages with a Play button and the file size. A speaker's photo shows top right when your podcast page has one.

The app opens instantly, then checks for changes. Home, Your Roster, Availability, News and Podcasts show what the phone last saw straight away, with "Checking for changes…" at the top. The answer buttons (Can't make it, Confirm, Respond and the date cards) stay greyed out until the fresh copy arrives a moment later, so nobody acts on out-of-date information. With no signal, the screen says when it was last correct.



A volunteer serving on both Sunday and Nourish sees a pill for each — availability is set independently per roster.

How volunteers install it

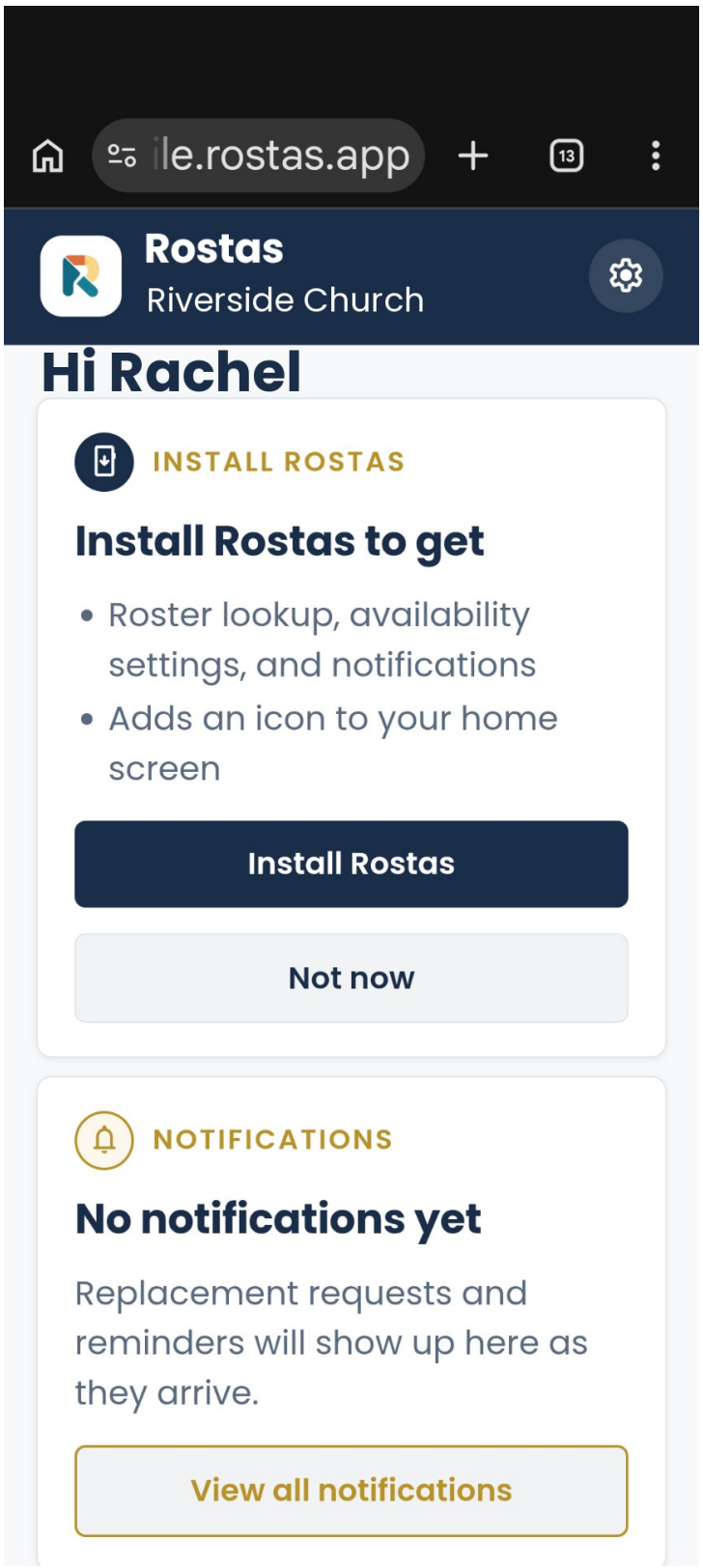
Every volunteer email carries a permanent "Get the app" card in the footer — automatic, not something you configure per email. To send someone their link straight away, see Sending a volunteer their app link. Installing looks different depending on the volunteer's phone:

The **Show me how** guide is also on the app's Home screen and in the app's **Settings** (the **App** row), so a volunteer can reopen it at any time. It ends on a **Your turn** list that stays at the top of the screen while they tap through Safari's menus.

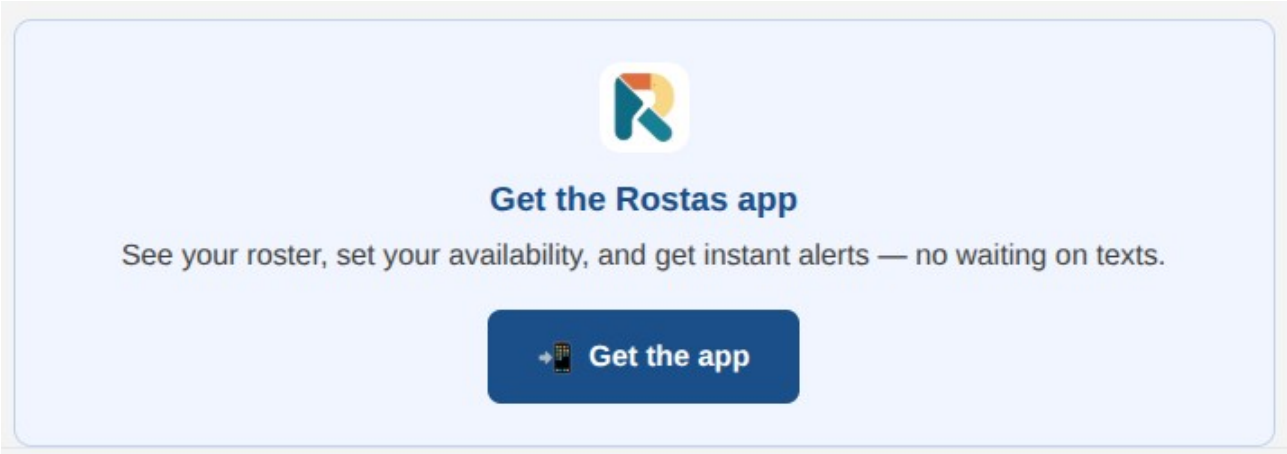
Helping someone set up an iPhone. Three things catch people out:

- **It must be Safari.** If the link opened in another browser or inside an app, the page says so. Open the link from their text message instead.
- **Leave "Open as Web App" switched on** (green) in the last step. If it's off, the icon just opens a Safari tab.
- **If the icon shows "Set up this device"**, it was added from the wrong page. Delete the icon, tap their link again, and add it from there.

"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices." Each volunteer's link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If they need another, or have changed phones more than twice, issue them a new link.



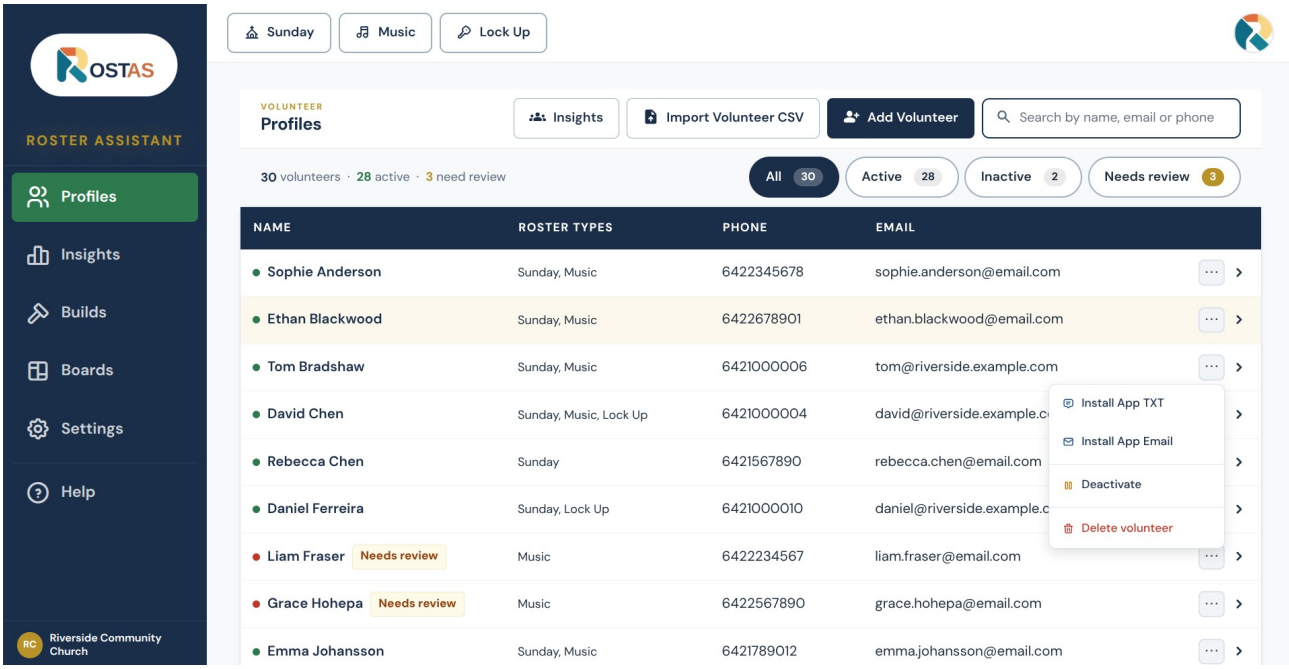
The Android install prompt — one tap installs the app, no app store involved.



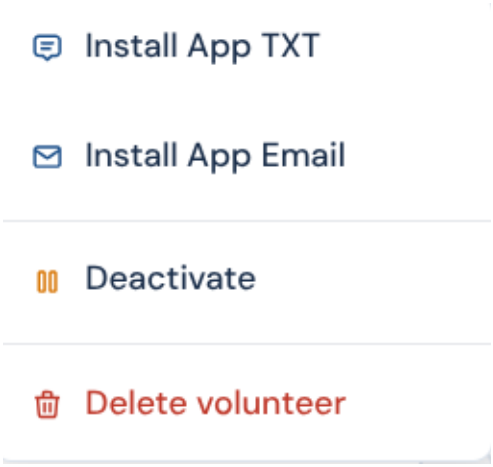
Every volunteer email carries this footer card automatically.

Sending a volunteer their app link

You don't have to wait for the next roster email. From the **Profiles** list you can send any volunteer their own app link straight away, by text or by email. Click the **⋯** button at the right-hand end of their row and choose one of the two **Install App** options.



The ⋯ button at the end of each row opens this menu. The two Install App options are at the top.



The menu close up.

Rostas confirms with a short message, such as *Text sent to Judy Aitkinson.* If it can't send, the message says why and suggests the other option. The usual reasons are:

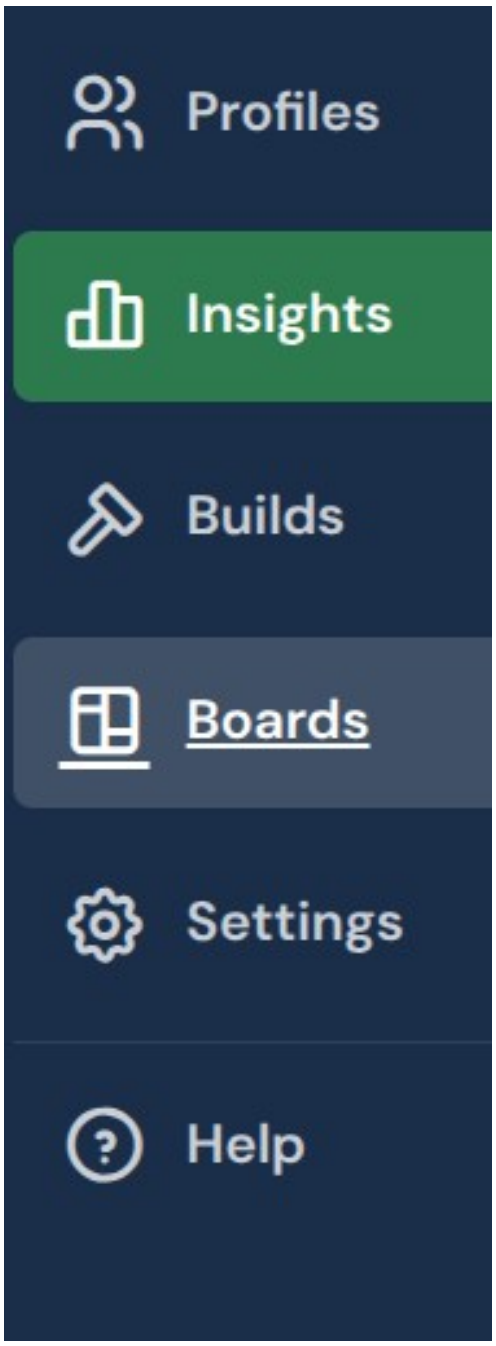
- The volunteer has **no mobile number** or **no email address** on file.
- The volunteer has **opted out** of texts or emails. You can check this with the toggles on their profile.
- Texts are **held during your SMS quiet hours** (see Settings). Use **Install App Email**, or try again later.

Both options send the volunteer's existing link, so it's fine to send it again if they lose it. Remember that each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If someone needs more, issue them a new link.

Running an app table after a service. Some churches find it easiest to set up a table where volunteers who are comfortable with phones help others. Look the person up with the search box on the Profiles page, choose **Install App TXT**, and ask them to open the text on their own phone. The helper never needs a password, because there isn't one — the link does the work. For iPhones, see *Helping someone set up an iPhone* in the section above.

Cost and test mode. A text uses one text from your SMS allowance, like any other text Rostas sends. The email costs nothing. While SMS test mode is on in Settings, the text goes to the coordinator's phone instead of the volunteer's, and the confirmation says **TEST MODE**. Email test mode works the same way.

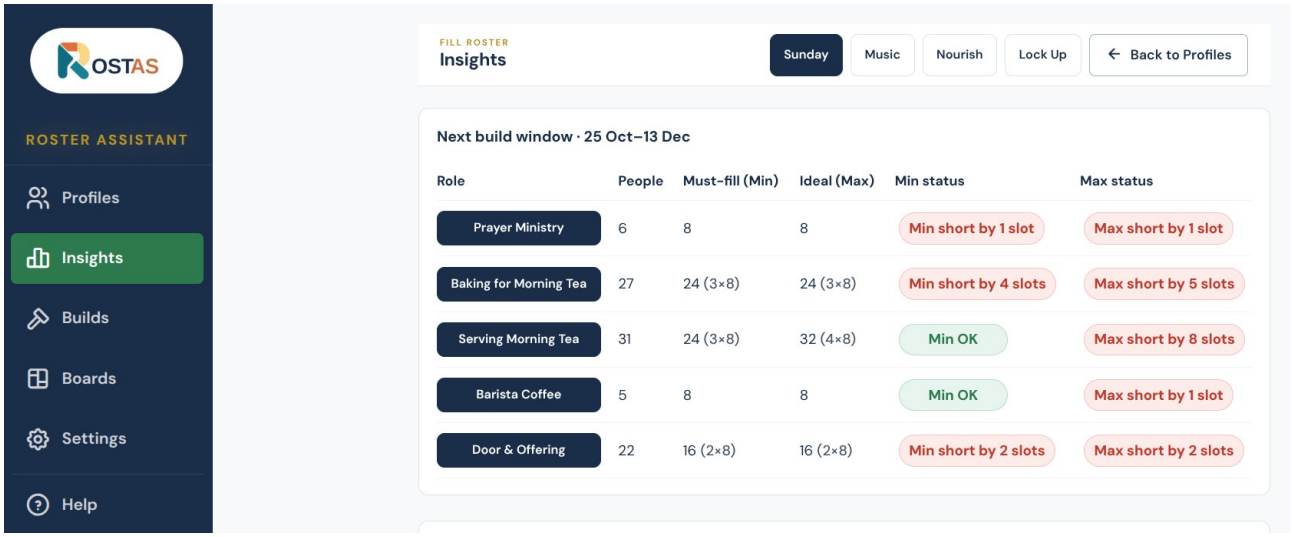
Insights is your at-a-glance health check for an upcoming roster — reachable any time from the **Insights** item in the side navigation (it sits right below Profiles), or via the "Insights" shortcut buttons on Profiles and a volunteer's own detail page. Insights refreshes whenever the roster, your volunteers or Settings change, so it always reflects your current forecast. It's worth a look between builds, not just when something's already gone wrong.



Insights lives in the side nav, right below Profiles.

The overview table

Pick a roster type along the top (Sunday, Music, Lock Up, and so on) and Insights shows every one of its roles against your next unbuilt window of dates. Two separate numbers matter for each role:

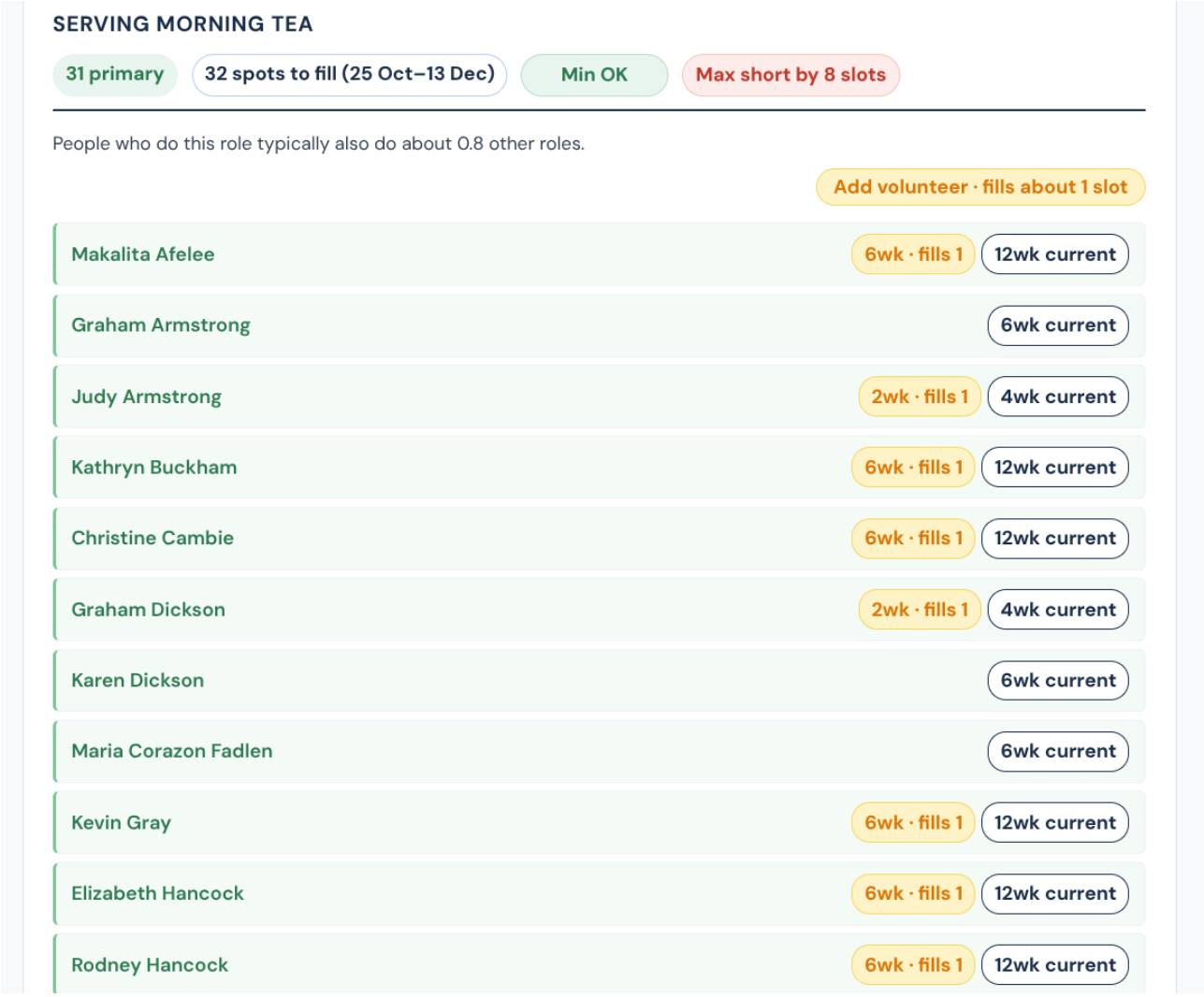


The overview table for Sunday's next build window. Baking for Morning Tea is short on both Min and Max; Serving Morning Tea meets its minimum but is short of the ideal.

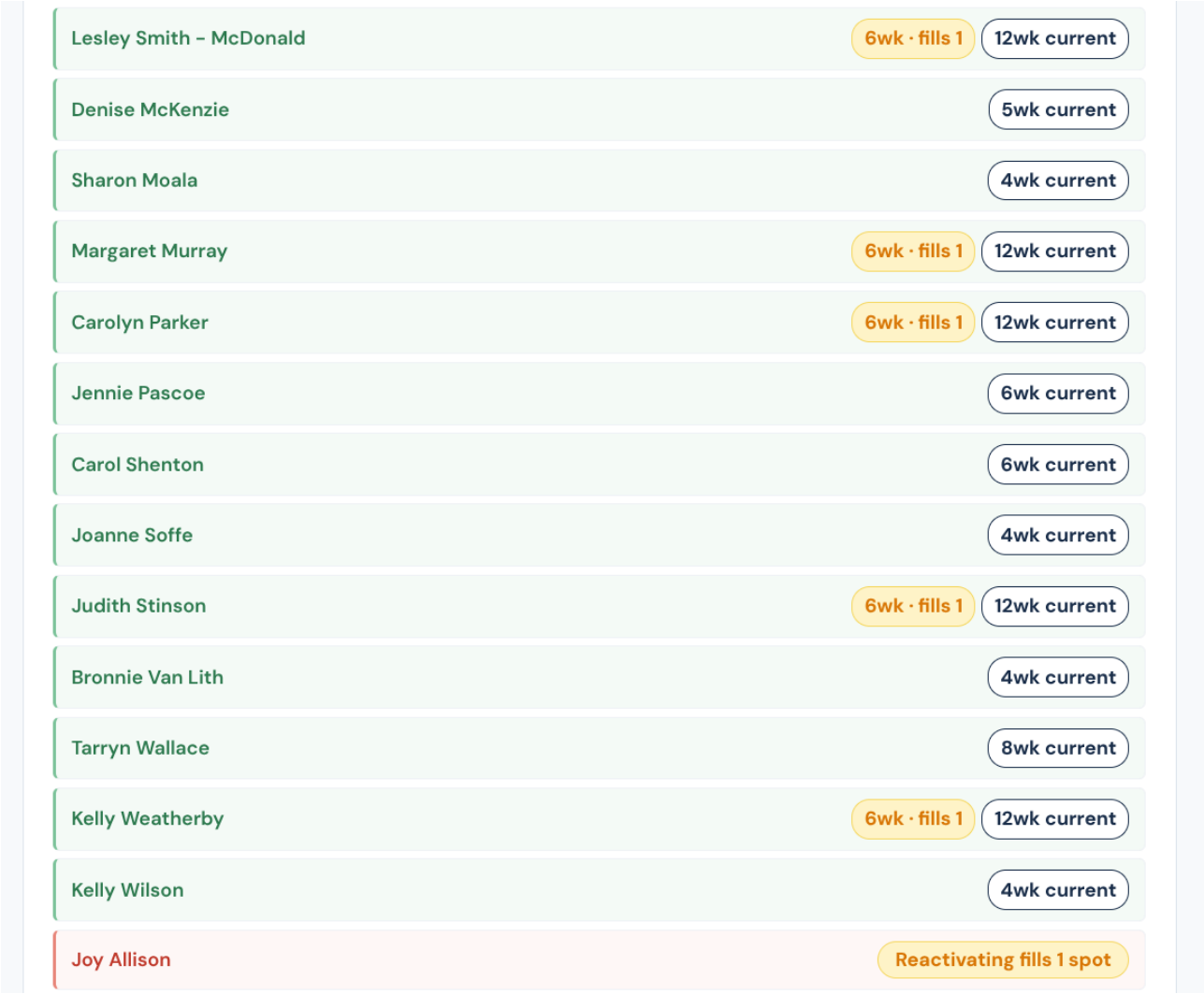
> **Min and Max are different questions.** A role can be "Min OK" — enough people to function — while still short of "Ideal (Max)", the fuller complement you'd rather have. Watch Min status first; it's the number that actually stops a roster running short-handed.

Digging into a role

Click a role's name to jump to its detail card further down the page. Each card repeats that role's numbers, then lists every volunteer linked to it with a pill showing their current frequency cap — and, where it would genuinely help, a second pill suggesting a change.



A role's detail card — headcount pills at top, then a suggestion (here, recruiting a new volunteer) and the full volunteer list below.



Most volunteers just show their current cap. A few carry an amber suggestion too — loosening their cap would fill the number of slots shown.

You'll also see a line like "People who do this role typically also do about 0.8 other roles" — a reminder that many of your volunteers are shared across roles, which is exactly what the fill-order effect below is about.

Reordering roles

Some shortfalls aren't about headcount at all — they're about **fill order**. Rostas fills roles top-to-bottom in the order they're listed on Managing Roles: once a volunteer is placed in one role for a date, they're not considered for any role further down the list that same date. A role near the bottom can end up short simply because every volunteer who could have filled it was claimed by an earlier role first.

Where moving a short role earlier in that order would help, its card shows a distinct suggestion:

> **Example reorder suggestion:** "Moving this role to the 1st position would fill 2 of 3 slots. Cost: Serving Morning Tea loses 2 slot(s)." with an **Open Manage Roles** link.

> **Always a trade, never free capacity.** Moving a role earlier redistributes an existing shared volunteer — it doesn't create a new one. Whatever slots the short role gains, another role loses, and Insights always names which one and by how much before you act. If nothing else would get worse, it says so plainly ("No other role gets worse").

> **Insights tells you, it doesn't do it for you.** Every suggestion on this page is informational. Reactivating a volunteer, loosening a cap, recruiting someone new, or reordering roles are all things you choose to do yourself — from a Profile, or from Managing Roles. Insights just points you at what's worth trying.

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. The **New Roster Wizard** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. The **Roster Wizard** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Builds dashboard**.

The Builds Dashboard

The Builds dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. Open it by clicking **Builds** in the sidebar. Every roster type appears as a full-width row — one per roster — so you can see the state of your whole operation at a glance and act on any roster without leaving the page.



The Builds dashboard — each roster type is a full-width row. On the left are the roster's icon, name, day and weeks left; across the middle, a date-chip strip shows the dates in its last build; on the right, a state button tells you where that roster is in its cycle, with the ⋯ menu beside it.

The state button

The coloured button on the right of each row tells you where that roster is in its cycle, with a short hint underneath (for example "Click to continue"). Clicking the button, or anywhere on the row, opens that roster's wizard at the right step, so you never have to remember where you left off.

Under the roster's name and day you'll also see how many **weeks are left** on the current roster (for example "7.4 wks left"). It turns red when the roster is running short and it's time to build again.

The date-chip strip

Across the middle of each row is a strip of date chips: the dates in the roster's last build. The colours are deliberately simple: **blue means a date that has already passed**, and **green means an upcoming date**. A roster that hasn't been built yet shows "No roster built yet" instead.

> **These two colours aren't the same as the date bands in the wizard.** On the Builds dashboard, chip colour just means past (blue) or upcoming (green). On the Build Dates screen you'll see a richer set of coloured bands for last build, this build, next build, and excluded dates. That's a different view with a different job.

Beside the state button, the ⋯ menu holds the rest of what you can do with a roster: pausing, adjusting dates, roles and season length, resetting, or deleting. See The Build Menu below for the full walkthrough.

Starting a brand-new roster type? The green **New Roster** row at the bottom of the Builds dashboard sets one up from scratch. See the New Roster Wizard section below.

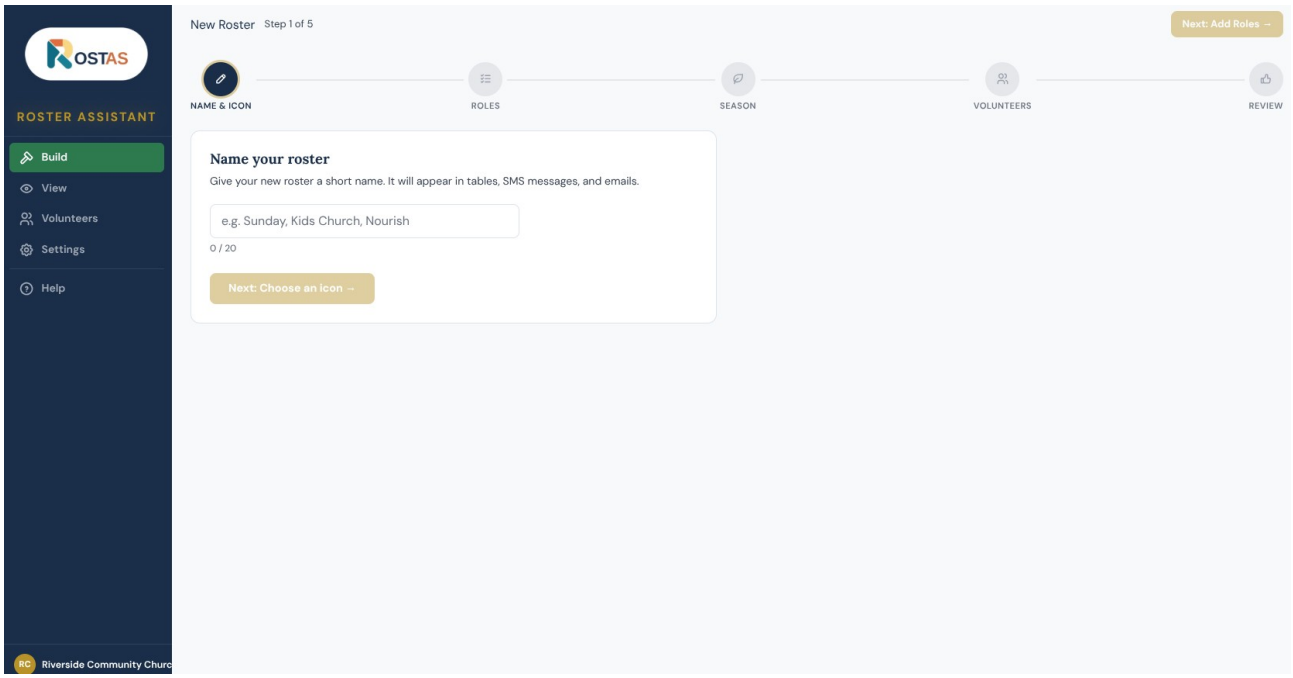
The New Roster Wizard

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

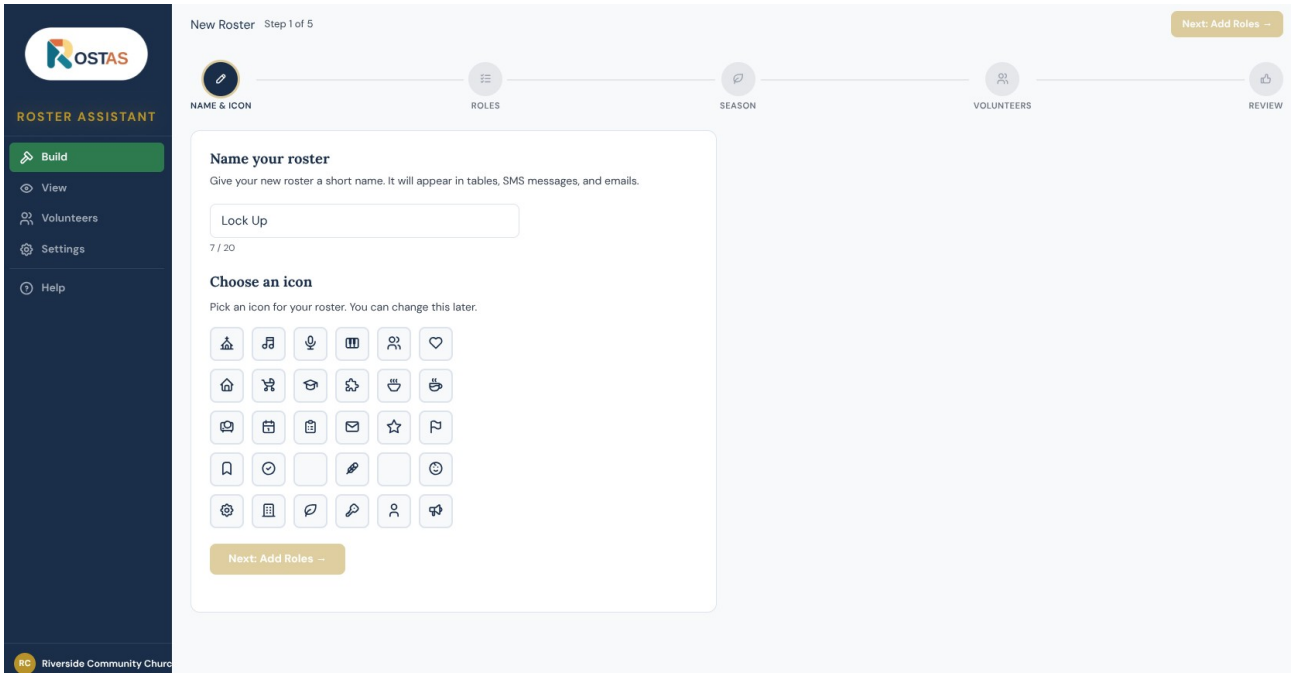
> **You only run the New Roster Wizard once per roster type.** After setup is complete, all future roster builds use the Roster Wizard instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — so keep it brief and clear. A few words are kept for Rostas's own settings and can't be used as a roster name: Name, Email, Phone, ID, Key and Role.



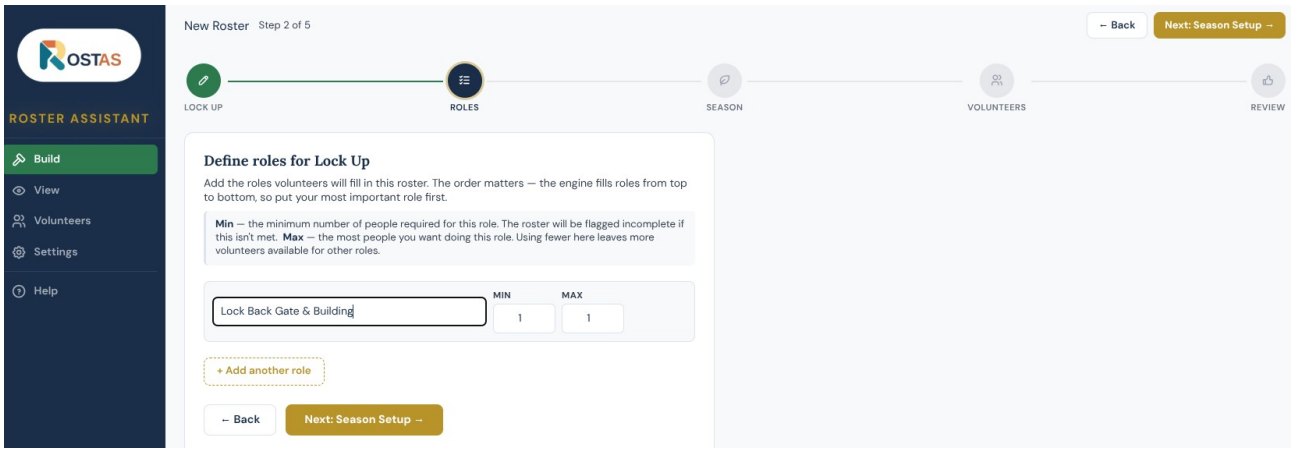
Step 1 — name your roster. This name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality".



After naming the roster, choose an icon that represents it. The icon appears on the roster's row on the Builds dashboard and beside its name in the app.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required. You can add, rename, or retire roles later from Managing Roles.

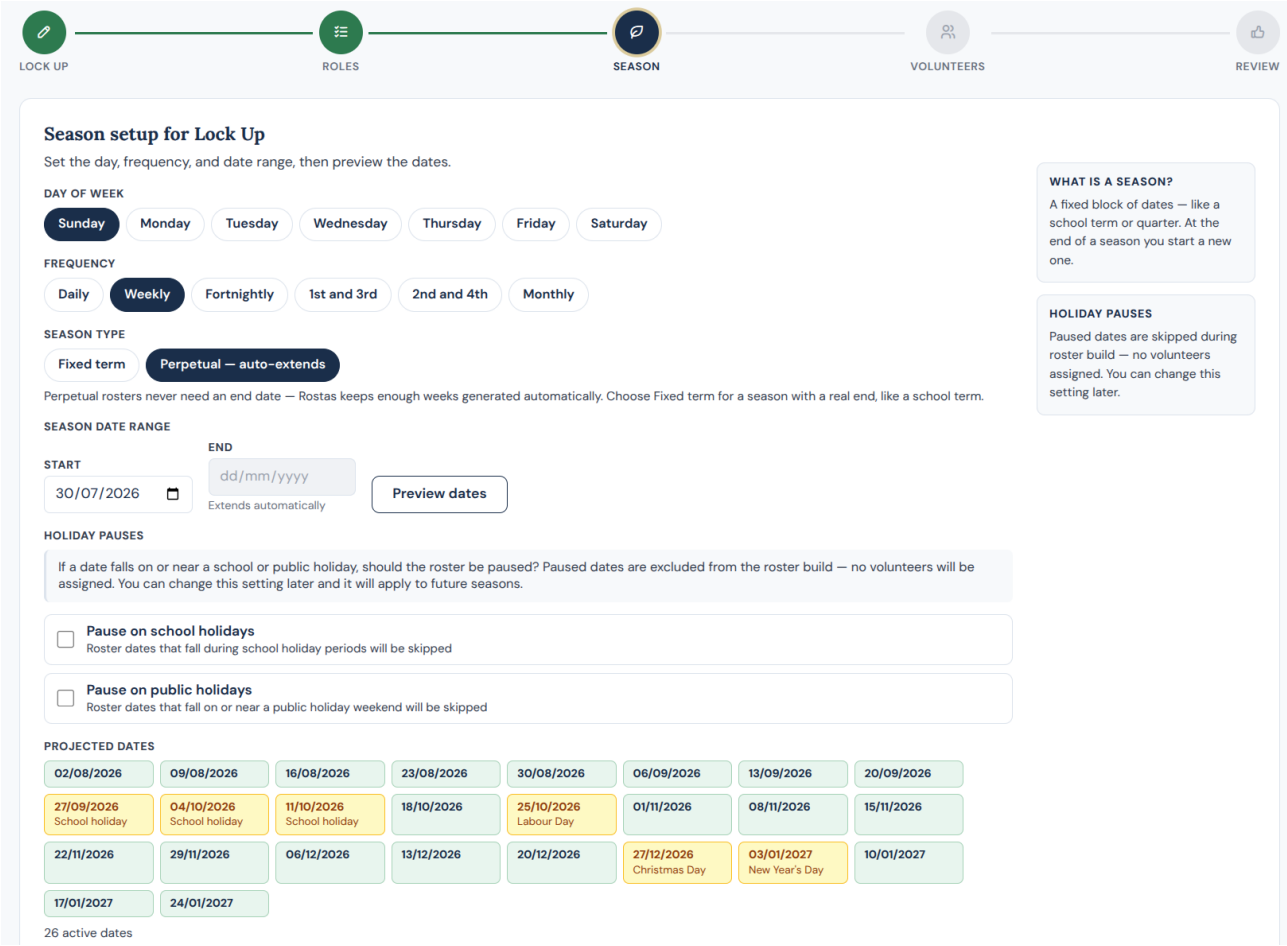


Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

> **Role names matter.** Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

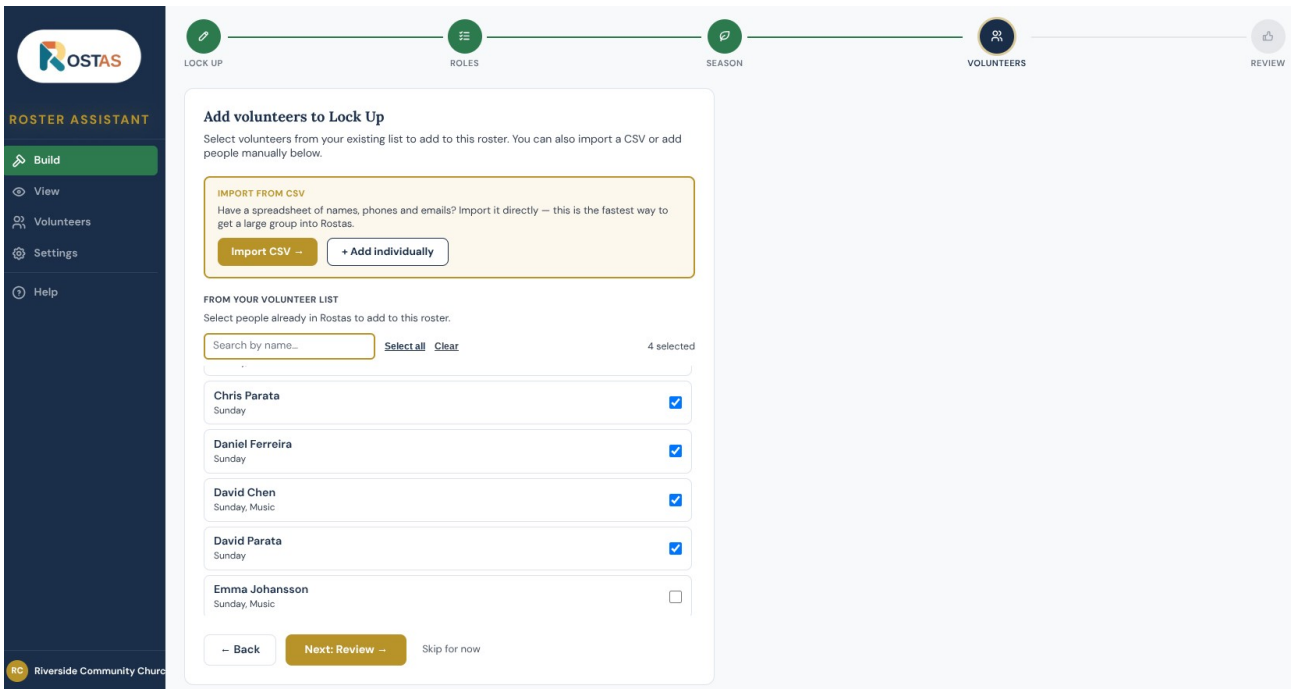
A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.



Step 3 — set up your first season. Choose day of week, frequency, and date range. Projected dates appear as pills below — school holidays are labelled automatically so you can see which dates will be paused.

Step 4 — Volunteers

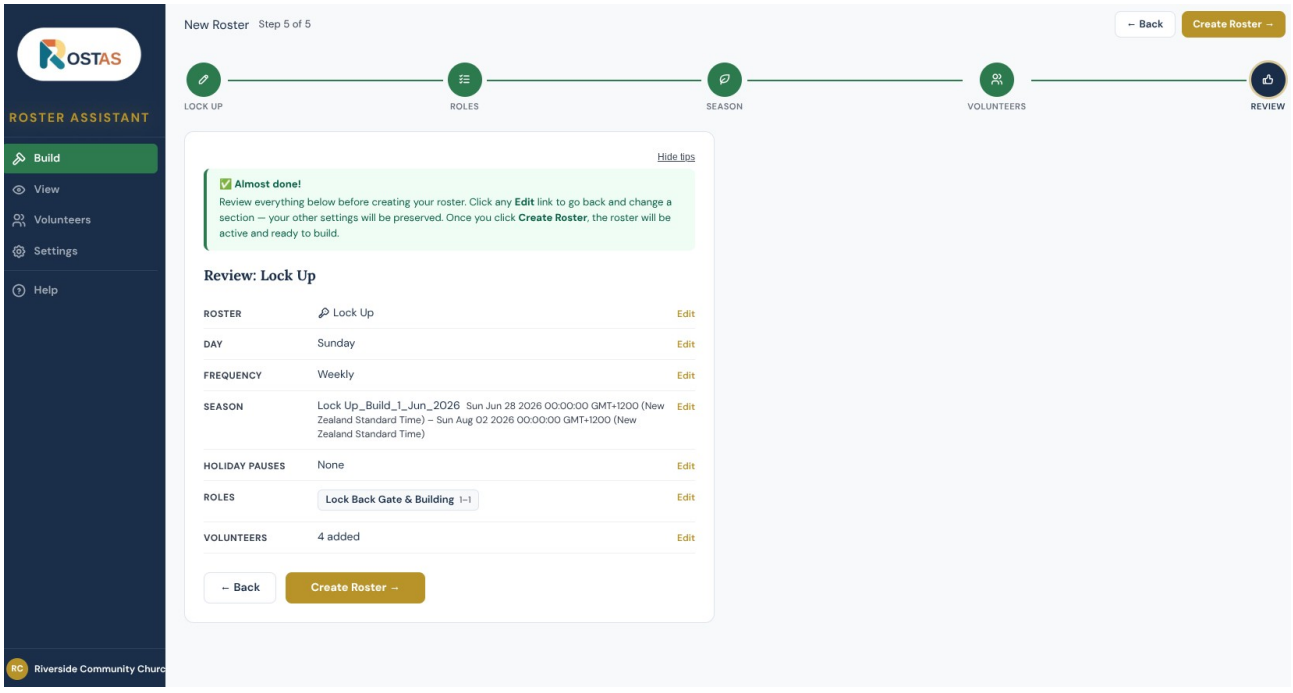
Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Tick each volunteer you want to include. Only volunteers already in Rostas appear here — if someone is missing, add them in Profiles first then return to this step.



Step 4 — tick each volunteer who serves in this roster. Use the search field to find someone quickly if you have a large list. You can also import additional volunteers via CSV from this step.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, icon, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.



Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

Click **Create Roster →** to finish. Rostas takes you straight into the Roster Wizard for your new roster, ready for its first build, and the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

The Roster Wizard

The Roster Wizard is the roster cycle you run every few weeks. Each roster type has its own (the page is headed "[Your roster] Roster Wizard") and it takes you through the same six steps every time: **Confirm Dates, Roles, Role Prefs, Availability, Build & Check, and Notify**.

To start, open the **Builds** dashboard and click a roster's row or state button. If a build is already under way, you're taken straight back to the step you left off at.

Finding your way around the wizard

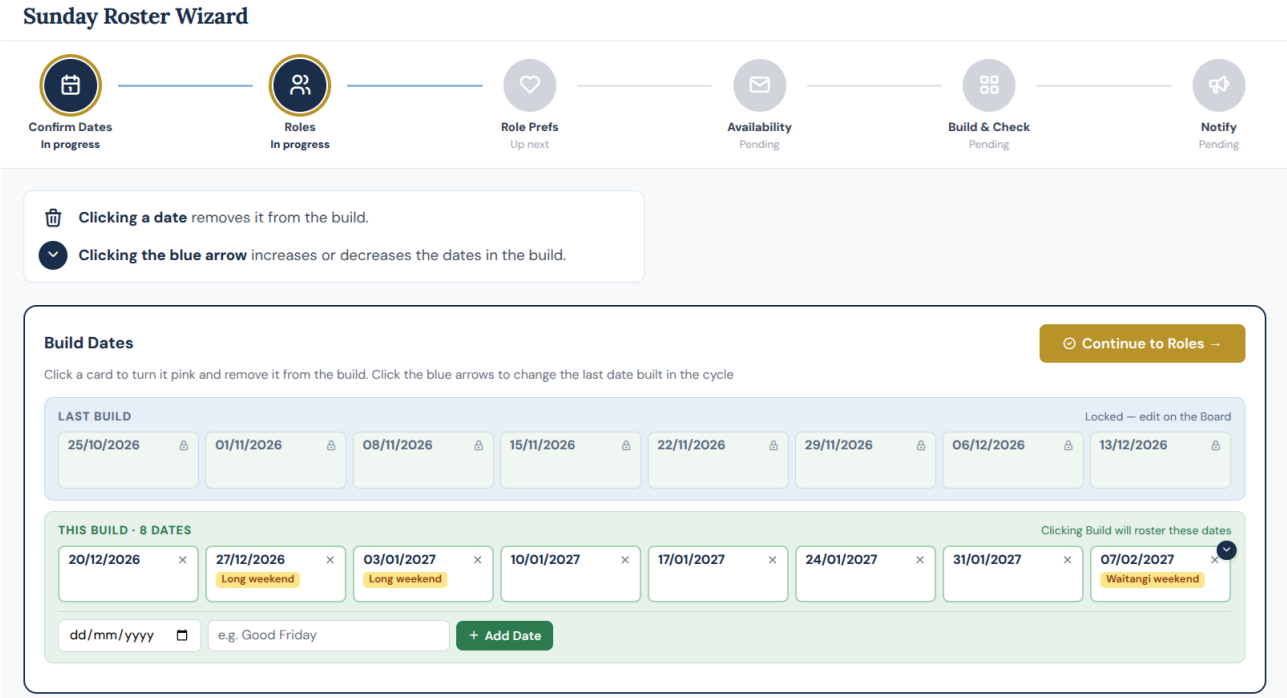
Across the top of every step is a row of six circles, one per step. Each says how that step stands: **Completed**, **Skipped**, **In progress**, **Ready** or **Pending**. Click a completed or skipped circle to look at that step again; click **Confirm Dates** at any time to go back to the dates.

Directly under the circles is one bar that stays in the same place on every step: **← Back** on the left, "Step N of 6" in the middle, and the main button (for example **Continue to Role Prefs →**) on the right. Some steps have their own buttons inside the card instead, and then the right-hand button is hidden.

Step 1 — Confirm Dates

The wizard opens on the **Build Dates** screen, where you confirm which dates this build covers. A small box at the top reminds you how it works: **clicking a date** removes it from the build, and **clicking the blue arrow** makes the build longer or shorter. You can also add a one-off date with **+ Add Date**. All of this is explained in Confirming Build Dates below.

When the dates look right, click **Continue to Roles →** on the Build Dates title row. That saves the dates and takes you to the next step.

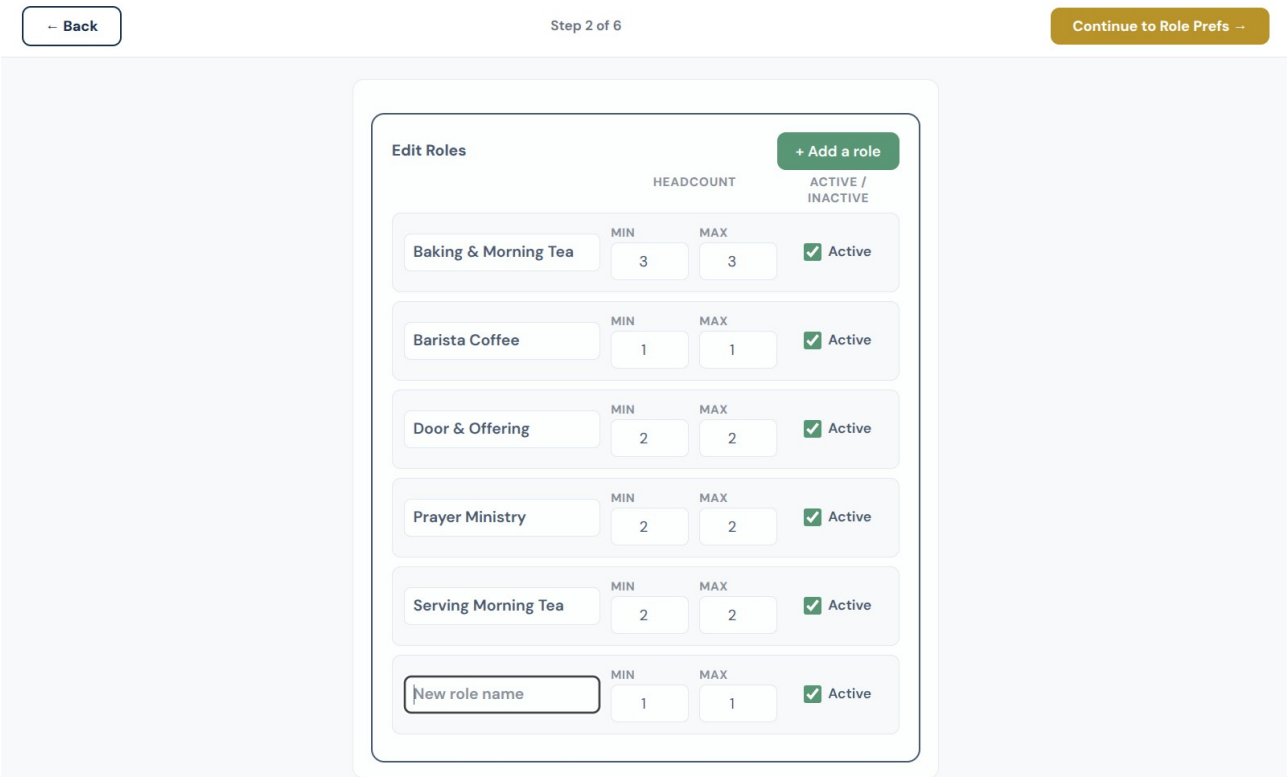


Step 1 — Confirm Dates. Last Build dates are locked (change those on the Board); This Build shows how many dates this build will roster. Remove or add dates, move the boundary with the blue arrow, then click Continue to Roles.

Step 2 — Roles

This step shows one card, **Edit Roles**: every role on this roster with its name, its **Min** and **Max** headcount and an **Active** tick box. You can rename a role, change its headcount, untick it to leave it out, or use **+ Add a role**. What you set here carries forward to later builds. Roles start out as they were last time, so on a routine build you can usually just click **Continue to Role Prefs →**.

There's no separate Save button: any change you make is saved when you leave the step, whether by Back, Continue, or clicking a circle at the top.



Step 2 — Roles. Set the minimum and maximum people each role needs, or untick a role you don't need. + Add a role adds a blank row at the bottom: type the new role's name and set its headcount.

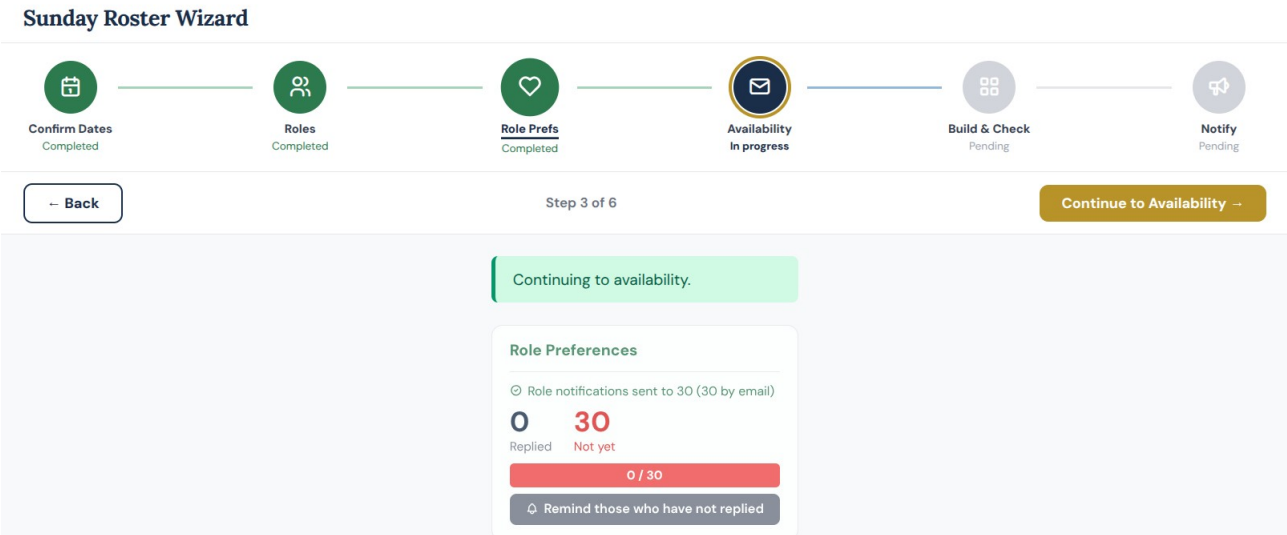
> **Changing the order roles are filled in?** Do that from Manage roles on the ⋯ menu.

Step 3 — Role Prefs

This step asks volunteers which roles suit them. At the top it tells you how many volunteers on this roster already have role preferences. Volunteers with no roles set won't be rostered. Choose one of these:

The two "send only…" and "set them myself" options only appear when some volunteers have no roles. Each volunteer gets **one message**: through the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise by email, otherwise by text.

After you send, the step shows how the messages went (for example "Role notifications sent to 24 (18 by app, 5 by email, 1 by text)"), with a count of who has **Replied** and who has **Not yet**. Use **Remind those who have not replied** if you want to give people a nudge, and **Continue to availability** when you're ready to move on. You don't have to wait for every reply before moving on.



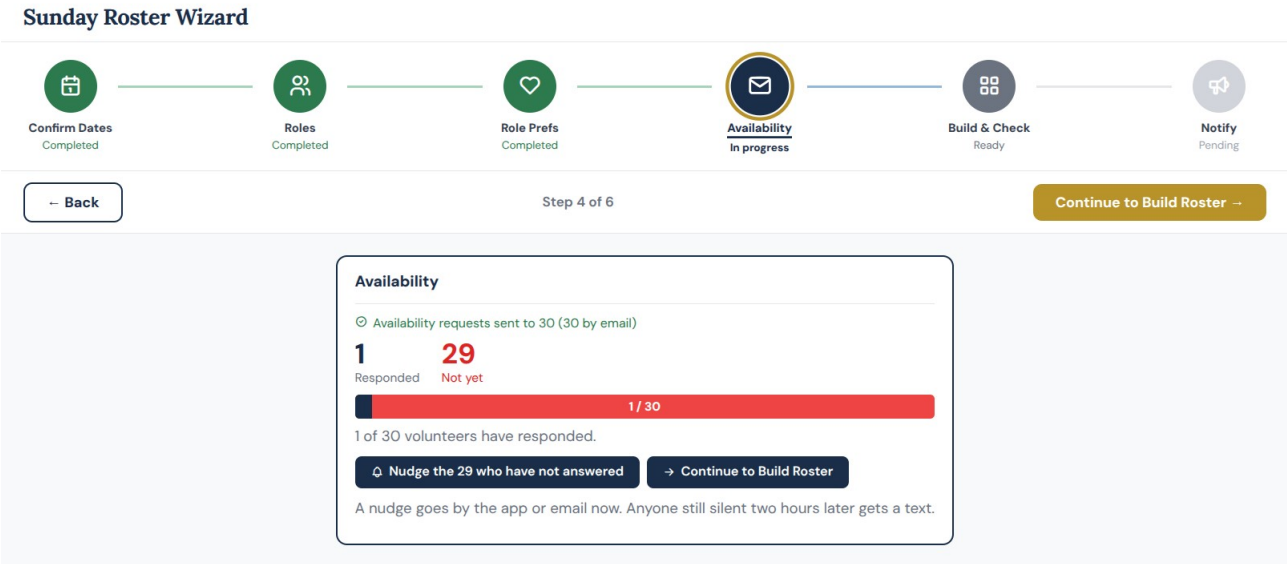
Role Prefs after sending. The Replied and Not yet counts update as volunteers answer.

> **Changed your mind after skipping?** Click the Role Prefs circle at the top. A skipped step shows the same options again, and choosing one replaces the skip.

Step 4 — Availability

This step asks: *do you want to ask volunteers for their availability first?* You have two choices:

Sending takes about a minute ("Sending availability requests..."). Once the poll has gone, the step shows how it was sent (for example "Availability requests sent to 30 (30 by email)") and who has **Responded** and who has **Not yet**, with a progress bar. Click **Nudge the N who have not answered** to chase the rest. The nudge goes by the app or email straight away, and anyone still silent two hours later gets one text (never during quiet hours). When you're ready, click **Continue to Build Roster**.

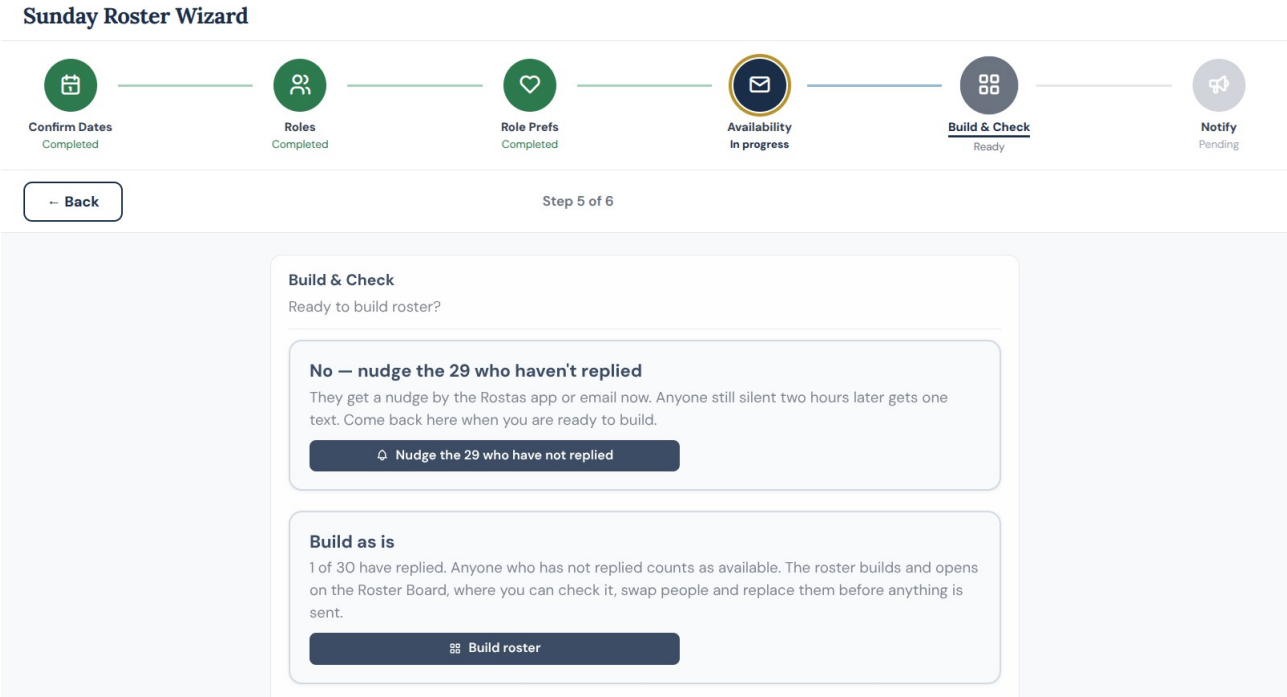


Waiting for replies. The counts update as volunteers answer.

Give people a few days to reply before you build. You can leave the wizard and come back; the roster shows **Gathering** on the Builds dashboard in the meantime.

Step 5 — Build & Check

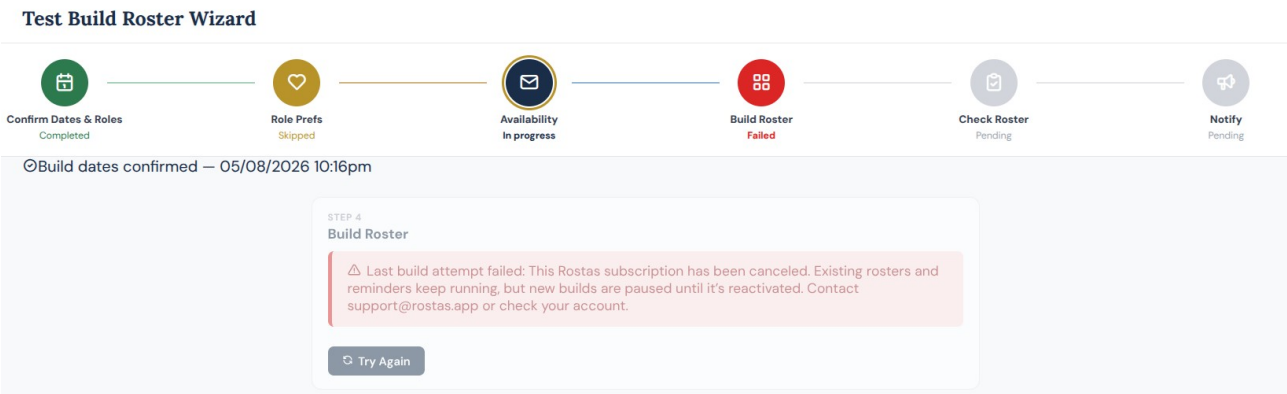
This step asks **Ready to build roster?** If some volunteers still haven't answered the poll, you can **nudge** them first and come back later. Otherwise choose **Build as is** → *Build roster*. Anyone who hasn't replied counts as available.



Step 5 — Build & Check. Nudge the stragglers, or build now.

The roster engine looks at every volunteer's availability, role preferences, how recently they've served and how often they want to serve, and fills every slot it can (see The Intelligent Matching Engine). A build can take up to 5–10 minutes for a big roster. When it's finished, the **Roster Board opens by itself**.

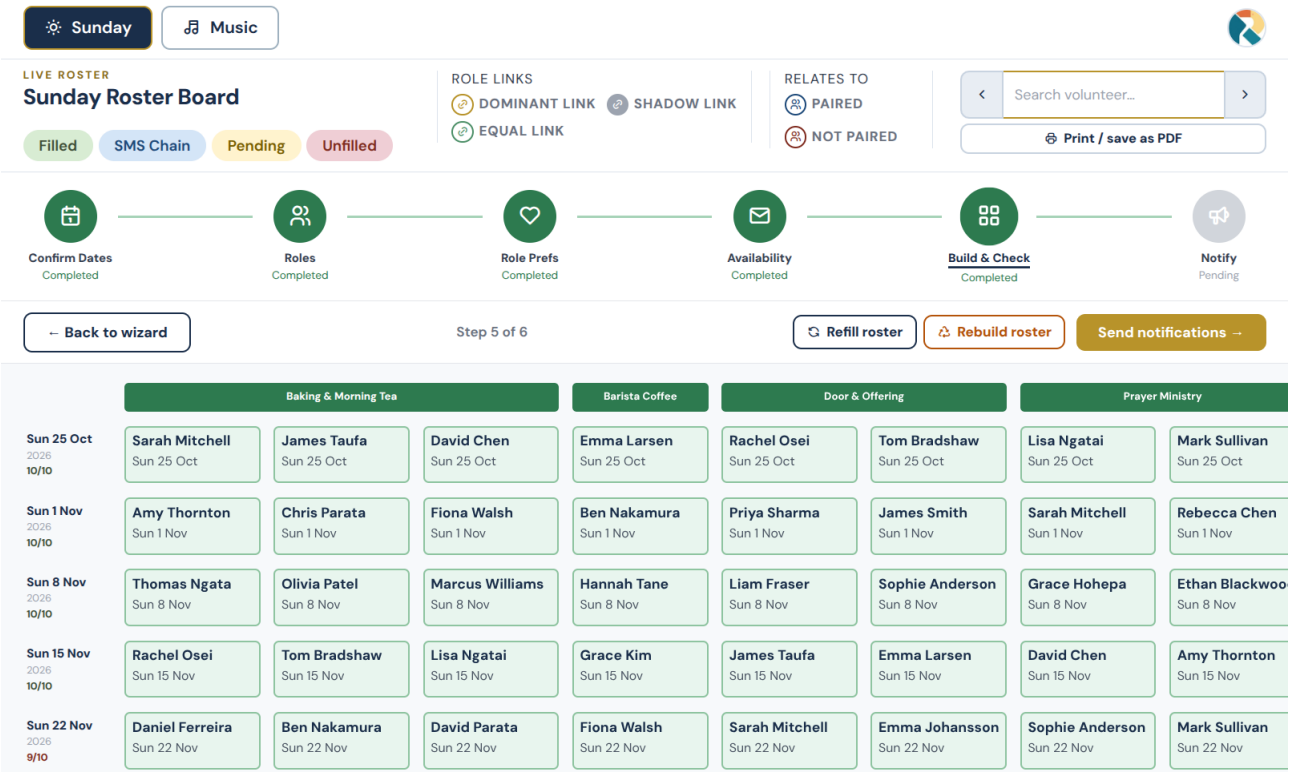
If a build can't complete (for example your Rostas subscription has lapsed, or a role or date setting blocks it), the step says "Last build attempt failed" with the reason, and a **Try Again** button for once it's fixed.



If a build fails, the step shows exactly why and lets you try again once it's fixed.

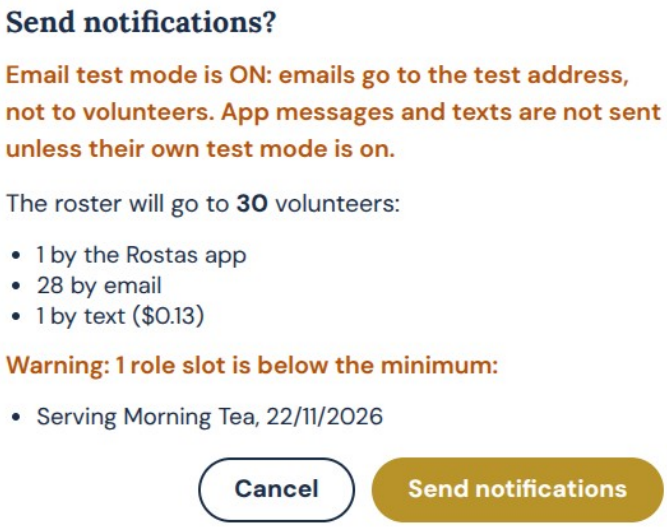
Checking the roster on the Board

The Board is where you check the roster before anyone is told. Until you send, it shows the wizard's step circles across the top and a bar with **← Back to wizard**, "Step 5 of 6", and three buttons:



The Board after a build. Click any cell to swap or replace someone, then Send notifications when you're happy.

When you click **Send notifications**, a box shows exactly what will happen before anything goes: how many volunteers will be told by the Rostas app, by email and by text (with the cost of the texts), anyone who can only be texted and must wait until quiet hours end, anyone who can't be reached at all, and a warning listing any roles still **below their minimum**. Click **Send notifications** in the box to go ahead, or Cancel to keep working.

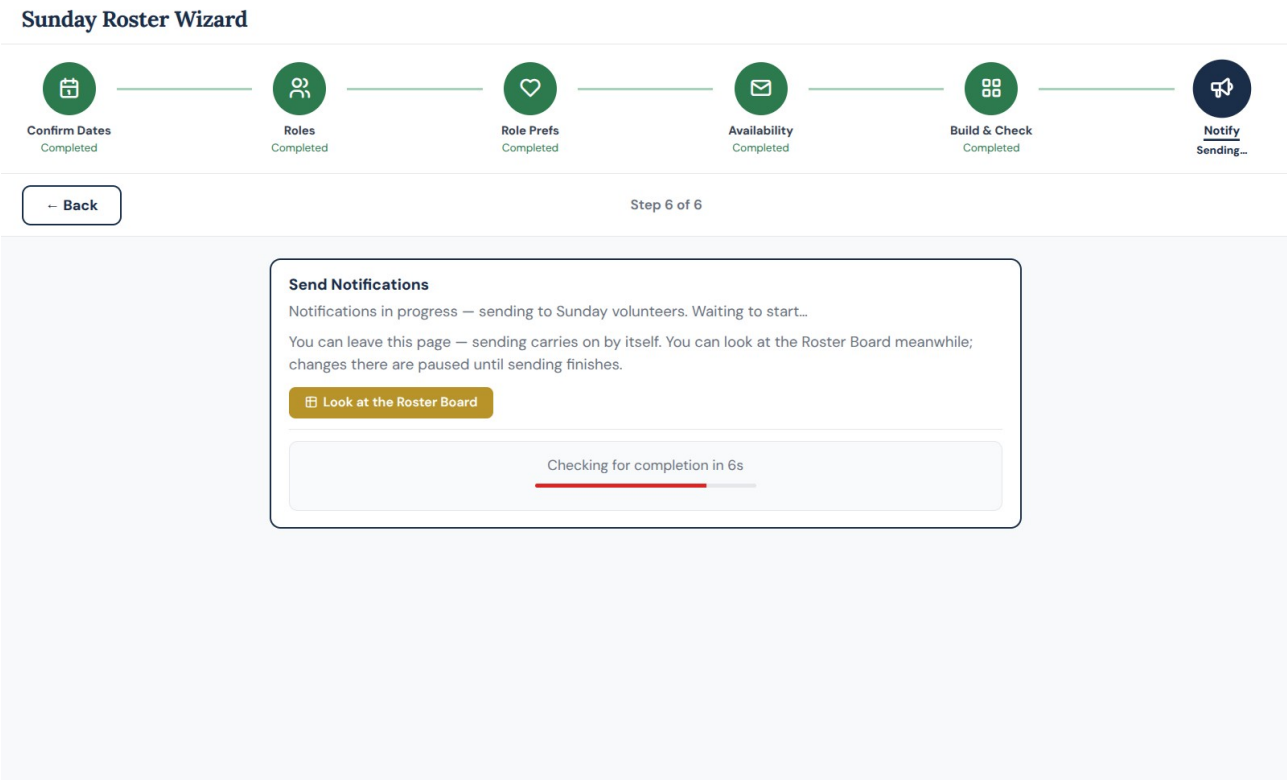


The Send notifications check, listing who will be told and how, and any role still below its minimum.

> **Don't skip the check.** It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are told. Look for red (unfilled) slots and make any swaps you need first.

Step 6 — Notify

After you send from the Board, the wizard opens on the Notify step. While messages are going out it shows "Sent N of M so far". You can leave the page and sending carries on by itself. You can look at the Board meanwhile (**Look at the Roster Board**), but changes there are paused until sending finishes. The Notify circle reads "Sending…" until it's done.

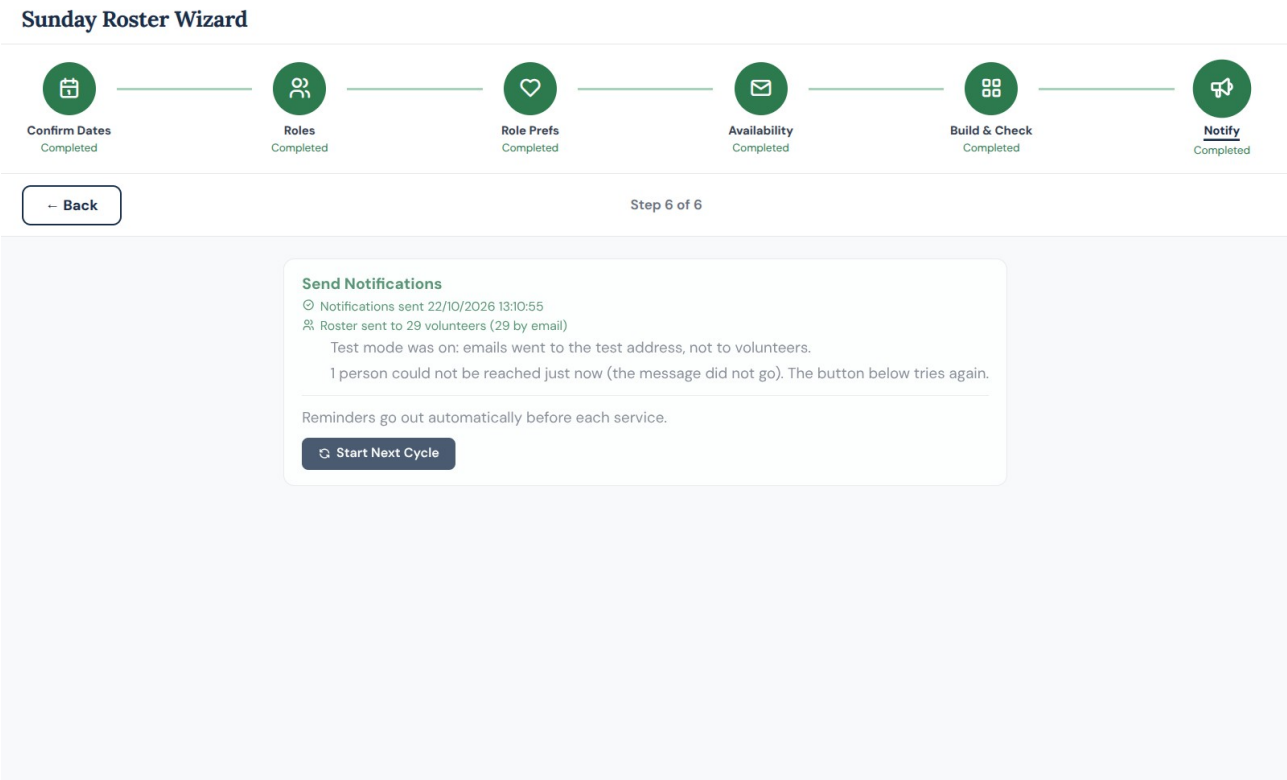


Sending in progress. The page checks every few seconds and shows the result when sending finishes.

Each volunteer gets one message with their roles and dates and confirm and decline links: through the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise by email, otherwise by text. When it's done, the step shows when notifications were sent and how many people were told and how (for example "Roster sent to 29 volunteers (29 by email)"). It also tells you about anyone who wasn't reached:

- **Text-only volunteers during quiet hours**: their text waits until quiet hours end.
- **Couldn't be reached just now**: the message didn't go through.
- **No app, email or phone number**: they can't be told; add their details on their profile.

If anyone can still be reached, a **Send to the N not yet reached** button tries them again. When you're ready to start the next roster, click **Start Next Cycle**.

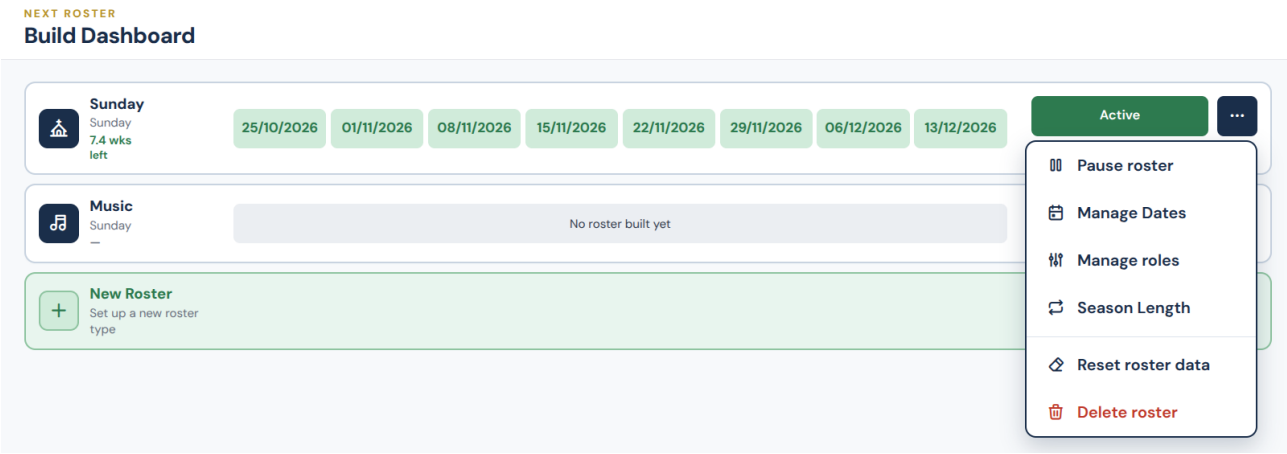


Step 6 — Notify. All six circles show complete, and automatic reminders are queued.

- Reminder email sent 3 days before each service date (change this in Settings → Timing & behaviour → Reminder days before service)
- The day before, an app notification or a text, depending on Settings → Timing & behaviour → Day-before reminder texts
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it", the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

The Build Menu

The ··· menu beside each row's state button on the Builds dashboard holds everything you do with a roster between builds — pausing it, adjusting its dates or roles, changing its season length, clearing its data, or deleting it outright. Click it to open a pop-up of options.



The ··· menu open on a roster row. When a roster is paused, the top option reads "Resume roster" instead of "Pause roster".

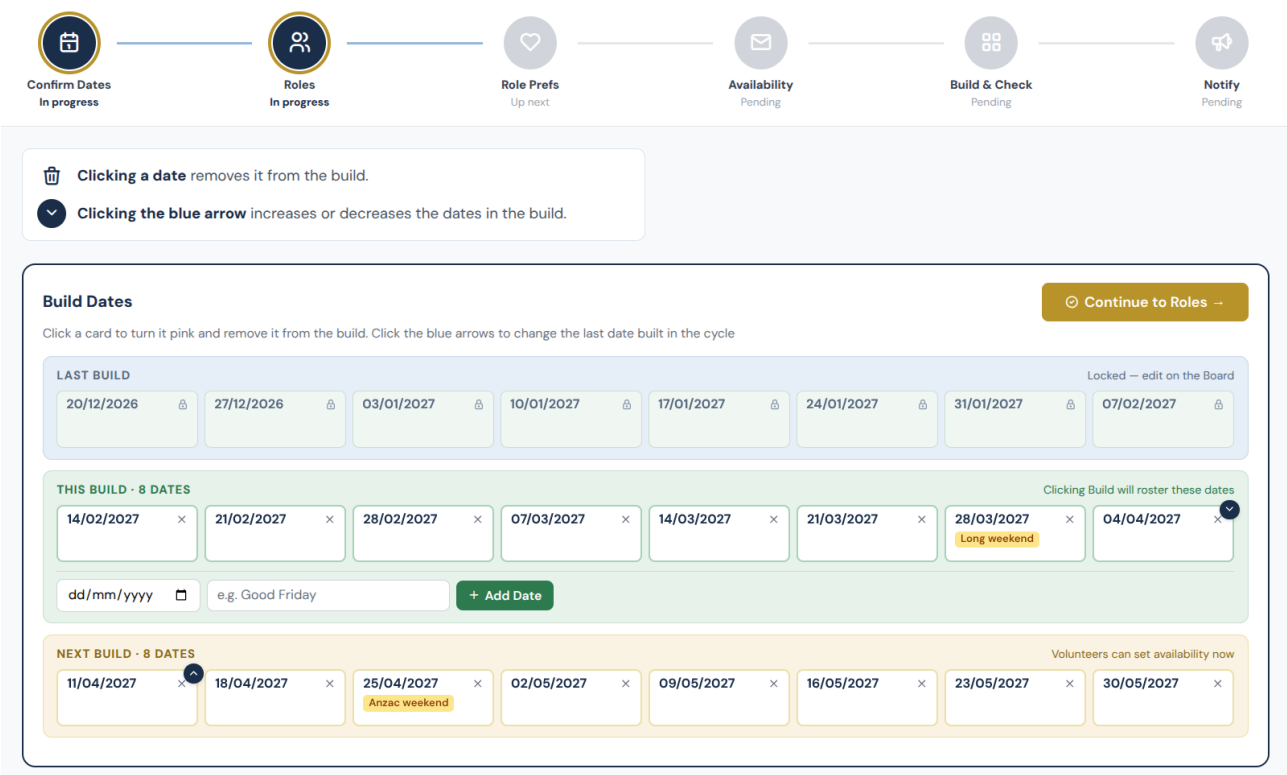
Pause / Resume roster

Pausing a roster stops all automatic activity for it straight away — no builds, no reminder emails or texts, no availability emails or nudges, and no replacement chains (a chain already running stops asking people) — without losing any history. Anything that falls due while it's paused is skipped, not saved up for later. The menu option and the row's state button both switch to **Resume roster** while paused; click either to pick back up exactly where you left off.

Confirming Build Dates

Before each build you confirm exactly which dates it covers, on the **Build Dates** screen. It lays out your roster's dates in three bands — what's already built, what this build will cover, and what's coming next — and lets you drop a date you don't want, shift the boundary between builds, or add a one-off extra date such as Christmas Day or Good Friday.

You reach it two ways: as the first step of a build (Confirm Dates), or on its own from the Builds dashboard — ··· — **Manage Dates**. A small box at the top of the screen sums up the two main controls: clicking a date removes it from the build, and clicking the blue arrow makes the build longer or shorter.



The Build Dates screen — each date is a card, grouped into three bands. Coloured tags on a card show anything Rostas has flagged about that date: a public holiday, a long weekend, or a label you've added yourself. The blue arrows sit on the dates at the edge of each band.

Removing a date

Click any date card in This Build or Next Build to exclude it — the card turns pink and drops out of the build. Click it again to bring the date back. Cards in Last Build can't be removed this way, since they're already built.

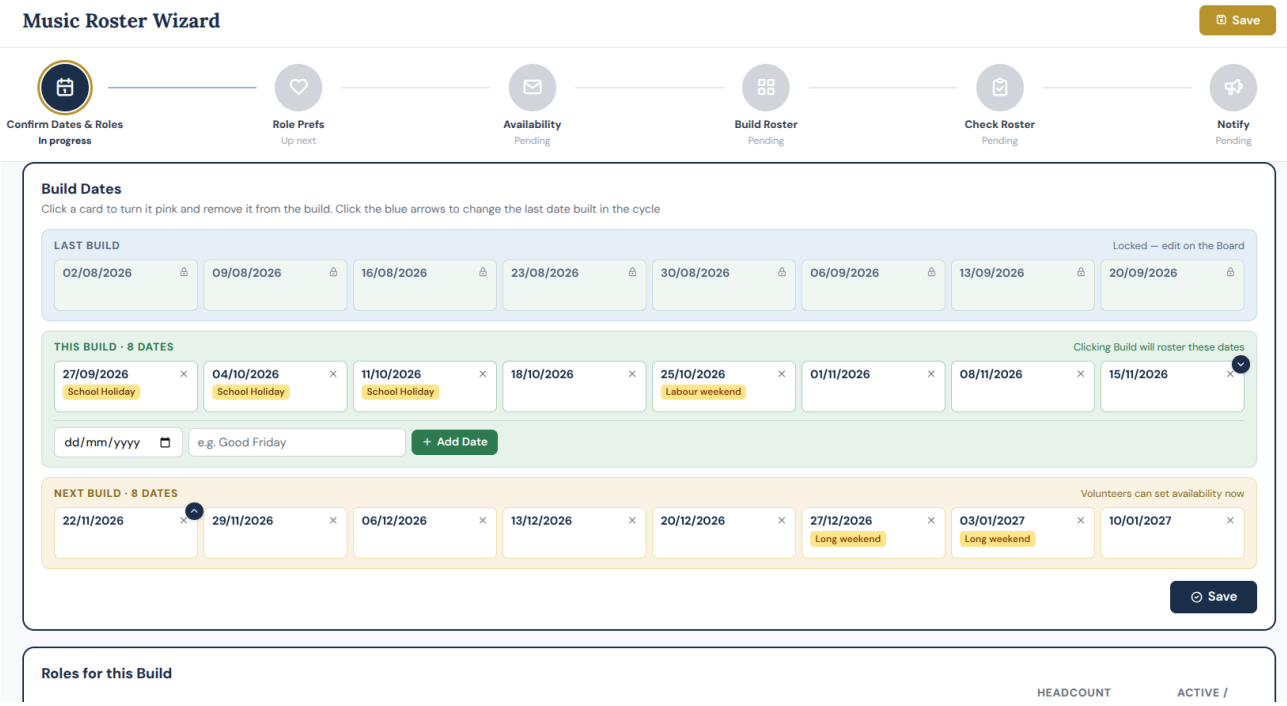
Shifting the boundary between builds

A small blue arrow sits on the date at the boundary between This Build and Next Build. Click it to move that date across the line — pulling the next upcoming date into This Build to extend how far this build reaches, or sending the last date of This Build back into Next Build to shorten it.

Adding an extra date

Use the date field and label box beneath This Build to add a one-off service outside the normal pattern — Christmas Eve, Good Friday, a special event. Pick the date, type a short label (e.g. "Good Friday"), and click **+ Add Date**. The new card appears in This Build with your label shown as a tag, and is included the next time you build.

Holidays are tagged automatically — but tagging and pausing aren't the same thing. Dates that fall directly on a public holiday or a school holiday are labelled for you, and look distinct from dates you've excluded by hand, so you can tell an automatic holiday from a deliberate choice. Long weekends (Labour Weekend, Anzac Weekend, and others) get their own distinct yellow tag too — but the tag alone doesn't pause anything. Only a **direct hit** on the public holiday or school holiday itself pauses the roster (and only if you've ticked **Pause public holidays** / **Pause school holidays** for this roster type). A long-weekend Sunday that isn't itself the public holiday still needs rostering as normal — exclude it by hand if you don't want it covered.



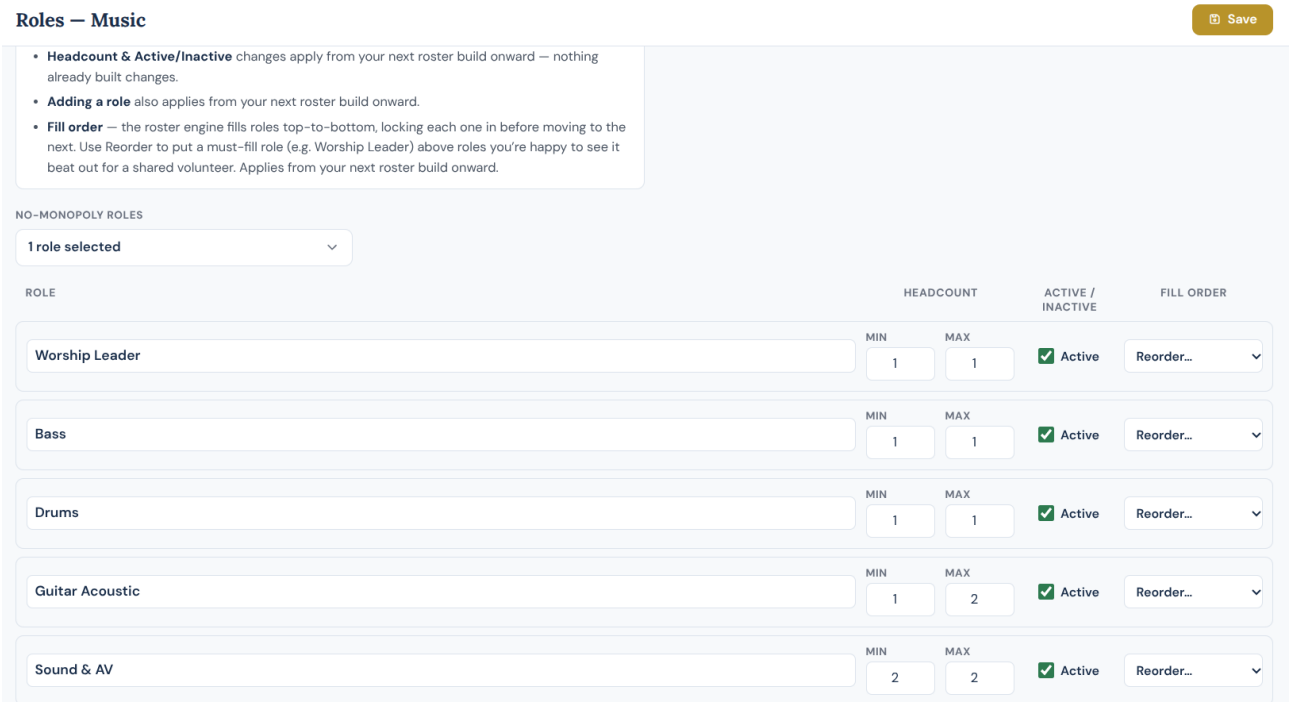
Excluding a date — a common example is the Sunday just after Christmas, when most people are away: click the × to turn it pink and it drops out of the build.

Confirm early. Ideally do this a few weeks before the dates arrive, so there's time to collect availability and build. A **perpetual** roster rolls forward on its own, so each cycle you're simply confirming the next stretch of dates; a **fixed-term** roster is confirmed up to its end date. (See Frequency & Season Type for the difference.)

Nothing changes until you save. Removing, shifting, or adding dates only takes effect once you click **Continue to Roles →** (in the wizard) or **Save** (when you opened Manage Dates from the ⋯ menu) — leaving without saving discards your changes. When you open this screen standalone via Manage Dates, saved changes apply from the next build onward; dates already built are never altered.

Managing Roles

Once a roster exists, you can add, rename, re-size, reorder or retire its roles at any time. Open the **Builds** dashboard, click the ⋯ menu on the roster's row, and choose **Manage roles**. The page lists every role for that roster with its headcount and an active switch.



The Manage roles page — each role shows its Headcount (the minimum and maximum people to roster) and an Active / Inactive switch. The engine always tries to fill the minimum and never exceeds the maximum.

Fill order — which role gets first pick

Rostas fills roles **top-to-bottom** in the order they're listed here — locking each one in fully before moving to the next. If a volunteer is capable of more than one role on a roster, whichever role sits higher in this list gets first claim on them for that date.

Use the **Fill Order** control on any role — **Move to top / Move up / Move down / Move to bottom** — to change where it sits. This matters most for a role with a thin, shared bench: putting it higher gives it first pick of your multi-capable volunteers instead of leftovers.

Reordering redistributes, it doesn't create capacity. Moving a role up can close its own shortfall, but only by taking a shared volunteer away from whatever role used to get them first. See Insights for exactly which role would carry that cost before you decide.

Changes apply from your next build onward. Renaming a role, changing its headcount, switching it active or inactive, or adding a new role all take effect at the next build — dates you've already built keep their original roles and wording. Nothing changes underneath the volunteers you've already notified.

Deactivate rather than delete. Deactivating a role keeps the full history of who served in it; it just stops appearing in new builds. Reach for deactivate unless you're correcting a genuine setup mistake.

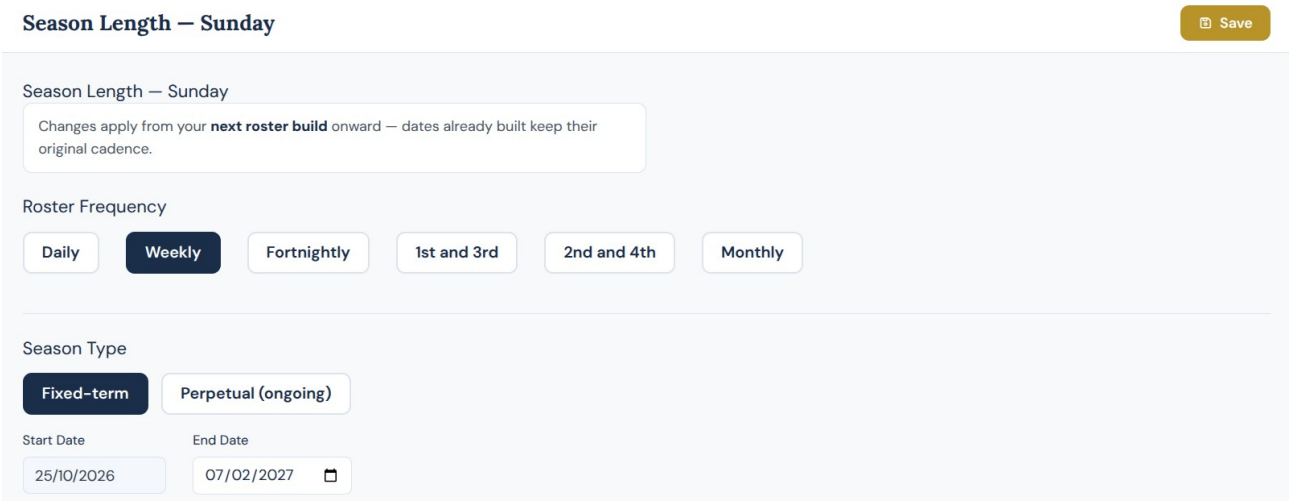
Mind the timing when renaming mid-cycle. Because a rename only affects messages sent after it, volunteers already notified will have the old name in their earlier email or text. If you rename partway through a cycle, expect a brief mismatch until the next build.

Season Length & Season Type

There are two separate frequency ideas in Rostas: how often the *roster* runs, and how often each *volunteer* serves. This section covers the roster side — its cadence and whether the season is fixed or ongoing. The per-volunteer cap is set on each person's profile (see Frequency on the Profile detail page); the two are explained together at the end.

Roster cadence — how often the roster runs

Not every roster runs weekly. A community meal might run fortnightly, a kids' ministry only on the 1st and 3rd Sunday, a review team monthly. The **Roster Frequency** setting on the **Season Length** page sets this cadence per roster type — it decides which dates appear in the season, and therefore which dates Rostas builds for. You reach it two ways: when you first create a roster (the Season step of the New Roster Wizard), or any time afterwards from the Builds dashboard — ⋯ — Season Length.



The Season Length page — Roster Frequency pills across the top, and the Season Type control below. A fixed-term season also shows its Start Date and End Date. Click Save at the top right. Changes apply from your next roster build onward; dates already built keep their original cadence.

> **Cadence is set once per roster type** and applies to everyone in it. If two groups run on different weeks, set them up as separate roster types.

Season type — fixed-term or perpetual

Below the cadence pills, the **Season Type** control decides whether this roster has an end or simply keeps going:

> **Perpetual seasons roll forward on their own** — the end date is maintained by Rostas, so you never have to extend them. Most ongoing church rosters (Sunday service, welcome team) suit Perpetual. If you later need a perpetual roster to stop on a set date, switch it to Fixed-term and give it an end date.

Volunteer frequency cap — how often a person serves

Separate from the roster's cadence, each volunteer has their own cap — how often *they* personally get rostered — so nobody is used every week just because they're always free. You set it on each person's profile (Frequency on the Profile detail page), independently for each roster they serve in. The two settings work together:

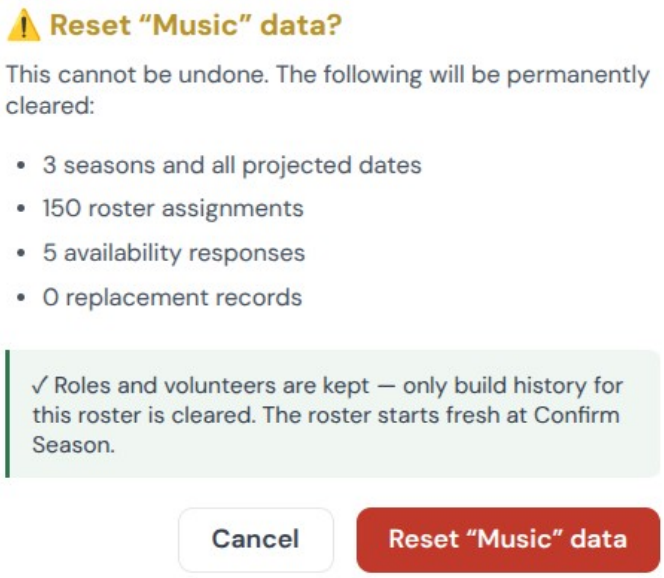
> **The cap counts distinct service dates**, not individual roles. A volunteer in two roles on the same date counts as one service — so serving twice on one Sunday doesn't use two of their allocation.

Resetting Roster Data

Reset roster data clears a roster type's operational history — built assignments, availability responses, replacement chains — without touching the roster's setup: its roles, volunteers, and season stay exactly as they are. It's a pick → preview → confirm flow: choose the roster type, review what will be cleared, then confirm. Afterwards the roster's state button on the Builds dashboard reads **First Setup** again, ready for a fresh first build. (A paused roster stays Paused.)

> **Built for getting started.** This is the tool for wiping sample or test data before a roster goes live — clear out anything built while you were setting up, then start rostering for real without deleting and re-creating the whole roster type.

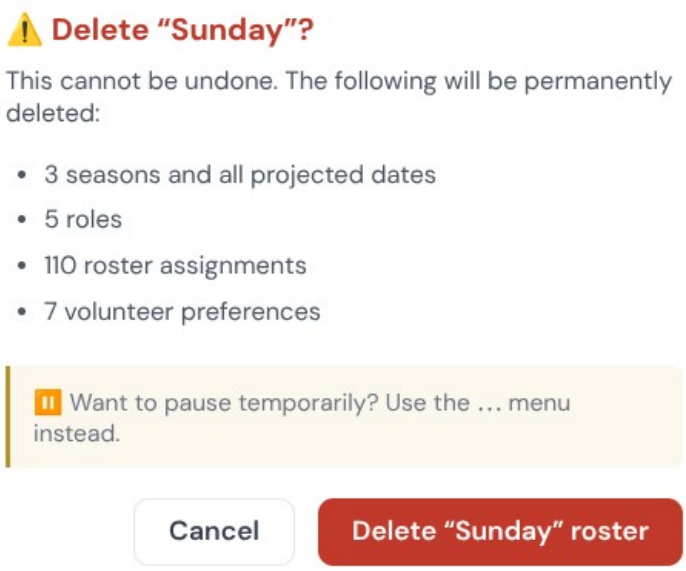
> **Reset vs Delete.** Reset clears history but keeps the roster type itself — its roles and volunteer assignments to it survive. Delete removes the roster type entirely — see Deleting a Roster below. If you're clearing out test data before going live, Reset is almost always what you want.



The Reset roster data confirmation — preview what will be cleared before you commit.

Deleting a Roster

Delete roster permanently removes the roster type — its shell, roles, seasons, build history, and every assignment tied to it. Unlike Reset, there's no going back.



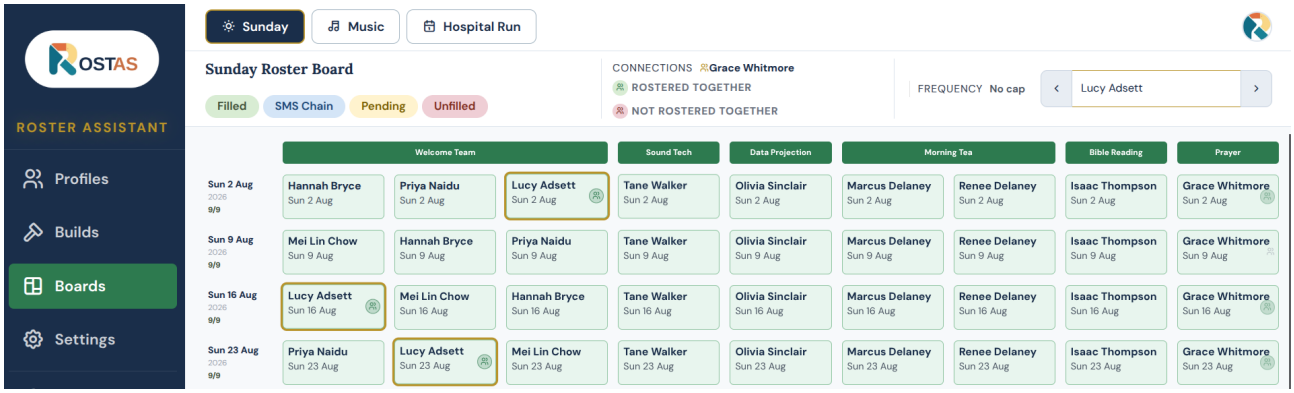
Deleting a roster asks you to confirm, and lists exactly what will be removed — seasons, roles, assignments, and preferences, with real counts. It also nudges you toward pausing instead if you only need a temporary break.

> **Deleting is permanent.** If you only need to stop a roster for a while — over summer, say — use **Pause** from the ⋯ menu instead. Pausing keeps all the roster's history and settings; deleting removes them for good.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **Boards** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.



The Roster Board — dates run down the left, role columns across the top with green headers. Use the roster type tabs at the very top to switch between rosters. The legend and frequency search are in the header row above the grid.

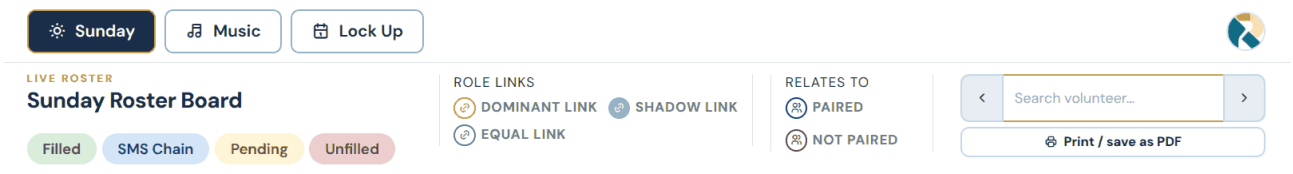
> **White isn't the same as Red.** A red cell is an unfilled slot that needs a volunteer. A white row is a date you deliberately excluded — usually in the Confirm Dates step, turning a chip pink there. The Board just carries that decision through: the row stays blank on purpose, so it doesn't get mistaken for a gap. White rows aren't clickable — there's no assignment to act on.

Legend and Frequency

The legend row at the top of the board shows the four colours (white excluded dates have no chip of their own). To the right, the **volunteer search** (with ◀ ▶ navigation arrows) lets you find a specific person and step through volunteers one by one. The **Frequency** panel shows how often the currently searched volunteer is rostered and when they were last assigned.

Printing the roster

Under the search box is a **Print / save as PDF** button. It opens the roster you're looking at in a new tab: every date on the board as a row and every role as a column, with everyone's names — ready to print for a noticeboard or hand out. Weeks with no service say so, and people who declined are left out.



The top of the Roster Board: the legend on the left (Filled, SMS Chain, Pending, Unfilled), and Print / save as PDF under the volunteer search.

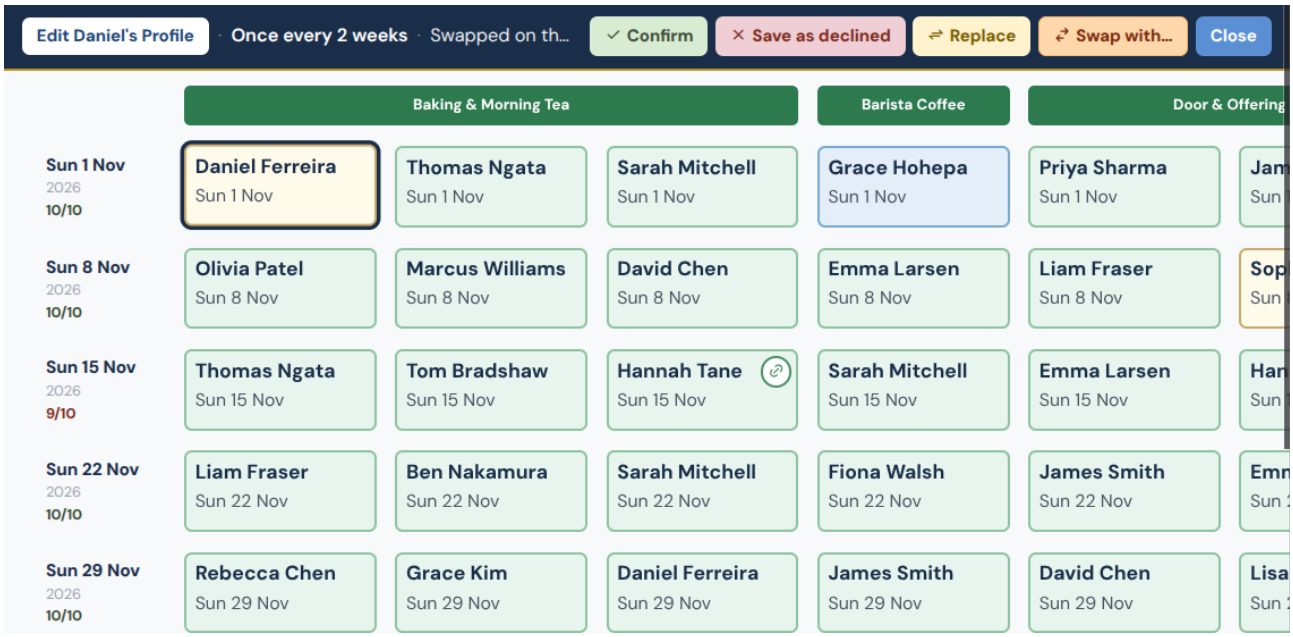
Click **Print / save as PDF** at the top of that page. It prints on A4 landscape, and the column headings repeat on every page. To make a PDF instead, choose **Save as PDF** as the printer.

Taking Action on a Cell

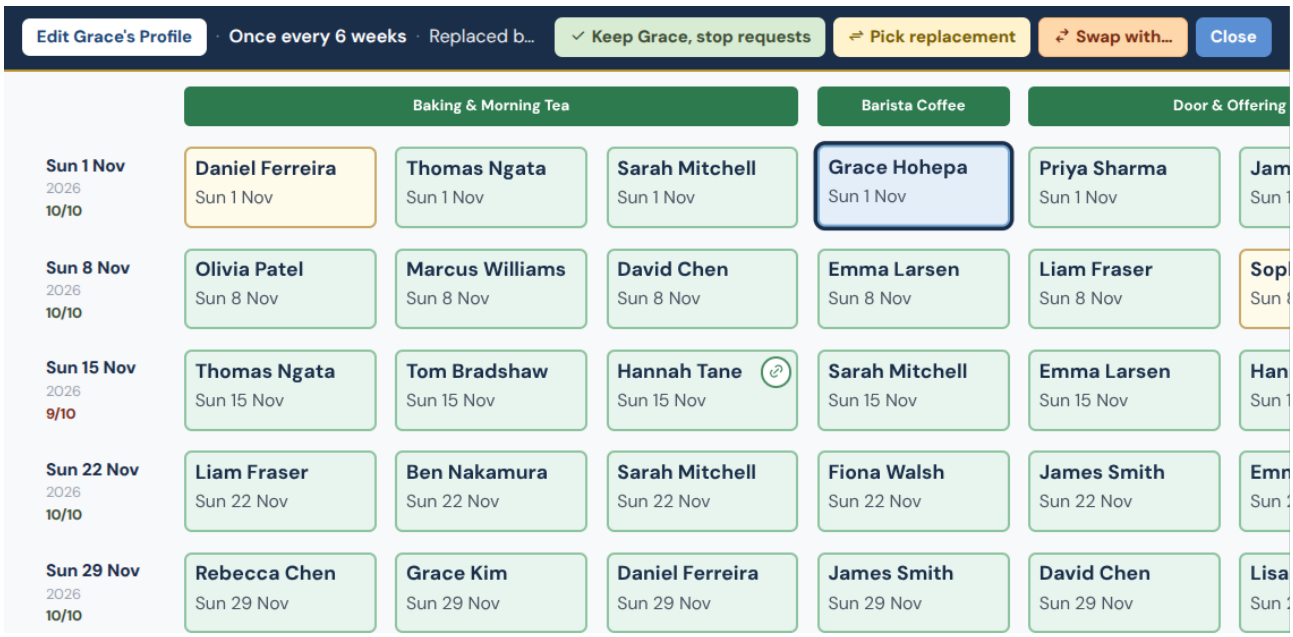
Click any card on the Board to select it. The card gets a navy border and an action bar appears above the green role headings, showing who is on the card, their frequency and any recent change, with buttons on the right. The buttons depend on the card: a Filled card has nothing to confirm, so it shows no fill button at all.



A Filled card selected. The action bar shows Save as declined, Replace and Swap with...; there's no fill button because the card is already Filled.



A Pending card selected. Confirm appears first, then the same buttons as a Filled card.

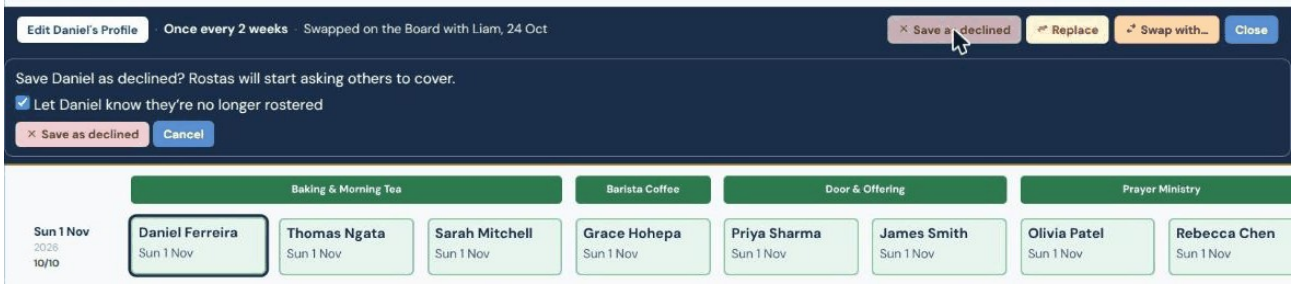


A card in an SMS chain (blue) selected. Keep Grace, stop requests keeps her on; Pick replacement lets you choose who covers instead of waiting for replies.

Confirm, Undo decline and Keep [name] also close open requests. If Rostas had already asked other volunteers to cover that slot, those requests are closed. Anyone who says Yes later is told someone else has already stepped in, so two people don't turn up. (On a card with any other status the same button reads **Save as filled**.)

Saving someone as declined

When a volunteer tells you they can't make it, click their card and choose **Save as declined**. A confirm step opens under the action bar before anything changes. Click **Save as declined** again to go ahead, or **Cancel**.



The decline confirm step. "Let [Name] know they're no longer rostered" is ticked to start with.

- **Let [Name] know they're no longer rostered** starts ticked. If that date's roster has already gone out, Rostas sends them an app notification, or a text with a link to their roster if they don't have the app. Untick it if you've already spoken to them.
- If the roster for that date hasn't gone out yet, nothing is sent and the Board tells you so. They simply won't be on the roster when it's sent.
- Rostas then starts the SMS replacement chain to find someone to cover. If the roster is paused, the card waits for you instead.

When the roster changes while the Board is open

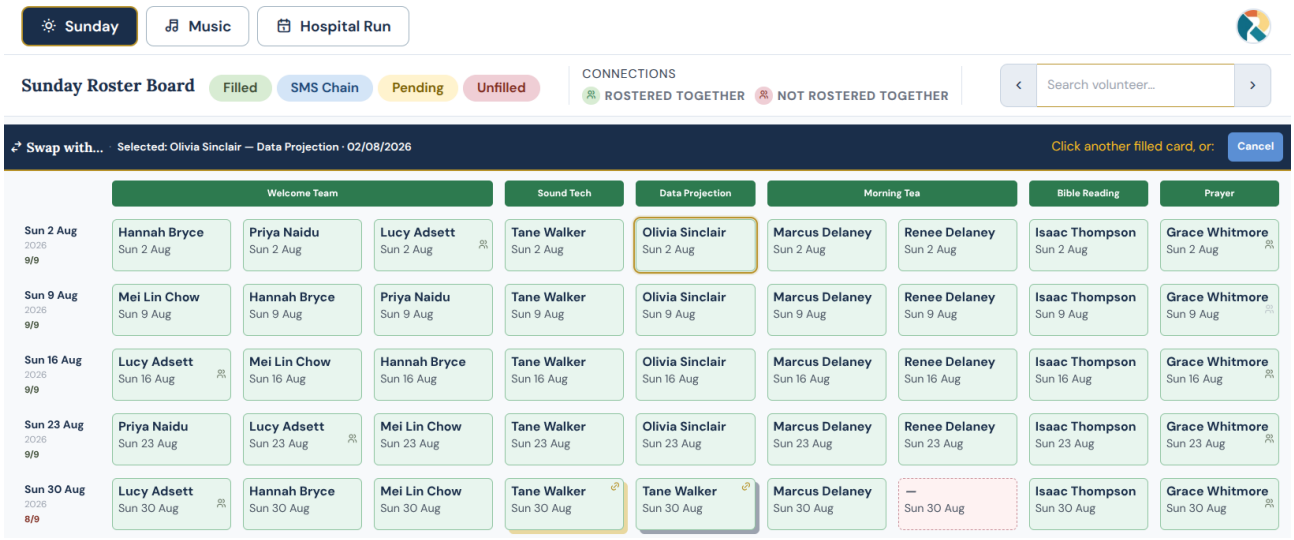
Volunteers answer texts and emails at any time, and other coordinators may be working on the same roster, so the Board keeps itself up to date:

- **It refreshes by itself.** Every 30 seconds, and whenever you come back to the tab, the Board checks for changes (a volunteer's Yes, a decline, another coordinator's change) and redraws in place.
- **If you have a card open**, it doesn't redraw under you. A bar at the top says "*The roster has changed since you opened the Board*" with a **Reload** button.
- **Each card is checked when you click it.** If it changed since the Board loaded, a red note says what it shows now and the buttons are greyed out; reload the Board first. If Rostas is in the middle of asking someone to cover it, a yellow note says who and when their reply is due.
- **Saves never undo a volunteer's answer.** If someone said Yes to that slot after your Board loaded, your change is refused and the Board reloads so you can see who's on it now.

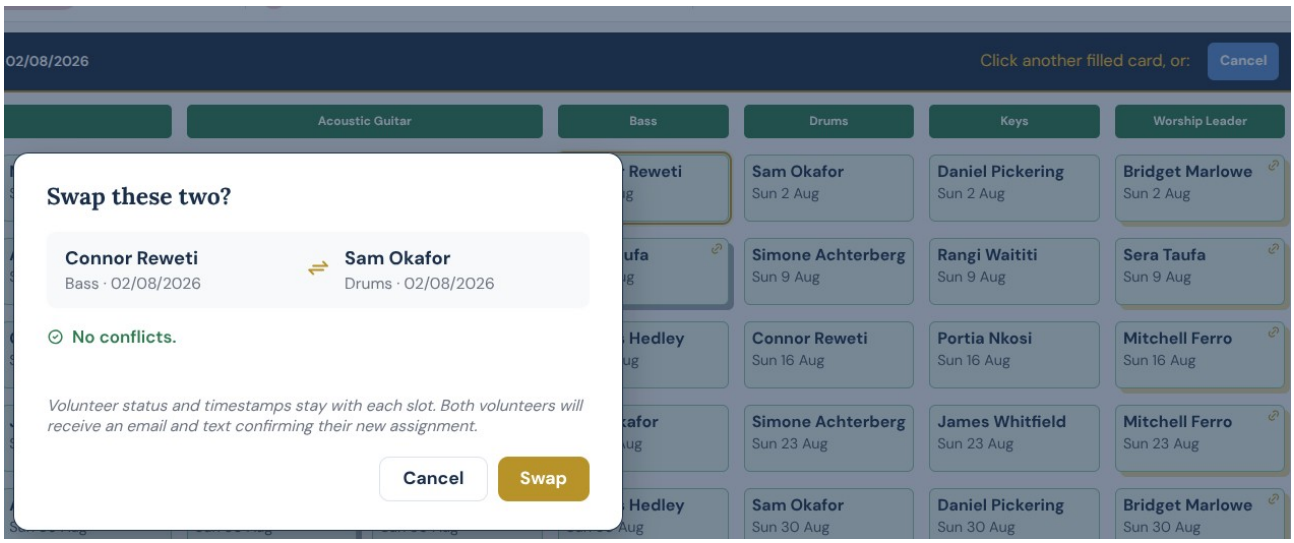
The coloured messages the Board shows after a save stay up for 10 seconds.

Swapping two volunteers

When two rostered volunteers want to trade dates, use **Swap with…** from the action menu. Click the first volunteer's cell, choose Swap with…, and that card is "armed" — it takes a gold border. Then click the cell you want to swap it with.

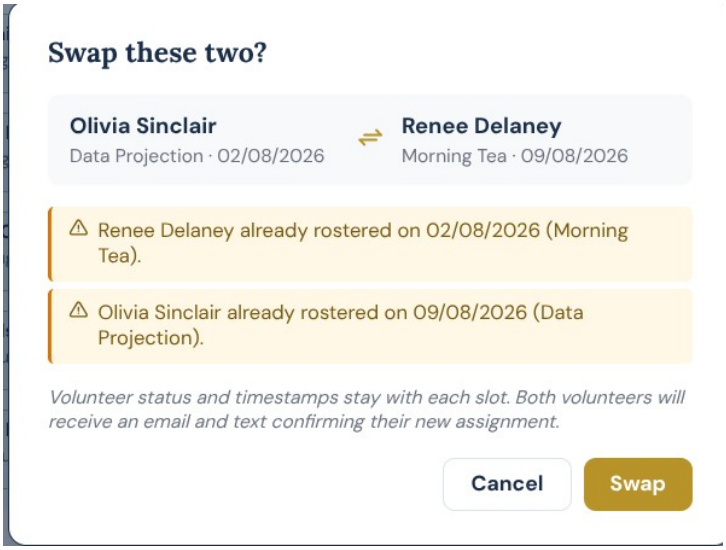


A card armed for swap — its gold border means Rostas is waiting for you to pick the card to swap it with.



A confirmation shows both volunteers, their roles and dates, so you can check the trade before committing.

Conflict warnings are advisory, not blocking. If a swap would clash — say a volunteer is already rostered elsewhere that day — Rostas shows amber warnings on the confirmation, but you can still go ahead. It flags the risk and leaves the decision to you.



A swap with conflicts — the amber warnings inform you, but the swap button stays available.

Manual Replacement

When you click **Replace** (or **Assign volunteer** on an Unfilled card), the replacement panel opens below the action bar. It shows everyone who could cover that role on that date, grouped into coloured bands down the left, best fit first. Each card shows the person's name and how recently they've been rostered. Click a person to choose them.



The replacement panel. The bands down the left say why each person is offered; click a person to choose them. Up to seven cards fit across a band, then they wrap onto a new row.



Further down the panel: No role set (tan), Another roster, Already on today and No roster (purple).

Finding someone by name

The **Search names** box at the top of the panel narrows the cards as you type. Bands with nobody matching are hidden, and if nobody matches at all the panel says "No one by that name." Clear the box with its × to see everyone again.



Typing "Sarah" leaves just the matching cards, still in their bands.

> **Both people are told automatically.** If this roster's notifications have already gone out, Rostas tells the new person straight away (an app notification if they have the app, otherwise a text and an email). The person you took off is told they're no longer rostered (an app notification, or a text with a link to their roster). If you haven't sent notifications yet, nobody is messaged; the roster simply shows the new person when you send it (Step 6).

Asking a volunteer from another roster

The **Another roster** and **No roster** bands, both marked *Contact first*, offer people who aren't part of this roster: a Music volunteer showing up for a Sunday gap, for example, or someone in Profiles with no roster ticked.

> **This is a one-off ask, not an addition to the roster.** Choosing someone in these bands sends them a one-off request for this single date — the same app/SMS/email delivery as everywhere else — but doesn't add them to the roster. Use it for genuine gap-filling, and it's worth a heads-up to the volunteer (and their usual coordinator) first, since it crosses roster boundaries.

Assigning a Second Role on the Same Date

Occasionally a volunteer may need to cover two roles on the same date — for example, stepping in for a missing team member while also serving in their usual role. Rostas supports this but flags it clearly so you're making a deliberate choice rather than an accidental double-booking.



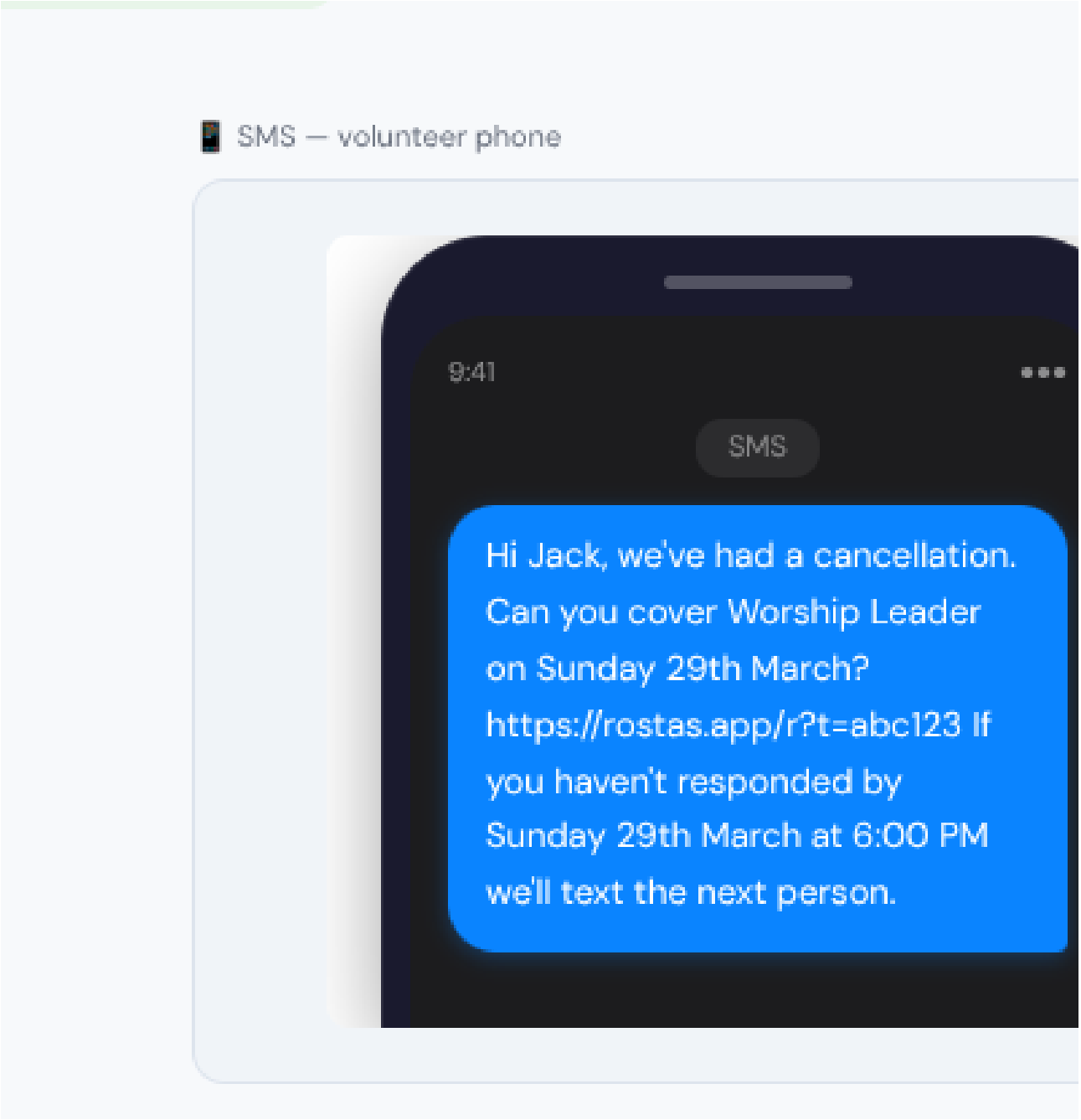
A volunteer holding two roles on one date — Rostas shows both assignments clearly so it reads as a deliberate choice.

> Use this sparingly. Volunteers serving in multiple roles in one service can feel stretched. Always confirm with the volunteer before assigning a second role.

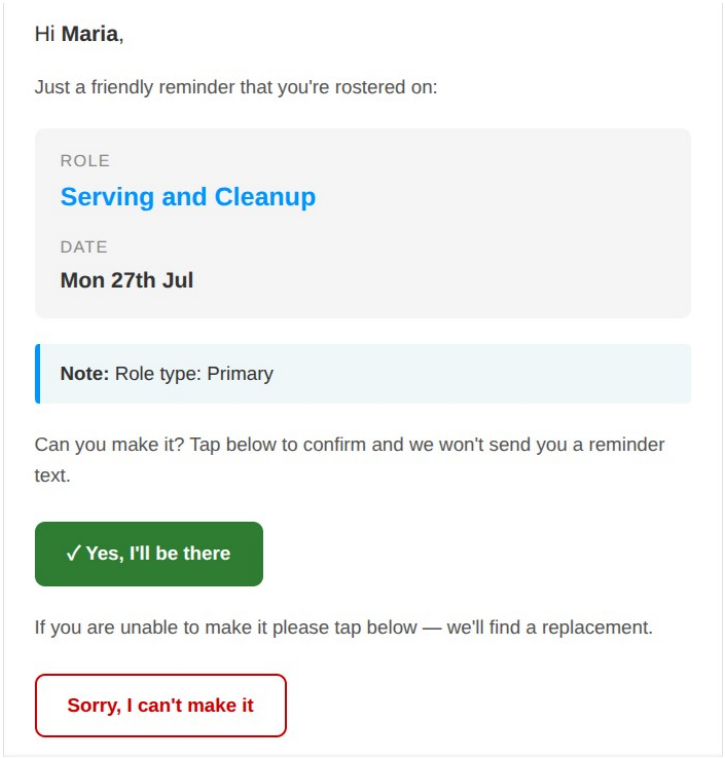
The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their notification email — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

The request text carries a **direct personalised link** straight to the accept / decline page — see Part A for the full explanation.



The replacement request SMS — it carries a direct link to the accept / decline page.



The page a volunteer reaches after tapping "Can't make it" — two clear options. If they changed their mind they can reinstate themselves on the spot.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent during your quiet hours (set in Settings → Timing & behaviour, default 9pm–8am). If the chain reaches a volunteer inside that window it pauses automatically and resumes once quiet hours end. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Searching for a Volunteer

Use the search field at the top right of the board to find a specific volunteer. As you type, their assignments are highlighted across the entire board — making it easy to see all their upcoming dates at once. Use the ◀ ▶ arrows to step through volunteers alphabetically. The Frequency panel shows how often the current volunteer is rostered and when they last served.



Searching a volunteer highlights every one of their assignments across the board, so you can see their whole schedule at a glance.

> **Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement.** Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar. It opens on the **Status** page, so you see straight away whether anything needs attention (see Using System Status). Click any category chip to get to the settings themselves.

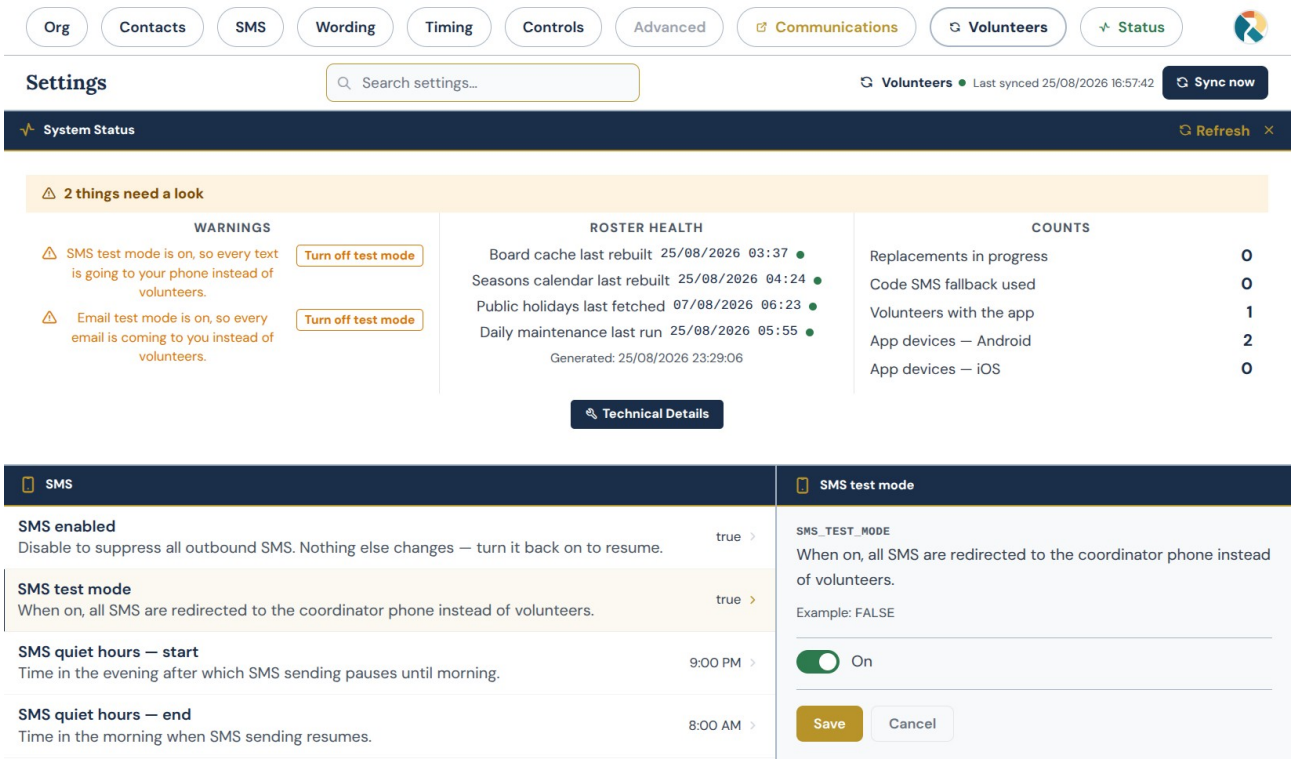
The Settings View

Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

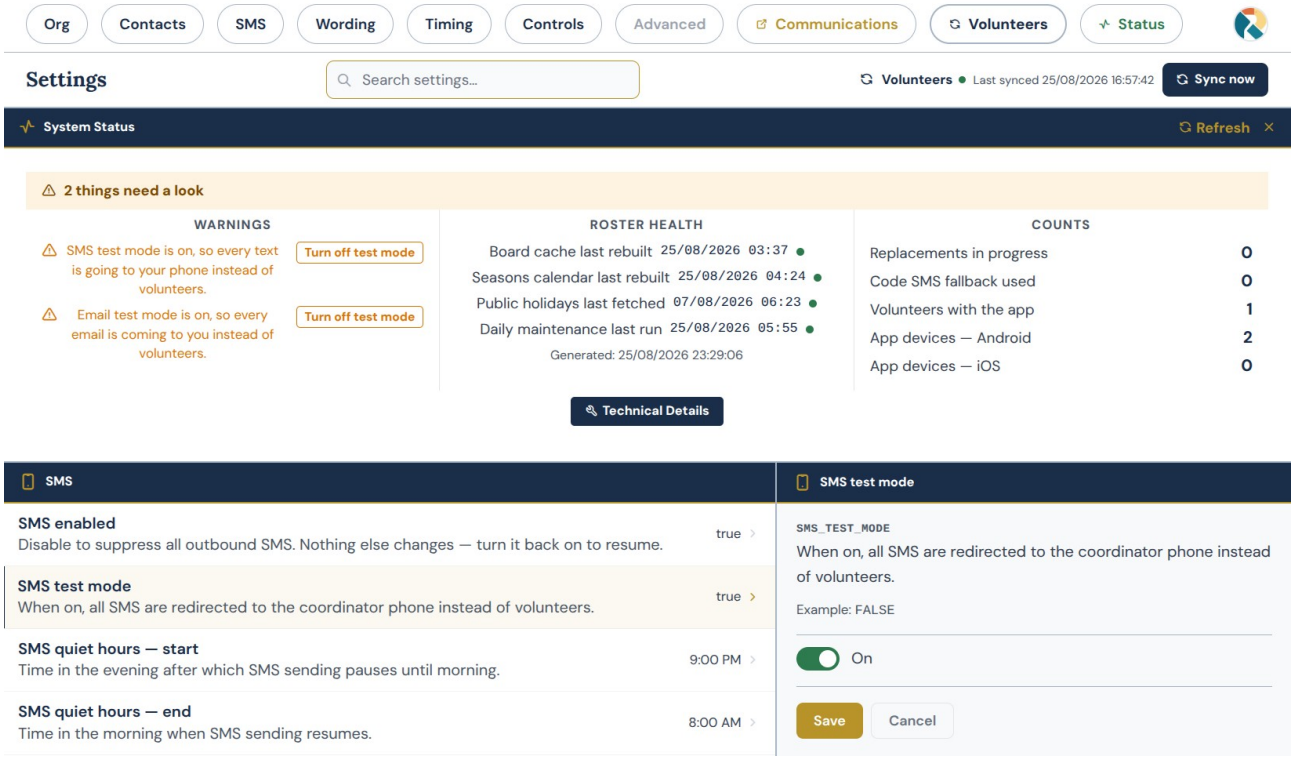
The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, App, Email, Timing, Controls, Advanced and Status. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly; **Status** takes you back to the Status page. The gold **Comms** chip (with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings…") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.



The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview. Any warnings show in a yellow strip above the list, with an Open System Status link.

The two-column layout

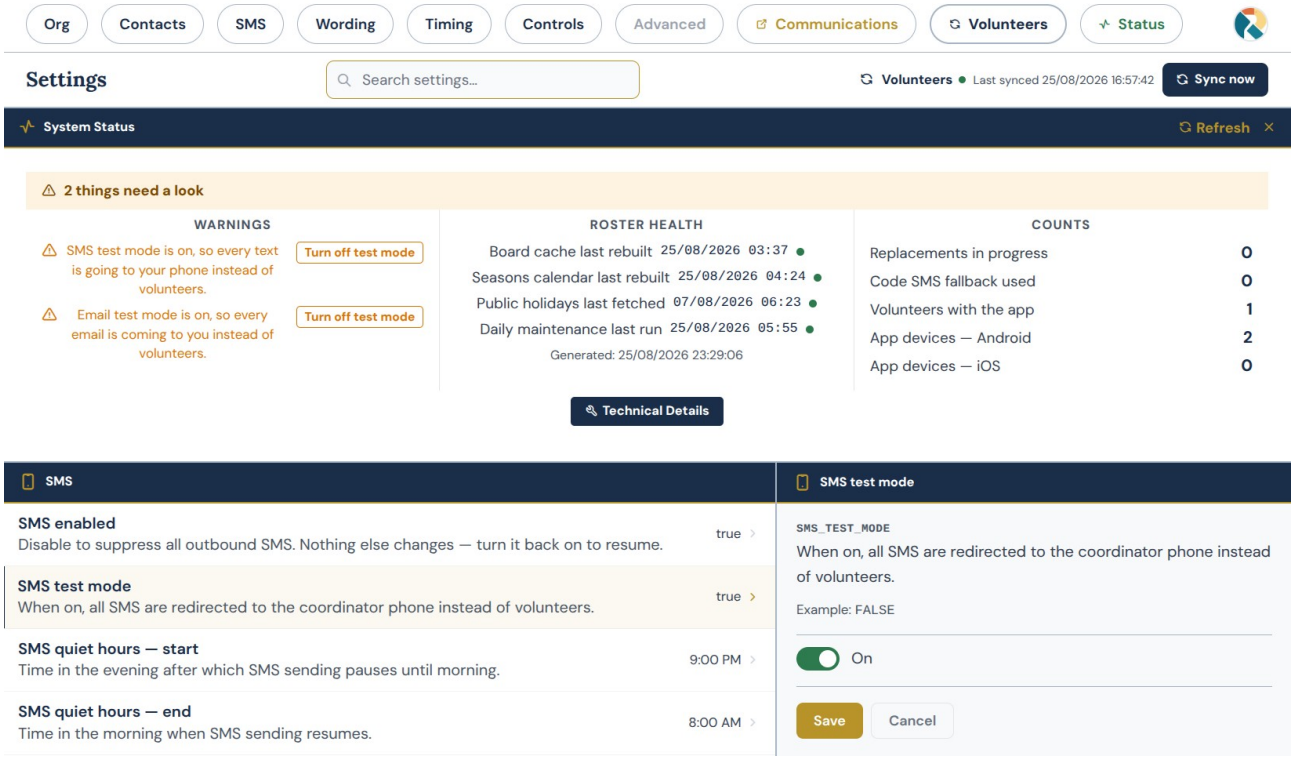


The two-column layout — categories and settings in the scrollable left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the sticky right panel.

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting



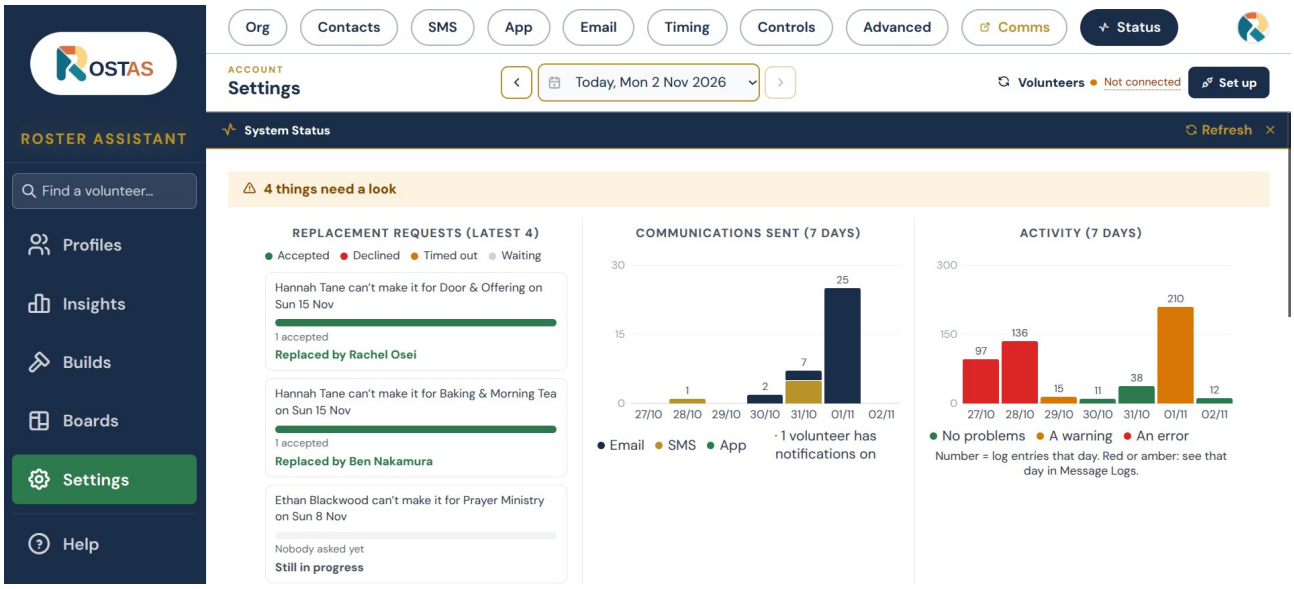
The right panel — key name at top, friendly label, full description, example value, and the input field. Validation runs as you type. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.

15. Click the row in the left panel. The right panel opens showing the setting name, description, and current value pre-filled in the input.
16. Make your change. The input type matches the setting — dropdowns for timezone and country code, toggles for on/off settings, text fields for everything else.
17. Validation runs as you type or on blur. If the value is invalid (wrong format, missing required content) the field turns red with an explanation. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.
18. Click **Save**. The left panel updates immediately to show the new value — no page reload needed.

Using System Status

Settings opens on the Status page, so it's the first thing you see every time. Read it from the top down:

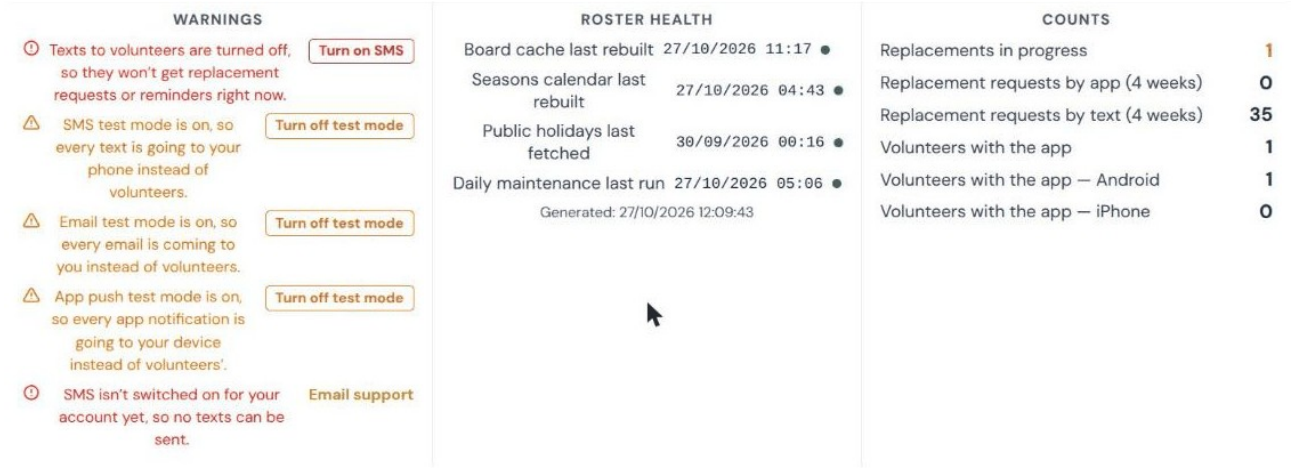
19. **The verdict** — one line at the top. Green means nothing needs a look; amber or red says how many things do.
20. **Three charts**: Replacement Requests, Communications Sent and Activity (see below).
21. **Message Logs** — what Rostas sent today and how people answered.
22. **Warnings, Roster Health and Counts** — the three columns at the bottom.



Settings opens on Status: the verdict, then the three charts. Message Logs and the warnings are further down.

Settings opens on the settings list instead when you arrive at a particular setting (for example from a warning's button or a Comms link), or while the set-up checklist is still showing for a new church.

If the verdict is green, carry on with whatever you came to do. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.



The three columns at the bottom of Status — current warnings with their fix buttons, roster health indicators, and counts. (This demo church has its test modes on, so it shows several warnings.)

Following a warning to its fix

Each warning in the System Status card says in plain words what's wrong, and most carry their own button that takes you straight to the setting that fixes it:

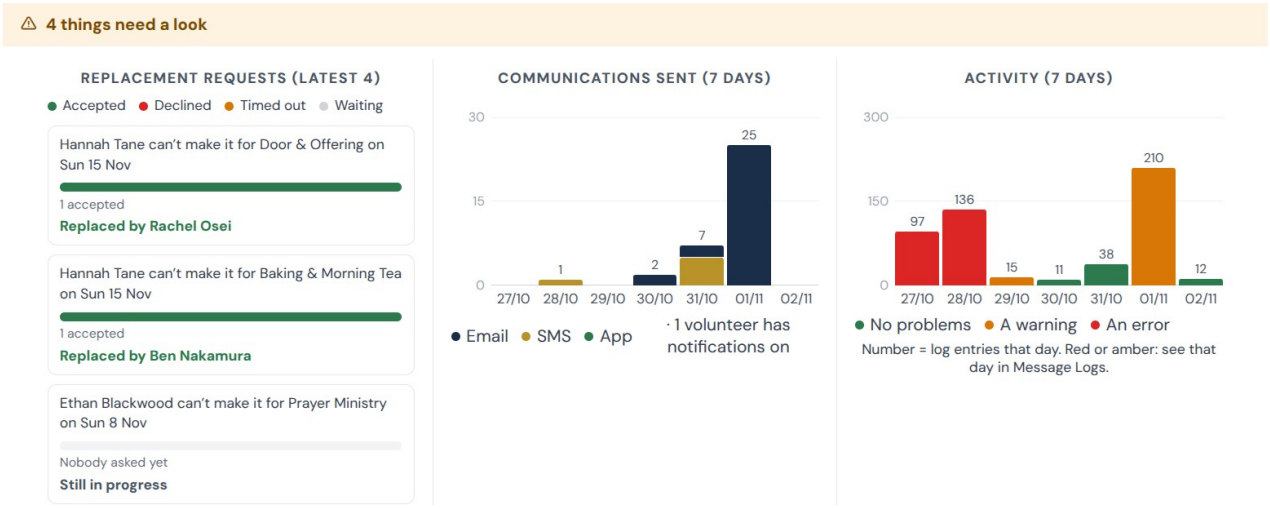
The typical workflow is: read the warning → click its button → save the setting that opens. If a warning has no button, the search bar above the settings list finds the setting by name.

After making a change, check the card again

The Status page doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click the **Status** chip, then **Refresh** in the System Status header, to confirm the warning has cleared.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

Once warnings are clear, the rest of the page gives you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand. Start with the three charts at the top:



The three charts at the top of Status, each with a key of coloured dots.

- **Replacement Requests (latest 4)** — a card for each of the four most recent requests, newest first, however long ago they started. Each card says who couldn't make it ("Hannah Tane can't make it for Door & Offering on Sun 15 Nov"), then a bar of how the people asked to cover it answered: accepted (green), declined (red), didn't reply in time (amber) and still being asked (grey). Underneath, it says how the request ended: **Replaced by [name]**: that volunteer said yes. **Replaced on the Board by [name]**: you picked someone yourself on the Roster Board. **Still in progress**: Rostas is still asking. "Nobody asked yet" means the first ask hasn't gone out yet. **Ended without a replacement**: everyone suitable was asked, the date has passed, or a newer request started for the same slot. Lots of amber across the cards can mean your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers reply, or that quiet hours leave too small a sending window.
- **Communications Sent (7 days)** — how many messages went to volunteers each day: emails (navy), texts (gold) and app notifications (green). An app notification counts as App only when it was delivered; if it fell back to a text, it counts as SMS. Next to the key it says how many volunteers have the app with notifications on, so an empty green part can simply mean nobody needed a notification that week.

- **Activity (7 days)** — one bar per day. The number is how many log entries Rostas wrote that day. The colour is the worst thing that happened: green for no problems, amber for at least one warning, red for at least one error. For a red or amber day, pick that day in Message Logs to see what went wrong.

Below the charts, two things are worth checking regularly:

- **Message Logs** — a table of what Rostas did today, oldest first: every reminder, replacement ask, swap and roster message, with who it went to, how it was sent and how they answered. Use the date picker to look at an earlier day, and tick **Show system events too** to include behind-the-scenes events such as volunteer syncs and roster builds. Click **Key: what the colours and labels mean** above the table for a full explanation. In short: a pale red row means something failed and a pale yellow row is a warning (both always shown); in the Response column, green means the volunteer said yes, gold means still waiting, amber means no reply in time, and red means declined or not sent. This is your first-stop diagnostic: if a volunteer says they didn't get a message, pick that day and look for them.
- **Communication Failures** — the most direct troubleshooting tool, shown in the Warnings column. When all is well it reads "No comms failures"; otherwise it lists recent send errors and warnings. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, check here for an entry on the date in question. If you see nothing at all for that date, the message may have been suppressed before sending — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours.

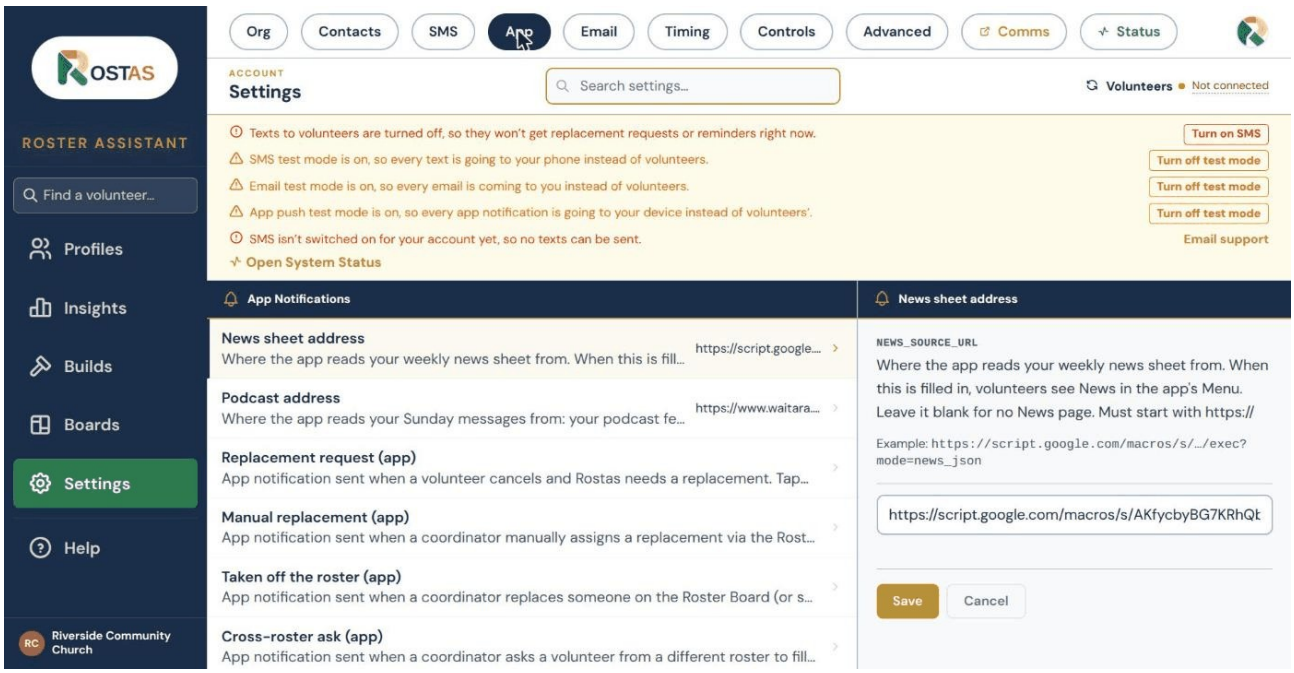
> Settings opening on Status makes this a habit without trying: glance at the verdict, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do. You'll catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, volunteer-facing logo, and the logo shown at the top of reminder emails (Email logo URL). The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Every email Rostas sends also comes from this name. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email and mobile, plus an optional coordinator for each roster (see A different coordinator for one roster). The “no replacement found” email goes to the **Organisation email** under Organisation, unless the roster has its own coordinator.
- **SMS** — the wording of every text Rostas sends (replacement request, manual replacement, taken off the roster, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder). Each has a live character counter and a placeholder check. See Message wording below.
- **App** — what volunteers see in the Rostas app. At the top are two addresses: **News sheet address** and **Podcast address** (see News and podcasts in the app). Below them is the wording of the app notifications that stand in for texts when a volunteer has the app.
- **Email wording** — the text blocks in roster, reminder and swap emails (intro, arrival note, sign-offs).
- **Timing & Behaviour** — each roster's service start time, how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing and day-before reminder texts, SMS quiet hours, replacement timers, and public holiday region. The **Public holidays region** field includes a dropdown of supported countries and a "Fetch holidays now" button — use this to pull the latest public holidays for your country whenever you update this setting.
- **Quick Controls** — the on/off switches: SMS enabled, the three test modes (SMS, Email, App push), and a switch to show or hide each roster type on the Builds dashboard and the Board. It also holds the **Volunteer database** row, where you connect Infoodle or Planning Center (see Choosing your volunteer database). Hiding a roster doesn't stop its reminders; to stop everything for a while, use **Pause roster** (Builds → ⋯).
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, licence key, roster type list, Infoodle and AWS SMS keys). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

News and podcasts in the app

The Rostas app can show your church's weekly news sheet and your recorded Sunday messages, as well as rosters. Each one is switched on by filling in an address under **Settings → App**:



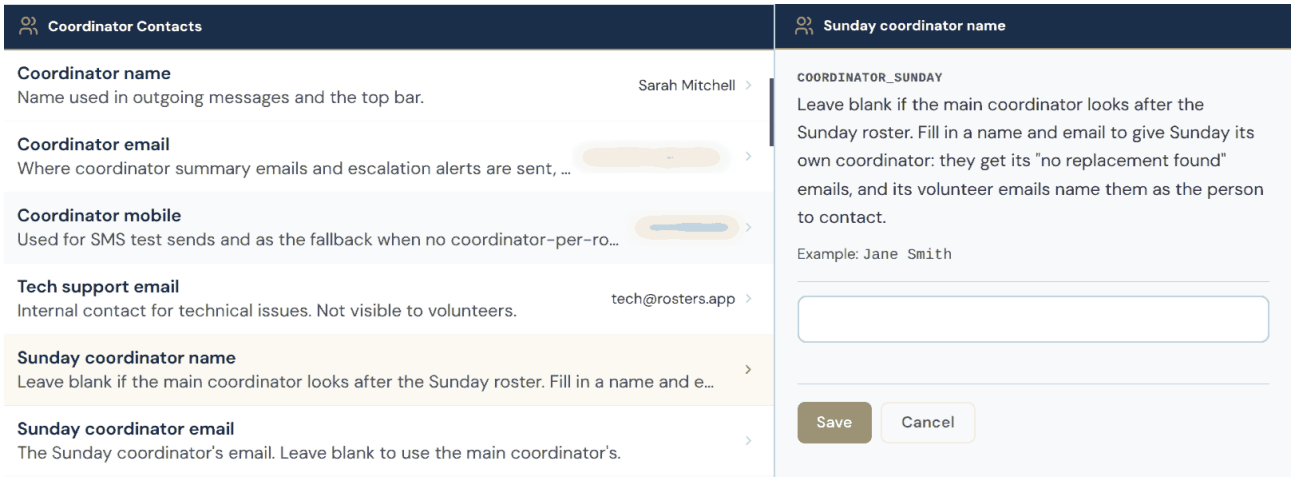
Settings → App. News sheet address and Podcast address sit at the top, above the app notification wording.

Leave an address blank and that page simply doesn't appear in the app. A changed address takes effect straight away for anyone who opens the page; volunteers' phones pick up a newly added Menu row within about three hours.

A different coordinator for one roster

You (the main coordinator) look after every roster unless you say otherwise. If one roster is run by someone else — say your music director runs the Music roster — give that roster its own coordinator:

23. Go to **Settings → Coordinator Contacts**.
24. Find that roster's tiles, e.g. **Music coordinator name**, **Music coordinator email** and **Music coordinator mobile**.
25. Fill in at least the name and email. Anything left blank uses your details.



Settings → Coordinator Contacts. Your own details come first; each roster's tiles follow. Leave a roster's tiles blank and you look after it.

From then on, for that roster only:

- the **“no replacement found”** email goes to them;
- volunteer emails for that roster (roster, reminder, availability, role preference and swap emails) say “get in touch with” them and are signed off with their name.

Everything else stays with you: emails that cover more than one roster, your coordinator link, and the test modes. Give each roster its own coordinator, or just the one or two that need it. To hand a roster back to yourself, clear its name and email.

SMS Settings in Detail

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

> **SMS enabled** (Quick Controls) — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if you need to pause sending temporarily).

> **SMS test mode** (Quick Controls) — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end (Settings → Timing & behaviour) are set as times of day, e.g. 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM. Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

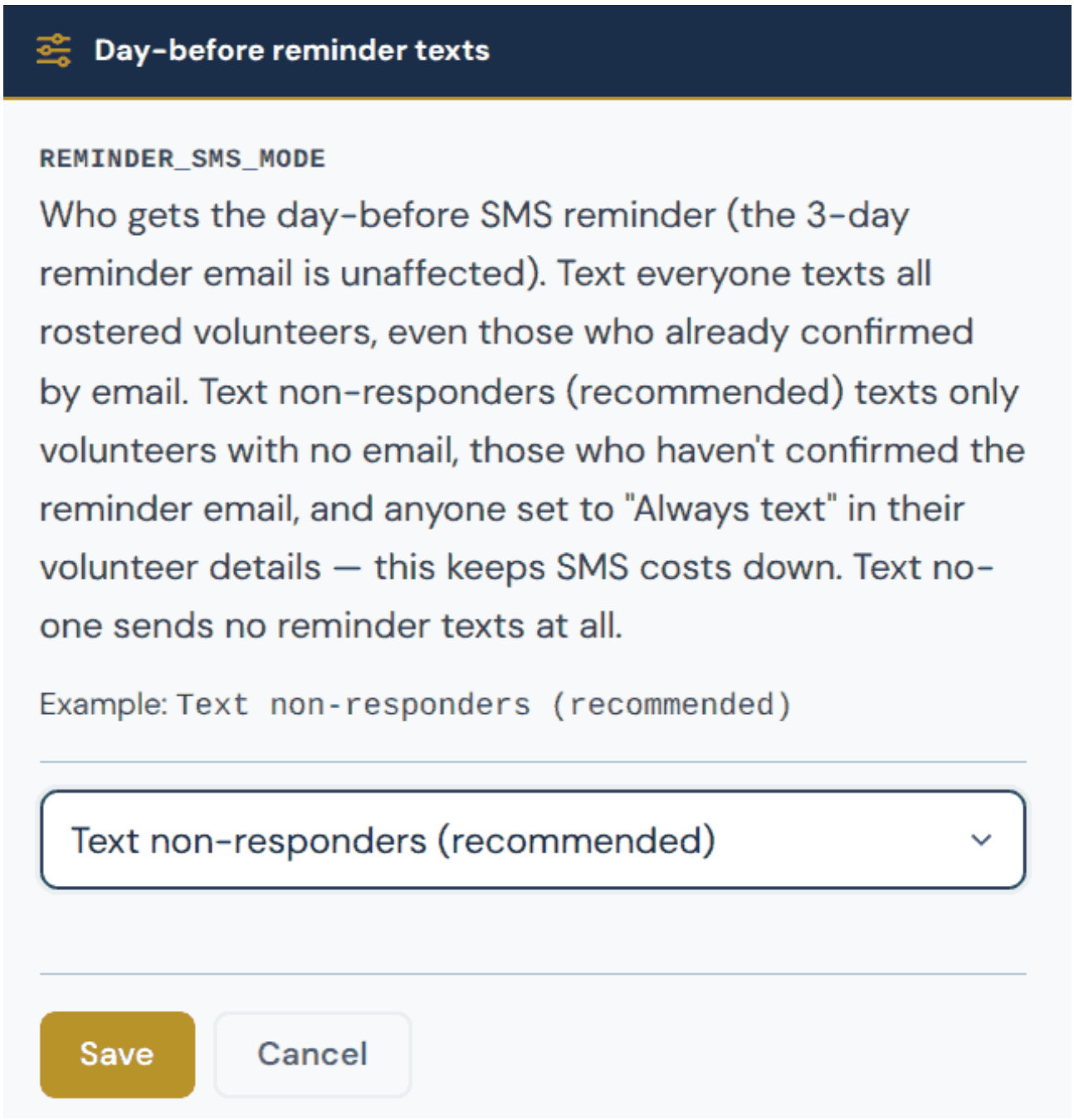
Replacement timers (Settings → Timing & behaviour) — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Reminder SMS mode — controlling reminder texts

The day-before reminder text is the single biggest driver of SMS cost — one text per rostered volunteer, every service. The **Day-before reminder texts** setting (Settings → Timing & behaviour) decides who actually receives it. (The 3-day reminder *email* is unaffected and still goes to everyone with an email address.)

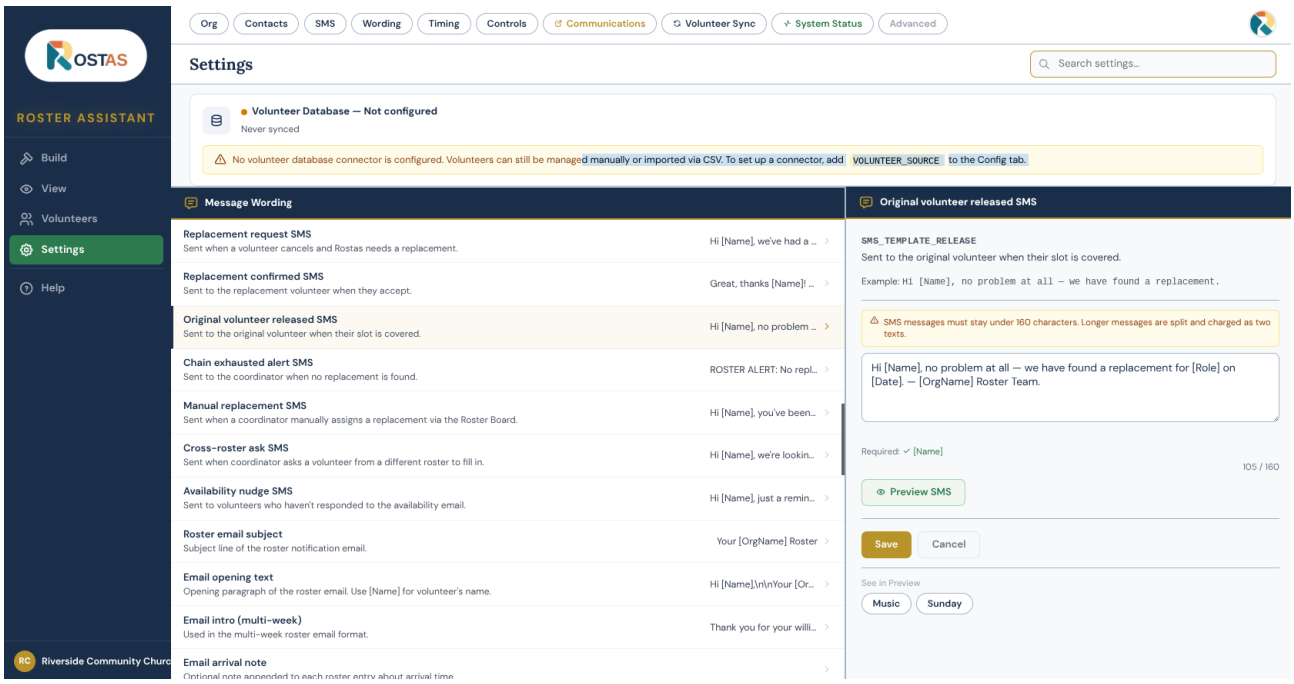


Reminder SMS mode — choose who gets the day-before text.

Text non-responders is the default, and the best value for most churches. It leans on free email and only spends a text where it'll actually help — someone with no email, or who hasn't confirmed. For the few volunteers who reliably miss email, turn on "Always text" on their profile so they still get a text under Text non-responders.

Message wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.

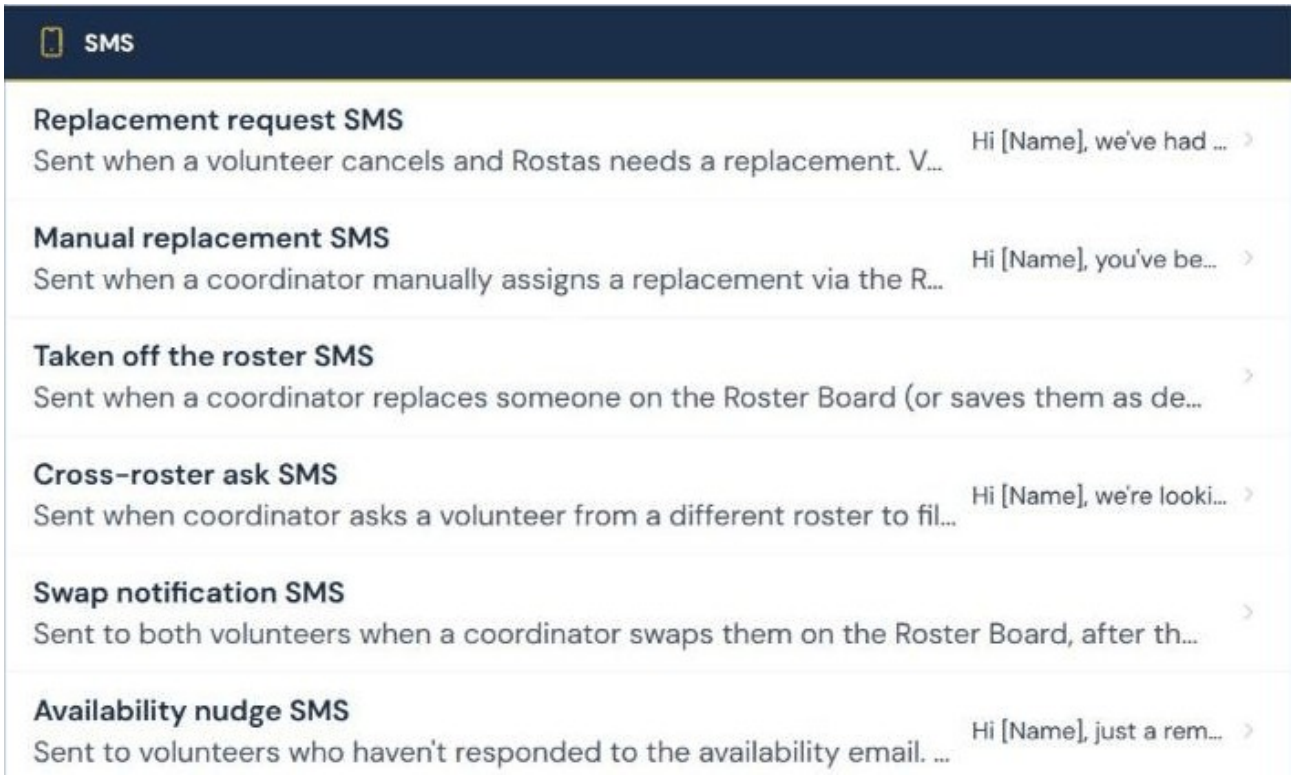


SMS template fields show a live character counter (105/160 in this example), the required placeholder list, and a Preview SMS button. The Save button is disabled if the message exceeds 160 characters or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Character counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea turns amber at 140 characters and red at 161+. The Save button is disabled when the count is red. The SMS templates are deliberately terse for this reason — when you edit one, the counter is protecting your church's SMS costs, not just formatting. One thing the counter can't see: curly quotes, em dashes and other characters outside standard GSM-7 text count double towards that 160-character limit, so a message that looks short can still split into two texts. Stick to plain straight quotes and hyphens when editing SMS wording.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Link] — without it, the volunteer has nothing to tap. Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → today's date, [Link] → a sample link). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, at the correct character count. It does not send a real SMS.

> All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link], [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

Message wording lives in three categories: **SMS** (replacement request, manual replacement, taken off the roster, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder), **App** (the matching app notifications), and **Email wording** (roster email intro, arrival note and sign-off; reminder email opening, can't-make-it text and sign-off; swap email). The protections above apply to every text template.



The SMS wording templates, including Taken off the roster SMS — each opens to an editor with its own character counter and required placeholders.

Taken off the roster SMS (and **Taken off the roster (app)** under App) is the message a volunteer gets when you replace them on the Board, save them as declined with the tick box on, or take them off a roster with *Let them know* ticked — but only for dates whose roster had already gone out.

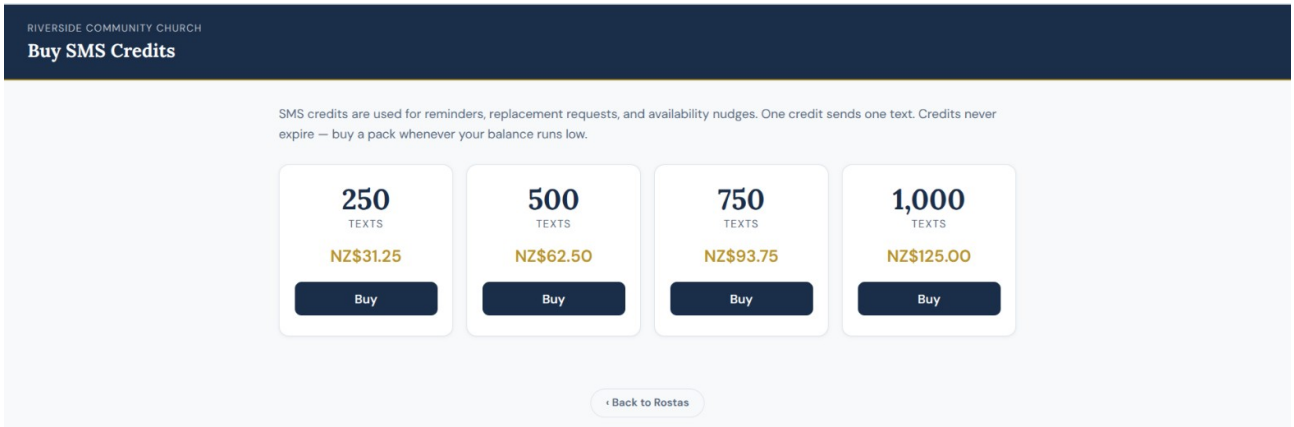
Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

SMS Credits

Sending SMS costs money — unlike email, every text has a real per-message cost from the mobile networks. Rostas covers this with a simple prepaid credit system: **one credit sends one text.** Every text uses them — reminders, replacement requests (automatic, manual and cross-roster), roster-change texts and availability nudges — and they never expire — you top up whenever your balance runs low.

Your first 20 SMS credits are free. Every new Rostas subscription starts with 20 credits so you can try texts straight away. After that, texts use prepaid credits: buy a pack from the Buy SMS Credits page whenever your balance runs low.

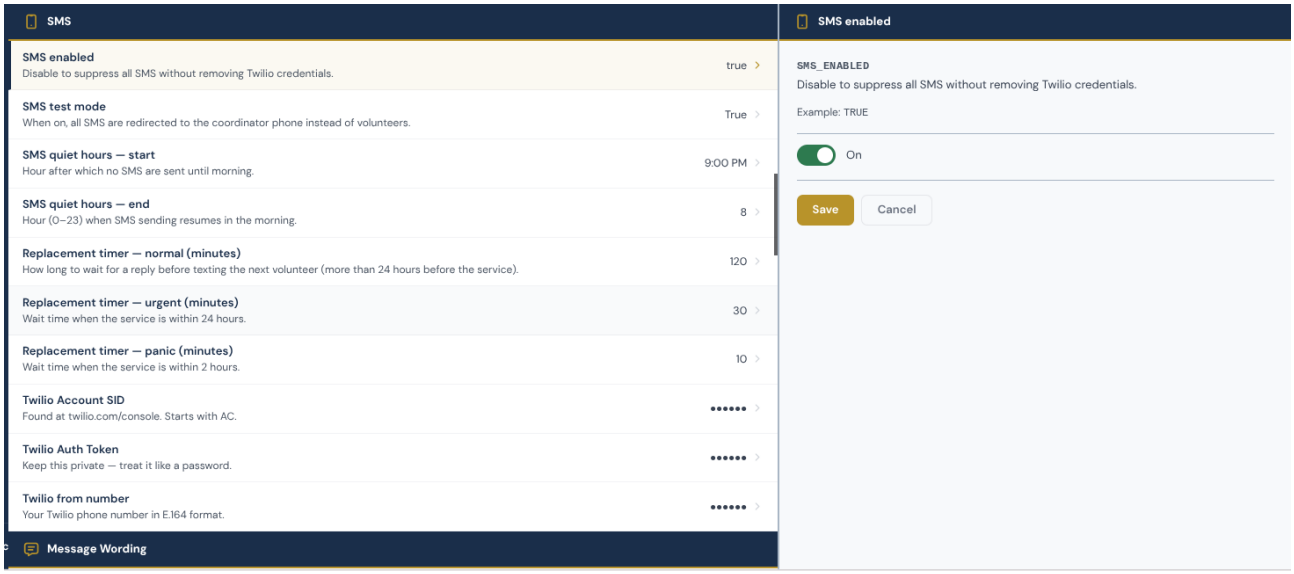


The Buy SMS Credits page — four prepaid packs. The large number is how many texts the pack buys; the price is below it. Credits never expire.

Keeping SMS costs down. Reminders are the biggest driver of SMS use — one text per rostered volunteer before every service. If you'd like to stretch your credits further, email reminders cost nothing, and you can rely on SMS mainly for the time-sensitive replacement chain. Your Rostas contact can help you tune this.

Quick Controls

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.



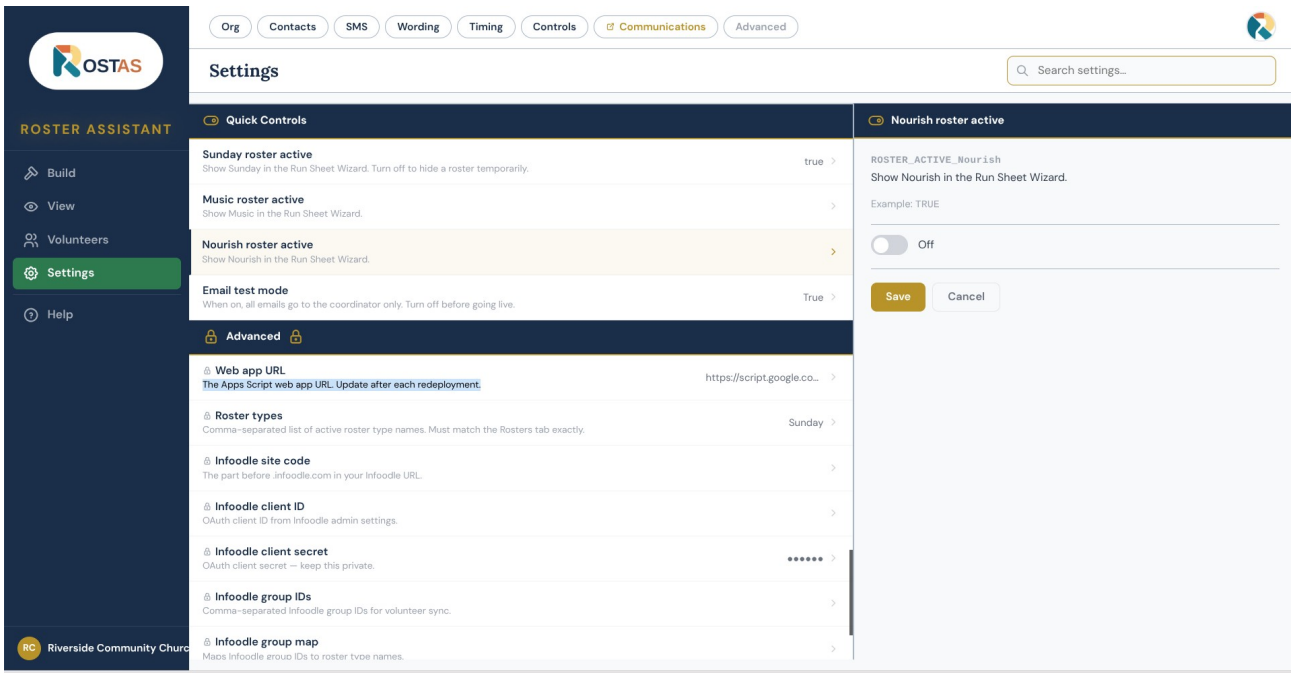
Toggle fields in the right panel — a single switch with immediate visual feedback. The current state is always visible in the left panel list before you even click the row.

> **Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster.**
> While a test mode is on, that channel's messages come to you instead of volunteers: SMS test mode redirects texts, Email test mode redirects emails, and App push test mode redirects app notifications.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting: click the row, read the amber warning in the right panel, then click **Unlock to edit**. The field becomes editable. Save as normal.



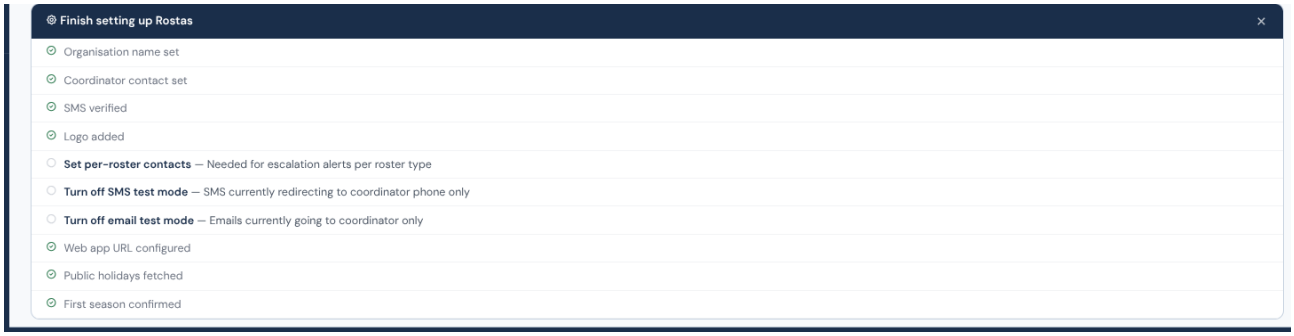
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and each row shows a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

You'll rarely need the Advanced section. Only change the **Web app URL** if Rostas support asks you to — if it's wrong, the links in texts and emails stop working.

> Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention before going live. The checklist covers ten items — click any incomplete item to jump straight to the relevant setting.



The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete by reading the current Config values, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. The card disappears by itself once every item is ticked.

The checklist goes away by itself once every item is ticked. To hide it sooner, click Dismiss; it won't appear again. If you dismiss it with items still incomplete, you can still fix them through the normal settings list — the checklist is a guide, not a gate.

Troubleshooting

Most issues in Rostas fall into a small number of categories. Work through this list before contacting tech support.

Volunteers aren't receiving SMS messages

- Check **Settings → Quick Controls → SMS enabled** is on
- Check **SMS test mode** is off — while it's on, every text goes to the coordinator instead
- Check the volunteer's SMS toggle is On in their detail page
- Check quiet hours — no texts go out during your quiet hours (Settings → Timing & behaviour; 9pm–8am unless you've changed it)
- Check the volunteer's mobile number is in correct international format (+64…)
- Check the System Status communication failures table for error messages on the relevant date

Volunteers aren't receiving emails

- Check **Email test mode** is off in Quick Controls
- Check the volunteer's Email toggle is On in their detail page
- Ask the volunteer to check their spam/junk folder
- Confirm their email address is correct in their volunteer detail page

Roster has unfilled slots after building

- Check that enough volunteers have responded to the availability email
- Check that volunteers have role preferences set — without preferences set, the engine can't assign them to specific roles
- Check frequency caps — volunteers who've reached their frequency cap (once every N weeks) won't be assigned again until it allows
- Consider rebuilding after more availability responses come in
- Use manual replacement on the Board to fill remaining slots

SMS replacement chain isn't progressing

- Check quiet hours — the chain waits during your quiet hours and carries on automatically when they end
- Check **SMS enabled** is on, and that the roster isn't paused (Builds → ⋯)
- Check there are eligible volunteers left on the backup list — if the list is exhausted, Rostas emails that roster's own coordinator if it has one, otherwise your Organisation email (set it in Settings → Organisation)
- Use manual replacement on the Board to assign someone directly

"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time"

This Google message almost always means your browser is signed in to **more than one Google account**. Google can't tell which account should open Rostas, and you may see `u/1/` in the address bar. Rostas itself is fine.

- **Every day:** open Rostas from its icon in your Church profile (see Put Rostas on your desktop). That profile has only the church account in it, so the problem can't happen.
- **Right now, as a one-off:** open the link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac) and paste the address there.
- Deleting `u/1/` from the address doesn't help: Chrome puts it straight back. Signing in to the church account first doesn't help either.

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the System Status communication failures table
- Volunteer links have stopped working (they open an error or a sign-in page)
- You need to change SMS provider or other API credentials
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

> **When contacting tech support**, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot of any error message or the System Status panel is very helpful.

Connectors

Most organisations get their volunteers into Rostas by importing a CSV — it works for everyone and needs nothing more than a spreadsheet. But if your church or organisation already keeps its people in another system, a **connector** can sync them into Rostas automatically, so you don't maintain two lists by hand.

> **Connectors sync identity only.** A connector brings across each person's *name, mobile, and email* — nothing more. Everything about *how* they serve — which rosters they're in, the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with — is set up and lives entirely inside Rostas. Your other system stays the source of truth for contact details; Rostas stays the source of truth for rostering.

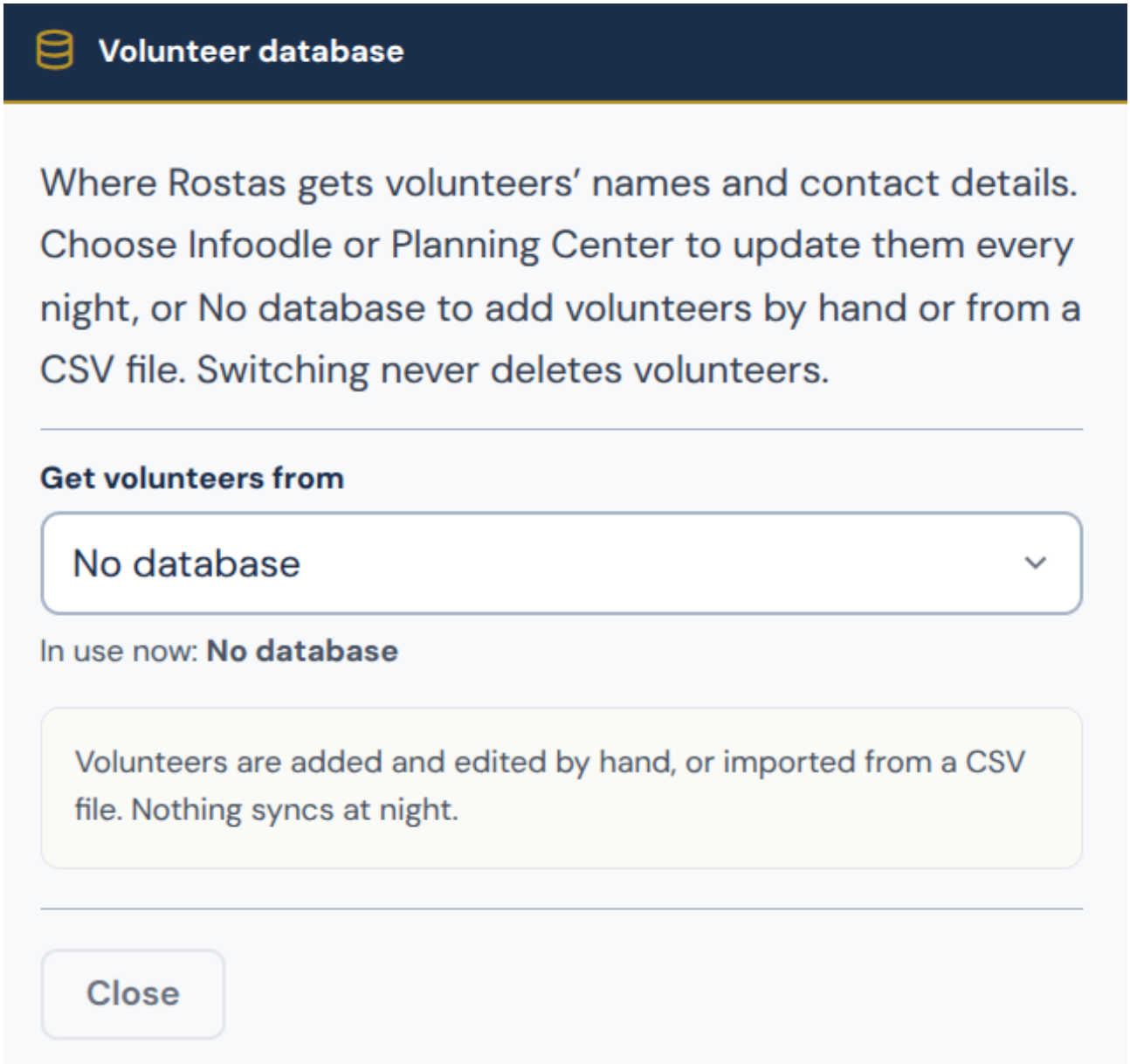
Choosing your volunteer database

Everything to do with connectors is in one place: **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database**. It is the last row in the Quick controls list. Click it and the panel opens on the right.

At the top of the panel, **Get volunteers from** has three choices:

- **No database** — you add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Nothing syncs at night. This is where every new Rostas starts.
- **Infoodle** — see Infoodle below.
- **Planning Center** — see Planning Center below.

Only one database is used at a time. The line under the choice shows what is in use now and when it last synced, for example *In use now: Infoodle · last synced …*.



Settings → Controls → Volunteer database with No database chosen. The line under the choice shows what is in use now.

Switching database

Pick a different database, set it up (the steps are under each one below), then press the button that appears under the panel — **Use Infoodle for volunteers**, **Use**

Planning Center for volunteers, or **Stop syncing volunteers**. Rostas asks you to confirm in a yellow box inside the panel before it changes anything, and tells you if the database you are switching to isn't connected yet.

> **Switching never deletes volunteers.** Everyone already in Rostas stays exactly as they are, with their roles, frequency and history. From the switch onwards, names and contact details are updated from the new database every night and whenever you press **Sync now**.

The sync status at the top of Settings

Across the top of Settings, a small **Volunteers** strip shows whether the connection is healthy and when it last synced, with a **Sync now** button to run a sync straight away. If no database is chosen it reads **Not connected** with a **Set up** button; if Planning Center needs attention it shows **Connect** or **Reconnect**. Each of those simply opens the Volunteer database panel.

Infoodle

Once Infoodle is connected, new and updated contacts flow in on their own — a volunteer added in Infoodle appears in your Profiles list without a re-import, and a changed phone number or email updates itself.

Where to find your Infoodle details

Rostas needs three things to connect: the **address** of your Infoodle site, a **Client ID** and a **Client secret**. You find all three in Infoodle itself — you don't need to contact Rostas or Infoodle support. In many churches the Rostas coordinator and the person who administers Infoodle are the same person; if that's not you, ask that person to follow these steps (or to sit with you while you do).

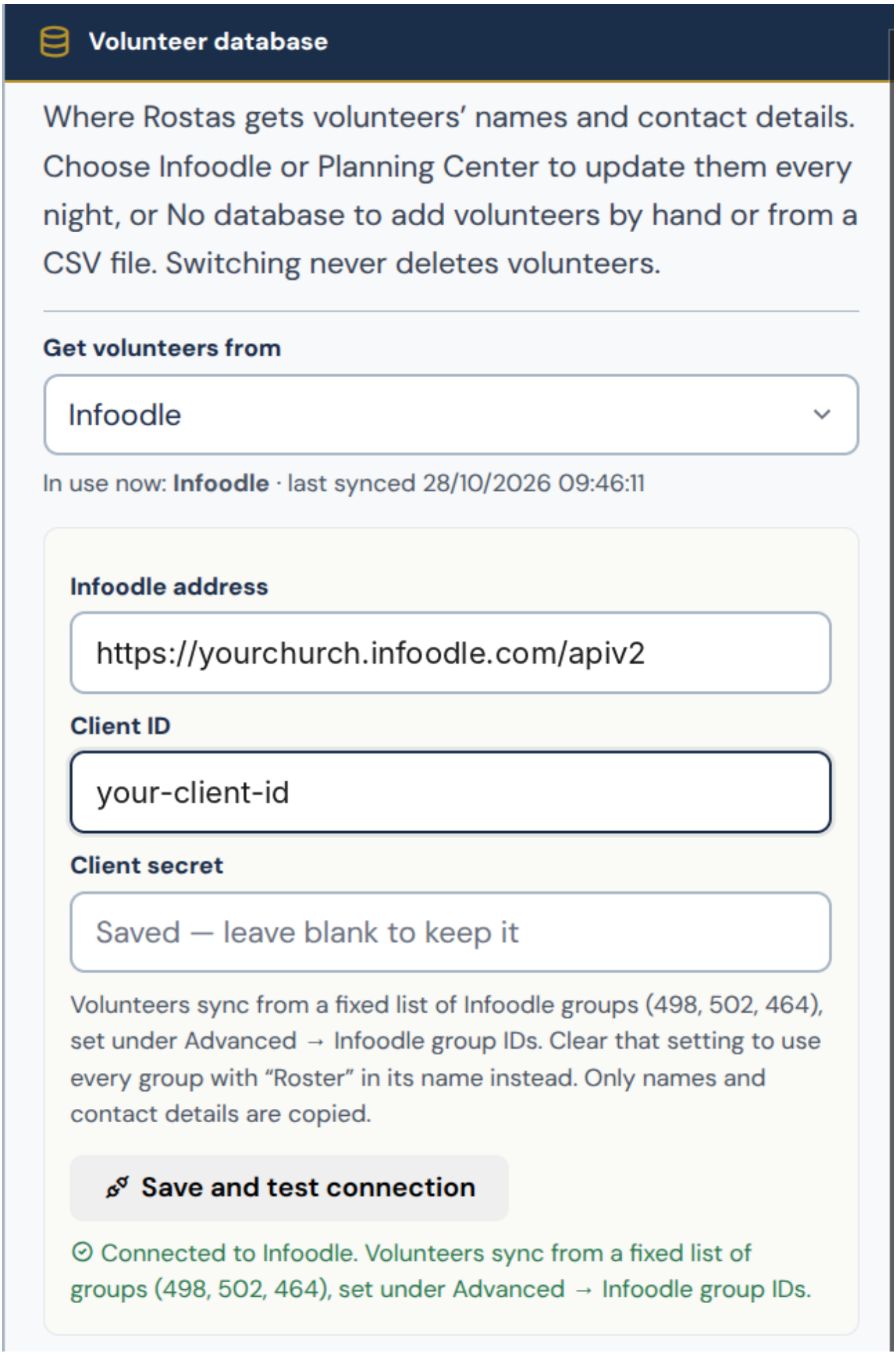
- **Infoodle address** — the web address you use to log in to Infoodle, followed by `/apiv2`. For example, if you log in at `https://yourchurch.infoodle.com`, the address to enter is `https://yourchurch.infoodle.com/apiv2`.
- **Client ID** — the **username you normally log in to Infoodle with**.
- **Client secret** — a code Infoodle creates for your login. To make it:
  Log in to Infoodle with the login you want Rostas to use. On your **Dashboard**, choose **My Account**. (To do this for someone else's login, open that person's own profile, click the settings cog and choose **Settings**.)
  Scroll to **API Credentials** at the bottom of the page and generate your secret.
  Infoodle shows a warning first — read it, then continue. **Copy the secret somewhere safe straight away.** It gives access to your church's Infoodle data, so keep it private and don't email it around. When you're back on the My Account page, the **Client secret** box now holds the number. Select **Authorise** to finish.

> - There is **one secret per Infoodle login**, and Rostas can see only what that login is allowed to see in Infoodle. Use a login that can see the groups your volunteers are in.
> - Consider creating a separate Infoodle login just for Rostas, rather than using one person's own login. That way the connection doesn't break if that person leaves, changes role or changes their password.
> - If the connection ever stops working — for example after the secret is changed in Infoodle — enter the current details in Rostas and press **Save and test connection** again.

Connecting Infoodle

26. Open **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database** and choose **Infoodle**.
27. Fill in **Infoodle address** (it must start with `https://`), **Client ID** and **Client secret**, using the details from Where to find your Infoodle details above.
28. Press **Save and test connection**. Rostas saves the details and signs in to Infoodle to check them. A green message confirms it worked; a red one says what went wrong.
29. Press **Use Infoodle for volunteers** and confirm.

If the test fails, **nothing is saved** — the previous details are put back — so a typo can never break a sync that was already working. Once the secret is saved, the box shows *Saved — leave blank to keep it*; you only retype it to change it.


Volunteer database
Where Rostas gets volunteers' names and contact details. Choose Infoodle or Planning Center to update them every night, or No database to add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Switching never deletes volunteers.
Get volunteers from
Infoodle
In use now: Infoodle · last synced 28/10/2026 09:46:11
Infoodle address
https://yourchurch.infoodle.com/apiv2
Client ID
your-client-id
Client secret
Saved — leave blank to keep it
Volunteers sync from a fixed list of Infoodle groups (498, 502, 464), set under Advanced → Infoodle group IDs. Clear that setting to use every group with "Roster" in its name instead. Only names and contact details are copied.
Save and test connection
Connected to Infoodle. Volunteers sync from a fixed list of groups (498, 502, 464), set under Advanced → Infoodle group IDs.

The Infoodle panel after Save and test connection. The green message confirms Rostas could sign in. The secret box reads “Saved — leave blank to keep it” once a secret has been stored.

Which people are synced

Rostas syncs the people in your Infoodle **groups with “Roster” in the name** — for example “Sunday Roster” or “Music Roster”. To add someone to Rostas, add them to one of those groups in Infoodle. If you press *Save and test connection* and no group has “Roster” in its name yet, Rostas tells you to rename the groups your volunteers belong to, and then press Sync now.

If your church was set up with a fixed list of group numbers (under **Advanced → Infoodle group IDs**), Rostas keeps using exactly that list, and the panel says so. Clear that setting if you would rather use the “Roster” name rule.

When someone is removed in Infoodle, Rostas doesn't delete them out from under you. Instead it flags them with a **"Deleted in Infoodle"** marker in the Profiles list, so you can confirm they should go and remove them here deliberately — protecting you from losing a volunteer's history by accident.

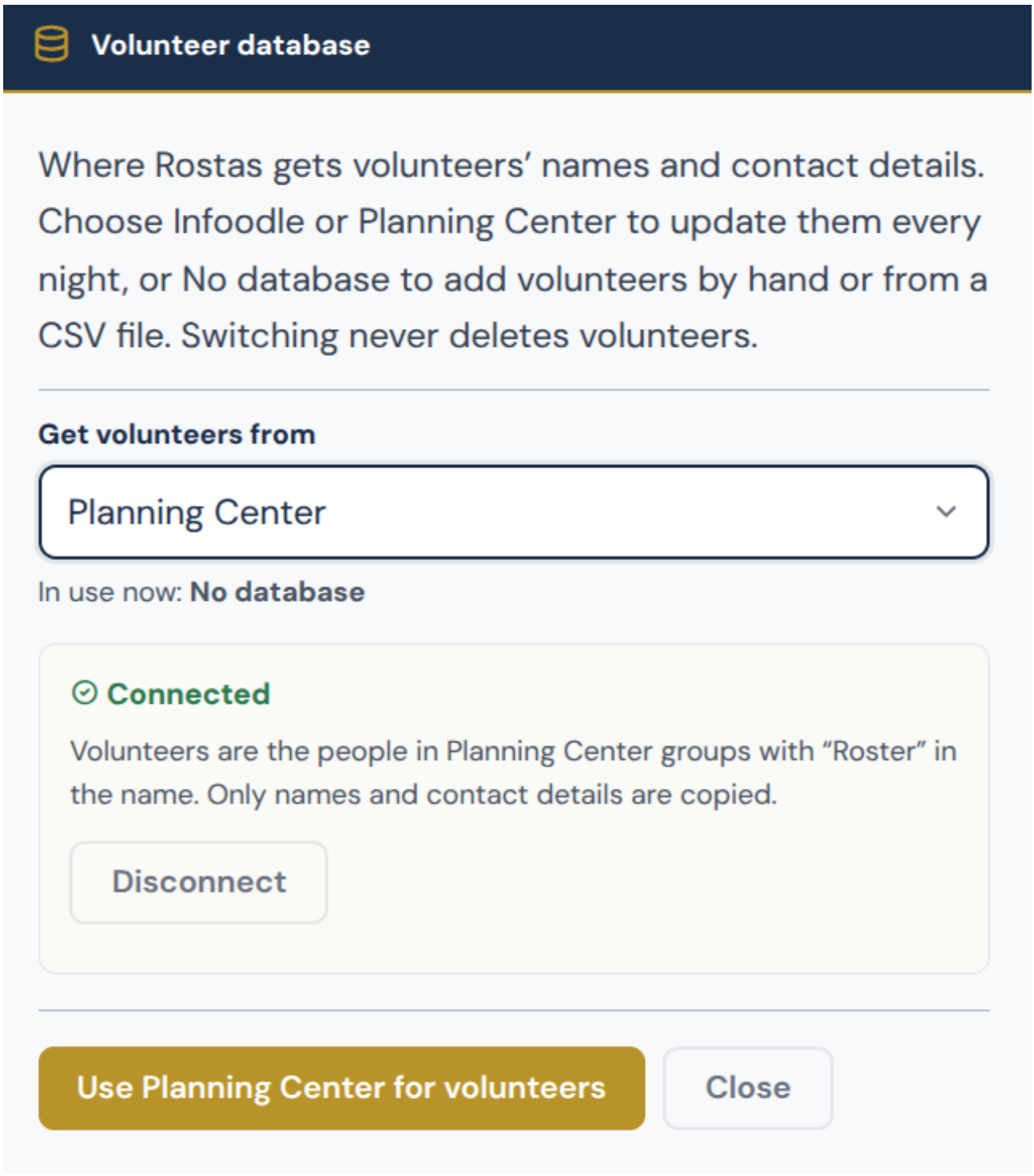
Planning Center

Planning Center connects by signing in to your Planning Center account — there are no codes or keys to copy.

Connecting Planning Center

30. Open **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database** and choose **Planning Center**. The panel shows *Not connected yet*.
31. Press **Connect Planning Center**. The button changes to **Open Planning Center sign-in** — click it. Planning Center opens in a new tab.
32. Sign in to Planning Center and approve the connection, then return to the Rostas tab. The panel says *Waiting for you to sign in…* and changes to **Connected to** your organisation's name as soon as you finish.
33. Press **Use Planning Center for volunteers** and confirm.

Your church needs its Rostas licence key in place before the sign-in will work; if the panel says so, contact support@rostas.app.



The Planning Center panel once connected. Pressing Use Planning Center for volunteers switches over (after a confirmation); Disconnect removes the connection.

Which people are synced

As with Infoodle, Rostas syncs the people in your Planning Center **groups with "Roster" in the name** (archived groups are ignored). Someone who leaves all of those groups is marked inactive in Rostas rather than deleted, so their history is kept.

Reconnecting or disconnecting

If Planning Center stops accepting the connection — for example the sign-in has expired or was revoked — the strip at the top of Settings turns red and reads **Planning Center needs reconnecting**. Press **Reconnect** and sign in again; volunteers aren't affected in the meantime, they just stop updating.

To stop using Planning Center, open the panel and press **Disconnect**. Rostas asks you to confirm, and reminds you that volunteers already in Rostas stay exactly as they are.

Other connectors

Infoodle and Planning Center are the connectors available today. Support for other church and volunteer platforms — such as Elvanto — is planned, so more organisations can sync rather than import over time.

> **Not on the list yet?** CSV import works with every system in the meantime — most spreadsheets and databases can export a CSV. If a connector for your platform would help, let your Rostas contact know; it helps prioritise what's built next.

Rostas Coordinator Guide · September 2026